

₹5 cr drugs seized, interstate nexus busted

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's Crime Branch has busted a major interstate narcotics network operating between Bareilly and the National Capital Region, arresting two men and recovering nearly half a kilogram of high-grade cocaine valued at around ₹5 crore in the illegal market.

The seizure was made after the Inter-State Cell of the Crime Branch tracked the movement of a suspected courier and later followed the supply chain to Uttar Pradesh, police said on Sunday. Investigators believe the syndicate had been pushing premium quality cocaine, commonly referred to in the drug circuit as crank, into Delhi and adjoining NCR cities.

Deputy Commissioner of Police, Crime Branch, Aditya Gautam said the operation had exposed an organised



interstate supply module and further raids are underway to identify other handlers and receivers linked to the network. "This is not an isolated recovery. The interrogation and subsequent arrests point to a wider chain involved in the procurement and delivery of high-quality narcotics. We are now working to trace the remaining members," Gautam said.

Police said the first break-

through came on April 10 when a Crime Branch team, acting on specific intelligence, laid a trap near Gazipur Roundabout in east Delhi. A suspected carrier, identified as 29-year-old Javed Hussain of Bareilly, Uttar Pradesh, was intercepted and searched.

From his possession, officers recovered 456 grams of fine-quality cocaine. The quantity and purity of the

recovered contraband immediately suggested that it was not meant for local peddling but for a higher-value urban distribution circuit. An FIR under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act was registered at the Crime Branch police station, and Javed was taken into custody for sustained interrogation.

According to investigators, Javed initially gave evasive replies but eventually disclosed that the consignment had been sourced from one Soib Khan, a resident of Bareilly. Based on this disclosure, police obtained his custody remand and began preparing for a follow-up raid outside Delhi.

On April 22, a Crime Branch team, with the assistance of local police in Uttar Pradesh, reached Bareilly and conducted a raid at the identified location. There, the alleged supplier, 25-year-old Soib Khan, was apprehended from his residence and formally

arrested in the same case.

Police said the arrest of Soib was crucial because it established that the Delhi courier was not acting independently but was part of a structured interstate trafficking line. Crime Branch officers suspect the syndicate had been using low-profile carriers and labour-class workers to move expensive narcotics quietly into Delhi, where the drug could be sold at several times the procurement value.

Investigators are now examining who financed the consignments, who the intended buyers in Delhi-NCR were, and whether similar deliveries had already taken place in recent months. Police sources said the recovered cocaine was of superior grade, making it attractive to high-paying users and elite party circuits rather than street-level consumers. This has raised the possibility that the racket was supplying to a niche but lucrative clientele.

FTII cancels exam at Delhi centre after students manhandle staff

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Film and Television Institute of India (FTII) administration on Sunday cancelled its entrance examination at a centre in Delhi after a few students allegedly entered the strong room and manhandled the staff, official sources said.

Exams at all other centres proceeded peacefully, they said. The matter will be investigated to identify the exact cause and chronology of events, the sources said on the cancellation.

During the first shift of the FTII's entrance examination at the said centre in Delhi, a delay in paper distribution in one building led to a law and order issue.

A few candidates allegedly entered the strong room and manhandled the staff, they said.

In an emergency meeting



with the examination agency and the centre in charge, the FTII administration decided to cancel the examination for candidates in that specific building, they said.

Police were on site, and the FTII observer was also present.

During the second shift,

the FTII observer noted the concerns raised by a few candidates and a decision was taken to cancel the second shift exam as well for the specific building, the sources said.

A decision on the date of re-examination will be communicated to the candidates, a source said.

Delhi-UP gun network busted, key supplier from Meerut held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has busted an illegal arms supply chain operating between east Delhi and western Uttar Pradesh with the arrest of three men, including an alleged key weapon supplier from Meerut, after a surveillance-led operation prevented what investigators suspect could have been a planned violent crime.

Police said the crackdown led to the seizure of five firearms, 16 live cartridges, three knives and a car used by the accused. The arrests were made in a two-stage operation beginning in east Delhi and ending with follow-up raids in Dadri and Meerut.

Investigators said the operation was launched after police teams picked up intelligence inputs through technical surveillance and monitoring of suspicious social media activity about the movement of armed men in a vehicle near the CRPF red light on the stretch connecting New Kondli Market to Khoda.

Acting on the inputs, police laid a trap and intercepted the car. Two men



travelling in the vehicle, identified as Babu alias Mardari and Raj Kumar, both residents of Ghazipur in east Delhi, were taken into custody. During the search, officers recovered one illegal pistol loaded with two live cartridges from Babu, while Raj Kumar was found carrying a button-operated knife.

Police said the immediate recovery suggested that the duo was moving armed through the city with a possible criminal intent, prompting investigators to widen the probe into the source of the weapons.

A case was registered, and sustained interrogation of the two accused led police to a larger illegal firearms channel supplying weapons from western Uttar Pradesh into Delhi. During questioning, the two men allegedly

disclosed that the weapons had been procured through Parvinder, a resident of Meerut who had been supplying firearms to criminal contacts in Delhi and adjoining areas. This shifted the investigation beyond the initial arrests.

Police teams then conducted raids at a location in Dadri in Uttar Pradesh based on the disclosures. During the search, officers recovered one automatic pistol, two country-made pistols and 14 live cartridges, indicating that the accused had access to a stocked supply line rather than isolated weapons. With Parvinder identified as the key supplier, police mounted another operation and tracked him down in Meerut, where he was arrested.

Officials said that after

his detention, Parvinder led police to an under-construction plot in Meerut where two more country-made pistols had been concealed. These were also seized. By the end of the operation, investigators had recovered two automatic pistols, three country-made pistols, 16 live rounds, three knives and the car allegedly being used by the accused for movement.

Police suspect the racket was part of a wider illegal arms circulation route that ferried weapons from western Uttar Pradesh into Delhi's eastern fringe, a corridor long considered vulnerable because of easy interstate mobility.

Investigators are now trying to establish how many weapons had already been supplied through this network, who the intended buyers were, and whether the firearms were being routed to organised criminals, extortion gangs or local shooters.

The role of Babu and Raj Kumar is also being examined to determine whether they were carriers, purchasers or active users planning an offence in Delhi.

Mother kills infant daughter over poverty in Faridabad

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Faridabad

A woman allegedly killed her 18-month-old child — her sixth daughter — by throwing her into a drain in Faridabad, claiming she committed the crime as she was unable to take care of her family due to poverty, according to police.

The incident occurred near Dheeraj Nagar on April 23 when the girl's body was found stuck in an iron mesh along a drain by two school children, the police said on Sunday, adding the body was retrieved and sent for a postmortem.

A Crime Branch team, which was probing the case, found CCTV footage showing the girl's mother carrying her in her arms in the area. She then returned alone. The police took the woman into custody, and during questioning, she confessed to throwing the girl into the drain, they said. The infant died of drowning.

The accused was identified as Neelam, a native of



Madhubani in Bihar.

She lived in Faridabad with her husband Sanjay, who works in a private firm, the police said.

A senior investigating officer said that during interrogation, the woman said that the deceased was the youngest of her six daughters and that she was driven to commit the crime due to poverty.

"She revealed that her family's financial situation was extremely poor, and with six daughters, she was unable to raise them properly," the officer said.

Police spokesperson Yashpal said they are investigating the matter, and the entire picture will be clear soon.



Delhi Lieutenant Governor on Saturday called on veteran leader and author Dr Karan Singh. LG said it was inspiring to hear his insights on history, along with his reflections on Delhi — its journey, the challenges it continues to face, and the opportunities that lie ahead

Devender Yadav blames AAP and BJP for hanging overhead wires

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav on Sunday said that hanging overhead wires, including those of electricity, cable and internet wires, have been posing danger to the lives and buildings of people across the Capital for the past many years due to the carelessness and inaction of successive Delhi Governments of Aam Aadmi Party and now the BJP.

Electricity, cable, and internet lines hanging precariously have posed a grave risk to people and buildings for years due to official negligence. He pointed to a recent inferno in East Delhi's Laxmi Nagar, where heat-wave sparks from overhead wires triggered a transformer blaze, gutting 14 flats in a Ramesh Park building.

Yadav said that residents in many colonies in Delhi, have been complaining that hanging wires have been posing threats to the lives of motorists, pedestrians, residents in flats and even housing societies as most of the wires discarded by internet providers, cable operators and even the power distribution companies, including live wires, hang precariously over the skyline which create sparks during heat-waves, causing avoidable accidents which could be averted only if the Government agencies took steps to remove them.

He said that it was sheer



luck that no lives were lost in the Ramesh Park power transformer inferno, as the residents managed to rush out, but their flats got gutted, causing losses to the tune of several crores. He demanded appropriate financial compensation for those whose flats were gutted, causing losses to the tune of crores of rupees.

Yadav said that it was strange that the Delhi Government "tightened" the Heat Wave Action Plan to Boost Effectiveness only when the Capital experienced unbearable heat wave conditions.

He said that the power demand is rising to over 9,000 MW this season, a figure significantly higher than last year's maximum demand of 8,442 MW. The Government should ensure that there are no power outages during this scorching summer.

Double hand transplant gives mother new lease of life

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A complex procedure and an act of generosity have enabled a young mother of two to undergo a bilateral hand transplant at a Delhi hospital after a brain-dead donor's family consented to donating the upper limbs, officials said.

The woman had lost both her hands in a chaff-cutting machine accident, they said. According to a statement issued by the Sir Ganga Ram Hospital, this is the second such bilateral hand transplant performed at the facility.

The transplant offered the patient, who had been completely dependent on others for daily activities since the accident, a chance to regain functional inde-



pendence after a suitable donor was identified.

The 12-hour surgery involved transplantation of both donor upper limbs — the right one at the supracondylar level (just above the elbow) and the left one at the

distal forearm level (near the wrist) — with surgeons carrying out precise microsurgical steps including bone fixation, tendon repair, vascular anastomosis and nerve coaptation to restore circulation and movement.

"This successful bilateral hand transplant is a matter of immense pride for the department and the hospital. Such procedures represent the pinnacle of reconstructive microsurgery and offer a second life to patients who have lost

both limbs and independence," Dr Mahesh Mangal, chairman, Department of Plastic, Cosmetic and Hand Microsurgery, said.

"Bilateral hand transplantation is not merely a surgery but a carefully orchestrated sequence where every minute is critical for graft survival. Our goal was not just to restore anatomy, but to help the patient regain dignity and functionality," Dr Anubhav Gupta, senior consultant, Department of Plastic, Cosmetic and Hand Microsurgery, said.

Highlighting the key steps, Dr Bheem Nanda, senior consultant, Department of Plastic, Cosmetic and Hand Microsurgery, said maintaining tissue viability during ischemia and ensuring stable skeletal fixation before vascu-

lar reperfusion were crucial.

Dr Nikhil Jhunjhunwala, consultant, Department of Plastic, Cosmetic and Hand Microsurgery, said postoperative care, including immunosuppression, rehabilitation and physiotherapy, would play a critical role in long-term functional recovery.

The hospital said the transplant was carried out by a multidisciplinary team involving specialists from plastic surgery, orthopaedics, anaesthesia, nephrology, neurology, psychiatry, pathology, genetics, physiotherapy, intensive care and hospital administration.

It also expressed gratitude to the donor and the donor's family for their decision, stating that their act has given the patient renewed hope and a new lease of life.

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Mrs. Pinki Bedi is the Owner of Entire ground floor being part of property bearing no. B-25, area measuring 128.05 sq. yds, situated in the layout plan of the Dera Ismail Khan Co-operative Housing Building Society Limited known as Derawal Nagar, Delhi-110009 through Sale Deed Dated 13.06.2011 as doc. no. 7991 executed by Mr. Satyendra Kumar Gupta in favour of Mrs. Pinki Bedi in respect of said floor.

Mrs. Pinki Bedi intends to transfer the ownership of above said floor by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Manoj Kumar Garg. Subsequently, Mr. Manoj Kumar Garg is in the process of mortgaging the said floor with ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 07 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 07-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 07-days period by contacting Law Veritas North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-4/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201302. Landline: +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

Public Notice

This is for the information of the general public at large that my clients MAHESH CHAND GARG S/o SHRI RADHA KRISHNA and MANJU GARG wife of SHRI MAHESH CHAND GARG, resident of L-140/394, L-BLOCK, GALI No.11, MAHIPAL PUR, EXTENSION, NEW DELHI have severed their relations and have disowned & debarred their son, ANURAG GARG, from all their movable & immovable properties and assets due to their absolute irresponsible misbehavior, disobedience and hostile attitude, cruel acts and activities towards harmony and dignity of my clients. My clients shall not be held responsible for any of the wrong doings, illegal acts and activities of them in past, present, future or deeds from the date of publication of this Bonafide notice. Anybody dealing with them shall do so at his/her own risks and consequences.

Prem Prakash (Advocate)
Legalpract Competent Lawyers LLP
Dwarka, New Delhi-110075

Public Notice

The general public is hereby informed that my client Sh. Gopal Krishan Gupta S/o Jai Bhagwan Dass Gupta R/o D-642 Saraswati Vihar Pitampura Delhi 110034 have severed all the relations with his son, namely Ashu Gupta, daughter-in-law Megha Gupta, due to their bad behaviour, and also has disowned and debarred his son, daughter-in-law from all the movable and immovable properties. My client has no connection and relation whatsoever with Ashu Gupta, Megha Gupta. Anybody dealing with Ashu Gupta and Megha Gupta will do so at his/her own risk and responsibility, and my client will not be responsible for any act, deed or dealing done by Ashu Gupta and Megha Gupta.

Sarthak Jain (Advocate) Ch. No. 105,
Lawyers Chamber Block III, Delhi
High Court New Delhi.

Public Notice

Be it hereby notified for the information of the general public that Sh. Rajesh Khanna, S/o Late Sh. Baldev Raj Khanna, is the absolute owner and in lawful physical possession of the built-up property bearing Old No. X/1501 and New No. X/3927, admeasuring 100 Sq. Yards (i.e., 83.61 Sq. Meters), constructed on Plot No. 1, out of lotted No. 2, situated at 430/2/14, LT. No. 15, "Shanti Mohalla", Gandhi Nagar, within the revenue estate of Village Ghondli, Tilaga Shahdara, Delhi - 110031. It is hereby further informed that the original title documents pertaining to the above-mentioned property have been lost/misplaced by the said owner and are not traceable despite best efforts. The particulars of the said documents are as under:

1. Relinquishment Deed dated 03.10.2019, duly registered in the office of Sub-Registrar, SR No. IV-B, Vivik Vihar, Delhi, vide Registration No. 7259, in Book No. I, Volume No. 2,036, Pages 86 to 91, registered on 11.10.2019, executed by all the legal heirs of Late Sh. Baldev Raj Khanna.

2. Sale Deed dated 15.05.1963, duly registered in the office of Sub-Registrar-1, Delhi, vide Registration No. 5,624, in Book No. I, Volume No. 944, Pages 168 to 169, registered on 15.05.1963.

3. Sale Deed dated 31.01.1972, duly registered in the office of Sub-Registrar, SD No. 1, Delhi, vide Registration No. 1,019, in Book No. I, Volume No. 514, Pages 94 to 95, registered on 31.01.1972.

In this regard, a report regarding the loss of the aforesaid original documents has already been filed with the office of the Sub-Registrar, Delhi, on 20/06/2024 dated 31.08.2024. If any person has found or comes into possession of the aforesaid Report, he/she is requested to kindly return the same to the undersigned or my client Sh. Rajesh Khanna S/o Late Sh. Baldev Raj Khanna R/o H. No. 45, Gagan Vihar Extn., Delhi - 110051. Further, any person dealing, transacting, creating any third-party interest, or claiming any right, title or interest in respect of the aforesaid property on the basis of the lost documents or otherwise shall do so entirely at his/her own risk, cost, and consequences, and my client shall not be responsible or liable for the same in any manner whatsoever.

KHAYATI JAIN Advocate, B-732, New Ashok Nagar, Delhi-110006, Mob: 97694992, e-mail: khayatijainadv@gmail.com

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING ATTENDANCE OF DEFENDANT (Order 5, Rule 20 of the Code of Civil Procedure) IN THE COURT OF: SH. PAWAN KUMAR MATTO, DISTRICT JUDGE (COMMERCIAL COURT-04), AT... ROOM NO. 304, SHAHDARA DISTRICT KARKARDOOMA COURT, DELHI.

ALSO AT: VINOD KUMAR PROP. OF M/S V'S TRADERSPlaintiff Against NEWAGE SCAFFOLDS PVT LTDDefendant

NEWAGE SCAFFOLDS PVT LTD. 1/7757, EAST GORAKH PARK, BABAR PUR ROAD, GALI NO. 1A, SHAHDARA DELHI - 110032

ALSO AT: 13/C-18, LIND FLOOR, VASUNDHARA HATT COMPLEX, SECTOR-13, VASUNDHARA, GHAZIABAD - 201012

WHEREAS you are intentionally evading service of summons it is hereby notified that if you shall not defend the case on the 10.07.2026 the day fixed for the final disposal, it will be heard and determined ex-parte. You are hereby summoned to file a written statement within 30 days of the service of the present summons and in case you fail to file the written statement within the said period of 30 days, you shall also be liable to file the written statement on the Court, for reasons to be recorded in writing and on payment of such costs as the Court deems fit, but which shall be at or later than 120 days from the date of service of summons. On expiry of one hundred and twenty days from the date of service of summons, you shall forfeit the right to file the written statement and the Court shall not allow the written statement to be taken on record.

Given under my hand and the seal of the Court, this 20.04.2026 District Judge (Commercial Court)-04 Shahdara District Karkardooma Courts Delhi

Public Notice

Be it known to all concerned and informing all that, Mr. Saddam Hussain is intending to purchase the said property from Mr. Shamshad Ali (hereinafter referred as the "Seller"). And He is approaching My client (Vastha Housing Finance Corporation Limited-Branh Faridabad) for loan Facility. In this connection, seller has become owner of the said property vide Regd. Sale Deed dated 28.08.2025, Doc No. 4756 executed by Mrs. Samina alias Samina Khan Here Mr. Saddam Hussain has informed that Original Sale Deed dated 26.10.2012 registered as Doc No. 13949 forming part of chain documents, and hereinafter called the "said document" has been lost/misplaced and is not traceable. A FIR to this effect has also been lodged with Crime Branch, Delhi vide LR No. 3329050/2025 dated 06/11/2025. If the aforesaid original document (the said document) or any one of them is found or has been found by any person, the same may be returned and delivered to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below. Further, if any person, body, institution is having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property, he/they may raise his/their objections, in writing, with documentary evidence, by Registered Ad Post to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 days of publication of this notice. No objection shall be acceptable. General Public may also take note that any deal or transaction done by anybody on the basis of the said documents or any of the said documents shall be illegal and not binding on our clients. The person who so do so shall be liable to be prosecuted under the law.

Despal Malik, (Advocate)-Plot no 804, first floor, Address-Shop-2 Kataria complex, Dayanand colony Gurgaon

BSES Yamuna Power Limited, Delhi ... A joint venture with Govt. of NCT of Delhi

NOTICE INVITING TENDER Date: 27.04.2026

E-tender is invited under the Two-Bid System (Unpriced & Priced) for the following works:

NIT No.	Brief Description	EMD Value (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & time of opening
CMC/BY/26-27/ R/SP/MVK/5	Turnkey project for Conversion of Overhead Electrical Network into Underground along with Multi Utility Duct (MUD) System at Chandni Chowk (2 Location i.e. Esplanade Road & More Sarai Road), Delhi	₹25 Lakh	04.05.2026 14:00 HRS	04.05.2026 15:00 HRS

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹1,180/- For details with respect to Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submitment of tender documents, corrigendum etc, please visit our website www.bsedelhi.com --> BSES YAMUNA POWER LTD -->Tender-->Open Tenders.

Regd.OFF: BSES Yamuna Power Ltd, Shakti Kiran Building, Karkardooma, Delhi-110032 | CIN: U40109DL2004PLC111525 Website: www.bsedelhi.com TEL: 011-41247111

EOI for Business Associates

Uttarakhand Seeds and TDC Limited invites Expression of Interest (E.O.I.) from Indian Citizens/Partnership Firms/ Seed Production Companies/ Private Organizations/ Co-operatives/Government Organizations/ Start-Ups or Any multinational company which is registered in India for empanelment as "Business Associate" in various states of India for supply of different category of seeds of various crops/varieties as per requirement of U.K.S. & T.D.C. Ltd. The Expression of Interest can be accessed/participated on the website www.uktenders.gov.in. The last date for the submission of EOI is on 17.05.2026 by 5:00 PM. Details of the Expression of Interest are also available on the website of the corporation.

Managing Director

UTTARAKHAND SEEDS AND TARAI DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LTD. PANTNAGAR, P.O. HALDI, DISTT. UDHAM SINGH NAGAR Website: www.pantnagarseeds.com, www.ukstdc.com, E-mail: tdc@uaseedsandtdc.com

EOI for Business Associates

Uttarakhand Seeds and TDC Limited invites Expression of Interest (E.O.I.) from Indian Citizens/Partnership Firms/ Seed Production Companies/ Private Organizations/ Co-operatives/Government Organizations/ Start-Ups or Any multinational company which is registered in India for empanelment as "Business Associate" in various states of India for supply of different category of seeds of various crops/varieties as per requirement of U.K.S. & T.D.C. Ltd. The Expression of Interest can be accessed/participated on the website www.uktenders.gov.in. The last date for the submission of EOI is on 17.05.2026 by 5:00 PM. Details of the Expression of Interest are also available on the website of the corporation.

Managing Director



Blistering heatwave: Delhi-NCR temperature spike to 45°C

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi-NCR continues to reel under intense heatwave conditions as of April 26 afternoon, with maximum temperatures soaring between 41 degrees Celsius and 45 degrees Celsius across the region. Residents are experiencing one of the harshest spells of summer so far, with hot winds, dry conditions, and very high daytime temperatures.

Delhi recorded a maximum temperature of 42.1 degrees Celsius on Sunday, 3.1 degrees above the seasonal average. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) said maximum temperatures between 42 and 44 degrees Celsius were recorded across the city, but heatwave conditions were not declared as the readings remained close to the prevailing normal levels. However, there is some relief in sight. According to the latest weather updates, the heatwave in Delhi is expected to ease from April 28 onwards, bringing a noticeable drop in temperatures.

"The normal temperature is updated every five days to reflect seasonal changes, and



for Safdarjung it has increased to 39.0 degrees Celsius for April 26-30 from 37.7 degrees Celsius during April 21-25, which reduces the gap needed to classify a heatwave," the IMD said.

The minimum temperature was recorded at 26.2 degrees Celsius, 2.4 notches above normal, at the Safdarjung observatory, the city's primary weather station. Delhi has been witnessing continuous heatwave conditions for the

past three days, with temperatures significantly above normal levels. The weather department notes that maximum temperatures are currently markedly above normal by 5°C or more, while minimum temperatures are also higher than usual, ranging between 25°C to 27°C.

Among other monitoring stations, Palam recorded a maximum temperature of 41.8 degrees Celsius and a minimum of 27.4 degrees

Celsius, while Lodhi Road registered 42.2 degrees Celsius and 24.6 degrees Celsius, respectively. Ridge recorded the highest maximum temperature at 43.5 degrees Celsius, with a minimum of 26.5 degrees Celsius, while Ayanagar logged 43.1 degrees Celsius and 27.1 degrees Celsius, respectively. The weather department has issued a yellow alert for heatwave-like conditions in the city for Monday, with the maximum

and minimum temperatures expected to reach around 44 degrees Celsius and 27 degrees Celsius, respectively. Relative humidity was recorded at 23 per cent at 5.30 pm.

Hot westerly winds blowing at speeds up to 18 kmph, gusting to 30-40 kmph, have further intensified the discomfort. These dry winds are a key reason behind the persistence of heatwave conditions across Delhi, Noida, Gurugram, Ghaziabad, and surrounding areas.

IMD said a Western Disturbance is currently active in the upper atmosphere (around 5.8 km altitude). This system is known to bring changes in wind patterns and can lead to cloud formation, light rain, or thunderstorms, which help reduce temperatures. A shift from hot, dry westerly winds to relatively cooler easterly winds at lower levels (up to 1.5 km altitude) is expected. This change will play a major role in lowering daytime temperatures.

The air quality was recorded in the 'poor' category at 4 pm, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 222, according to the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) data.

DELHI GEARS UP FOR SUMMER WITH ENHANCED ACTION PLAN

New Delhi: As Delhi stares at another severe summer, the city Government has ordered stricter and more scientific enforcement of its heatwave action plan, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta directing officials to focus on identified thermal hotspots, protect school-children and labourers, and ensure uninterrupted electricity as demand is expected to exceed 9,000 MW.

The fresh instructions were issued after a detailed review of heat preparedness, as temperatures continue to rise sharply across the Capital. Officials have been told to move beyond routine advisories and ensure visible field-level action in areas most vulnerable to extreme heat.

Under the revised strategy, the government has identified several high-risk thermal pockets through satellite mapping and scientific assessment. Among the most heat-stressed locations are Ayanagar, which has earlier recorded 45.5 degrees Celsius, Najafgarh, Safdarjung, Wazirpur, Jahangirpuri, Khayala, Shastri Park, Vishwas Nagar, Harkesh Nagar, Hari Nagar, and Delhi Gate.

Densely populated outer settlements such as Sawda, Mubarakpur Dabas, Bhalswa, Nand Nagri, Gokulpuri, and Bakkarwala have also been marked as zones facing severe heat island impact. Officials said these locations will receive additional water tankers, higher ORS stocks at health centres, and deployment of quick response teams.

Chief Minister said this year's plan has been made more robust with a scientific



approach and stronger on-ground monitoring. She said vulnerable groups will receive special protection, and departments have been instructed to respond quickly to all heat-related emergencies.

One of the major areas of concern is the safety of school children. The Government has directed that if heat conditions worsen, children may be given ORS solution before leaving school to prevent dehydration during travel. Schools have been asked to remain alert and coordinate with local authorities if emergency intervention is needed.

Construction workers and outdoor labourers have also been brought under a stricter safety net. During severe heatwave conditions, outdoor work may be stopped between noon and 3 pm. Employers will be required to provide drinking water, caps, cloth head covers, ice packs, and first-aid support at worksites.

Delhi Assembly special session on April 28 over women's quota

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A special session of the Delhi Assembly will be held on April 28 to discuss the women's reservation issue after related bills were defeated in the Lok Sabha by the Opposition.

The BJP has accused the Opposition of betraying women, and several party-ruled states have called similar special assembly sessions to discuss the issue.

A Delhi Assembly secretariat statement said that the Fifth Session of the Eighth Legislative Assembly is scheduled to commence on Tuesday at 11 AM in the Assembly Hall.



In a related development, Delhi Assembly speaker Vijender Gupta also shared that the Lieutenant Governor has prorogued the Fourth Session of the Eighth

Legislative Assembly with immediate effect.

This formal order brings an official end to the prolonged Sessions that had been ongoing, allowing for a struc-

tured transition into the new session. Officials said that the session was likely to be one-day-long to take up the women's quota bill discussion, but it could be extended further if required.

"After getting the approval of the LG, the notification has been issued in this regard to summon the Fifth Session of the Eighth Legislative Assembly," the Delhi Assembly secretariat said in a statement. In light of recent bomb threats, the Secretariat has significantly bolstered security protocols across the premises.

Tight security measures and a comprehensive safety net have been established at the Old Secretariat to safe-

guard the members and staff during the session. The Constitution Amendment Bill to implement 33 per cent reservation for women in legislatures in 2029 and increase the number of seats of the Lok Sabha was defeated in the Lower House earlier this month.

The Congress and other opposition parties, which voted against the bill, alleged that the Government's real agenda was to carry out delimitation before the caste census.

While 298 members voted in support of the Bill, 230 MPs voted against it. Out of 528 members who voted, the Bill required 352 votes for a two-thirds majority.

Sanjay Jamuar appointed as first CEO of Delhi Metro International Limited

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Sanjay Jamuar has been appointed as the first Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Delhi Metro International Limited (DMIL), which has been set up by DMRC with the support of the Government to take up Metro projects as well as Operation and Maintenance (O&M) assignments in India outside Delhi and abroad.

DMIL has the mandate to offer advisory services to other authorities and lenders to help develop, improve and prepare long-term plans for metro and transit



systems. DMIL will leverage the experience and expertise of DMRC, which has directly or indirectly helped many cities in India to build their own metro systems. Jamuar is an ex-IRTS

officer with wide experience across the Indian railways, DMRC, and internationally in the UK, USA, France, the Middle East and Europe. He holds a post-graduate diploma in strategic leadership from Warwick Business School, UK, and has done research work at Leeds University in Transport Economics.

Incidentally, when he joined DMRC in 1998, he was the first O&M employee. Therefore, coming back to DMRC is like a homecoming for him. DMRC is already involved as a consultant with the Dhaka Metro project in Bangladesh.

11,800 violators booked during 3-hour mega drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In one of its sharpest recent enforcement actions, Delhi Traffic Police prosecuted 11,800 motorists in just three hours during a city-wide special drive against improper parking and wrong-side driving, two of the most common causes of congestion and road accidents in the Capital.

The intensive crackdown was carried out simultaneously across all traffic ranges and districts on Saturday, with teams deployed on arterial roads, market stretches, service lanes, and accident-prone corridors. The operation focused on clearing obstructive parking and penalising motorists found driving against the designated flow of traffic.

Additional Commissioner of Police, Traffic, Vijayanta Goyal Arya said the drive was part of Delhi Traffic



Police's sustained effort to improve road discipline and reduce daily violations that repeatedly trigger traffic snarls and safety risks. "Improper parking and wrong-side driving are among the most persistent violations on Delhi roads. Both directly affect smooth movement and put lives at risk. The enforcement will continue with the same intensity," Arya said. Out of

the total prosecutions, more than 8,500 were issued for improper or obstructive parking. Officials said vehicles parked in no-parking zones, near road intersections, on footpaths, outside markets, and along narrow service lanes were specifically targeted because they routinely choke traffic movement during peak hours.

Several vehicles were also towed away from critical

stretches where illegal parking had narrowed carriageways and created bottlenecks. Traffic personnel were instructed to focus on spots with a history of daily congestion complaints.

The second major focus was wrong-side driving, for which over 3,500 motorists were prosecuted during the same three-hour window. Dedicated enforcement teams were stationed at roads known for frequent violations, especially stretches where commuters take dangerous shortcuts by entering the opposite carriageway.

Officials indicated that similar surprise drives will continue in the coming weeks, particularly in areas with high violation density. The message from the latest crackdown was unambiguous: everyday traffic indiscipline, often dismissed as minor by motorists, is now under sharper police scrutiny.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police on Sunday widened its ongoing anti-drug outreach campaign by taking its message out of classrooms and police stations to crowded public spaces, organising flash mob performances at key city landmarks and a cycle rally involving around 400 participants to push its "Nasha Not Cool" message among the youth.

The third day of the week-long campaign saw Delhi Police shift focus to direct public engagement, targeting weekend crowds at some of the Capital's busiest locations. Anti-drug flash mobs were organised at Central Park in Connaught Place, Kartavya Path, and Select Citywalk Mall in Saket, besides similar performances in North-West, West and Dwarka districts.

Through music-led street



performances and public interaction, police teams attempted to communicate the dangers of narcotics use and promote healthier lifestyle choices, especially among young people who formed a major part of the audience at these venues.

Delhi Police officials said the campaign is being designed as a sustained awareness exercise rather than a one-day symbolic event, with each day adding a new form of public participation.

The anti-drug message was also carried to the streets through an early morning cycling event in the New Delhi district. The rally began from Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium, moved around the India Gate hexagon and adjoining stretches, and returned to the stadium. Nearly 400 people, including police personnel, students, volunteers, fitness enthusiasts and members of the public, joined the event.

Officials said the idea was to link the campaign against substance abuse with visible promotion of physical fitness and disciplined living.

Sunday's activities came two days after Delhi Police launched the week-long campaign across the city under the title "Nasha Not Cool", an initiative aimed at creating awareness about the harmful impact of drug addiction and encouraging social resistance against narcotics.

Police said the campaign is now being amplified simultaneously through multiple platforms so that the message reaches beyond formal institutional spaces.

Actor Anil Kapoor, singer Kamal Khan, former Indian women's hockey captain Rani Rampal, and former cricketers Virender Sehwag, Zaher Khan and Suresh Raina have backed the campaign and appealed to young people to stay away from drugs.

Russian tradition Subotnik meets India's Swachh Bharat Mission

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

In a compelling display of cultural exchange and civic responsibility, the Russian Embassy in India recently organised a cleanliness drive in New Delhi, blending Russia's long-standing "Subotnik" tradition with India's ambitious Swachh Bharat Abhiyan. The initiative not only promoted environmental awareness but also symbolised the deepening friendship between the two nations through shared values of community service.

The event saw Russian diplomats, embassy staff, and volunteers actively participating in cleaning areas around the embassy premises. Armed with gloves, bags, and tools, participants took to the streets in a coordinated effort to contribute to the cleanliness of the city. The drive was more than a routine activity—it was a meaningful gesture of solidarity with India's nationwide sanitation mission.

At the heart of the initiative lies the concept of "Subotnik," a traditional Russian practice dating back to the early Soviet era. Derived from the Russian word for Saturday, Subotnik refers to voluntary community service carried out during weekends, where citizens engage in activities such as cleaning public spaces, repairing infrastructure, and supporting civic workers. Over time, it has evolved into a symbol of collective responsibility and social contribution in Russia.

Explaining the idea behind bringing this tradition to India, Russian Ambassador to India Denis Alipov highlighted the importance of volunteerism. He noted that Subotnik represents a strong culture of public service in Russia and expressed enthusiasm about organising a similar initiative in Delhi. According to him, the effort aligns naturally with India's Swachh Bharat Abhiyan, making it a fitting collaboration between the two countries.



Launched in 2014 by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan has grown into one of the world's largest cleanliness campaigns. It aims to improve sanitation, eliminate open defecation, and promote hygiene practices across urban and rural India. The participation of international communities, including diplomatic missions, reflects the campaign's global resonance and influence.

Volunteers who took part

in the embassy's cleanliness drive expressed pride in contributing to this larger mission. Many described the experience as both fulfilling and symbolic, noting that even small efforts can make a meaningful difference. Some participants also praised the scale and success of the Swachh Bharat initiative, calling it an example for other countries to follow.

Beyond environmental concerns, the event carried a

strong diplomatic message. By adopting a local campaign and integrating it with a Russian tradition, the initiative demonstrated how cultural practices can bridge nations. Participants emphasised that such activities foster goodwill, mutual respect, and closer people-to-people connections.

The embassy also framed the drive as a tribute to India's sustained efforts toward cleanliness and public health. Interestingly, officials noted that local civic authorities had already maintained the area well, leaving limited scope for cleaning—yet the symbolic value of the act remained significant.

Ultimately, the Subotnik-inspired drive in Delhi stands as a reminder that cooperation between nations can extend beyond policy and politics. Through shared action and community engagement, India and Russia continue to strengthen their partnership—one clean street at a time.

Delivery worker shot dead after argument in Jaffarpur Kalan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 21-year-old food delivery worker was shot dead at close range in southwest Delhi's Jaffarpur Kalan in the early hours of Sunday after a brief roadside altercation with a man identified by the victim's family as a Delhi Police head constable.

Police said the accused, identified as Neeraj, fled immediately after the firing and remains absconding. A murder case has been registered, and teams have been deployed to trace him.

The incident took place around 2.30 am when Pandav Kumar and his friend Krishan were standing on a village road after attending a birthday gathering at a friend's house. According to investigators, the two had stepped outside and were speaking with the hosts before leaving when Neeraj,



who lives across the road, came out and entered into an argument with them.

Police said Neeraj allegedly pulled out a firearm and shot Pandav in the chest from point-blank range. The force of the shot was such that the bullet pierced through Pandav's body and then hit Krishan, who was seated behind him on a motorcycle, on the right side of his abdomen.

Both men were rushed to a nearby hospital. Doctors declared Pandav dead, while Krishan is undergoing treatment. Investigators said the exact trigger behind the con-

frontation is still being pieced together.

Pandav's family has alleged that the accused is posted as a head constable with Delhi Police, though police officials have not officially confirmed his designation. They said the firing was completely unprovoked and accused the man of opening fire without any serious cause.

The killing sparked anger in the village, with family members and local residents gathering outside Jaffarpur Kalan police station demanding the immediate arrest of the accused.

IN FOCUS



People visit the Taj Mahal amid summer heat in Agra

PTI

World leaders relieved after Trump safe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

World leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, expressed relief on Sunday that US President Donald Trump and his top officials were unharmed following the shooting incident at the White House Correspondents' Dinner.

"Relieved to learn that President Trump, the First Lady and Vice President are safe and unharmed following the recent security incident at a Washington DC hotel. I extend my best wishes for their continued safety and well-being. Violence has no place in a democracy and must be unequivocally condemned," PM Modi said in a post on social media.

Expressing shock at the incident, British PM Keir Starmer said that any attack on democratic institutions must be condemned. "I am shocked by the scenes at



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with US President Donald Trump FILE PHOTO

Relieved to learn that President Trump, the First Lady and Vice President are safe and unharmed following the recent security incident at a Washington DC hotel. I extend my best wishes for their continued safety and well-being. Violence has no place in a democracy and must be unequivocally condemned

— PM NARENDRA MODI

the White House Correspondents' Dinner in Washington overnight. Any attack on democratic insti-

tutions or on the freedom of the press must be condemned in the strongest possible terms,"

he posted on X.

French President Emmanuel Macron extended his full support to Trump, calling the attack unacceptable. "The armed attack targeting the President of the United States last night is unacceptable. Violence has no place in a democracy. I extend my full support to Donald Trump," he posted on social media.

Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni expressed "full solidarity and most sincere closeness to President Trump, to First Lady Melania, to Vice President Vance" following the incident.

"No political hatred can find space in our democracies. We will not allow fanaticism to poison the places of free debate and information. The defence of the culture of confrontation must remain the insurmountable bulwark against every intolerant drift, to safeguard the values that

found our Nations," she posted on social media.

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney described the shooting incident as a "disturbing event". "I am relieved that the President, the First Lady, and all guests are safe following reports of gunfire at the White House Correspondents' Dinner in Washington tonight. Political violence has no place in any democracy, and my thoughts are with all those who have been shaken by this disturbing event," Carney said in a social media post.

Global leaders who condemned the incident include Pakistani PM Shehbaz Sharif, President of the Republic of Korea Lee Jae Myung, Japanese PM Sanae Takaichi, Israeli President Benjamin Netanyahu, Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum, Australian PM Anthony Albanese among others.

Peaceful voting concludes in Gujarat local body polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Voting for Gujarat's local self-government elections, being seen as a semifinal ahead of the upcoming Assembly polls, concluded peacefully on Saturday amid minor scattered incidents. The electorate recorded a moderate response, with average voter turnout reaching 57.08 per cent by the close of polling.

Polling remained slow until 9 a.m., while intense heat led to thin turnout at many polling stations between noon and 4 pm.

However, voter enthusiasm picked up significantly during the final hours, pushing the turnout higher by the end of the day.

Among urban bodies, 15 Municipal Corporations recorded 49 percent voting, while Municipalities registered 59 per cent turnout. Rural voters showed stronger participation, with District and Taluka Panchayats recording nearly 61 percent



Union Home Minister Amit Shah, ICC Chairman Jay Shah and their family members after casting votes in the municipal corporation elections, in Ahmedabad on Sunday.

PTI

voting, the highest among all categories.

Following the completion of polling, the process of sealing Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs) was undertaken at all polling stations in accordance with Election Commission guidelines.

Presiding officers and polling staff completed the required documentation and security procedures.

The Election Commission is expected to release the final turnout figures later in the night. Counting of votes and declaration of results will take place on April 28.

SHAH, CM BHUPENDRA CAST VOTES

Ahmedabad: Union Home Minister Amit Shah cast his vote with family members at a polling booth in Narayanpura, Ahmedabad, during Gujarat's local body elections on Saturday.

After voting, he offered prayers at Kameshwar Mahadev Temple and later interacted with party workers and local residents at the residence of BJP worker Paresh Patel.

Speaking after the first phase of polling, Shah expressed confidence in the prospects of Bharatiya Janata Party in the ongoing West Bengal Legislative Assembly Election and departed for Kolkata to campaign ahead of the next phase of voting in West Bengal. Meanwhile, Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel cast his vote at Shilaj and appealed to citizens to participate actively in what he described as the "sacred festival of democracy."

Gunfire at White House dinner

Authorities identified the individual as 31-year-old Cole Tomas Allen from California. Law enforcement officials stated that the suspect was armed and opened fire outside the venue but did not breach the secured event area.

Trump noted that one security officer was fired upon but escaped injury due to wearing a bulletproof vest. "They really got him," Trump said, praising the response of security personnel.

A reporter from CNN who was outside the ballroom said he witnessed the gunman firing nearby before law enforcement quickly intervened. The incident also unfolded amid protests outside the hotel, where demonstrators voiced opposition to the Trump administration and Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth.

Addressing the broader implications, Trump acknowledged the risks of his role but remained resolute. "It's a dangerous job, but I handle it as well as it can be handled," he said.

The president also referenced past threats to his safety, including two assassination attempts in 2024-one during a campaign rally in Butler Pennsylvania and another in Palm Beach Florida.

Calling for unity, Trump concluded his remarks by urging Americans to resolve differences peacefully. "We had people from across the political spectrum in that room... in light of tonight's events, I ask all Americans to recommit to resolving our differences peacefully," he said.

PM Modi turns up heat on TMC in final...

"While Ma (mother) is now in tears, Mati (land) has been handed over to syndicates and infiltrators and Manush (people) have been forced to leave the state in search of job opportunities elsewhere," he said.

Modi also alleged that even the smallest of politicians as well as goons consider themselves the Government under the Trinamool Congress regime in Bengal. "The TMC's 'nirmam sarkar' (cruel Government) stands with goons who torture women of this state. The time has now come to say we will tolerate no more," he said. "Miscreants who rape and torture women will be brought to justice after May 4 (day of the assembly poll results) by the new BJP Government of Bengal," the PM asserted.

Modi accused the Mamata Banerjee dispensation of gross inaction in cases involving trafficking of women from the state, and stated that the BJP Government would stand for women's empowerment every step of their way.

The Prime Minister also alluded to Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose's iconic pre-Independence slogan of 'Give me blood and I will give you freedom', to urge the people to vote for the BJP, "... and I will grant you freedom from TMC's 'maha jungleraj'".

In his second public address of the day at Arambag, Modi alleged the TMC-led Government

in West Bengal is not run from the state secretariat but by the goons and criminals sheltered by the party. "The TMC's 'nirmam (cruel) sarkar' doesn't run from the Nabanna (state secretariat). It is run by goons and criminals, requiring the intervention of the high court and the country's apex court to bring the Government back on track," Modi said.

He promised that the first Cabinet meeting of a BJP Government in the state will give its nod to the implementation of the Centre's flagship health insurance programme, Ayushman Bharat-Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana.

NIA nabs West Bengal blast accused

West Bengal Police had arrested an ambulance driver identified as Sanjay Mandal for disposing off the charred remains in an obvious bid to conceal the incident.

The case quickly took a political turn in violence-prone Bhangar, a constituency long marred by rivalry between the ruling TMC and the Indian Secular Front (ISF). ISF leaders, including panchayat member Abul Khair Molla and Bhangar MLA Nawsad Siddique were quick to put the blame on TMC workers for stockpiling explosives with outside help for voter intimidation ahead of the April 2026 West Bengal Assembly elections. Fearing escalation, district authorities have urged calm but residents remain on edge amid fears of retaliation.

ISF leaders alleged that the blast occurred while TMC-affiliated individuals handled bomb-making materials for attacking ISF workers. However, TMC denied the charges outright but the party is yet to officially confirm Qazi's affiliation. State police initially investigated the incident, collected samples from the blast site and arrested one individual. However, suspicions of a deeper conspiracy, echoing the 2022 Bhupatinagar bomb blast case, prompted the NIA to take over. The central agency registered an FIR, citing the inter-district body disposal and the organized nature of bomb manufacturing as indicators of a larger plot to spread terror or influence local politics. NIA investigators suspect the explosives were being prepared for electoral violence, a recurring concern in rural Bengal where crude bombs are frequently recovered before polls.

Described as a local TMC leader, Molla is accused of orchestrating the operation. One other accused had already been detained by state police. The NIA is expected to present evidence before a special court, with further arrests possible as the probe expands to uncover supply chains and political linkages.

Interestingly, Bhangar in South 24 Parganas has a documented history of crude bomb explosions tied to political turf wars, often surfacing before elections.

This case not only highlights the human cost with one life lost, three families scarred, it also signals the urgent need to dismantle networks manufacturing improvised explosives in a sen-

sitive border state. With Molla in custody, NIA aims to unravel the full conspiracy as to how political rivalry fuels underground bomb factories in the region.

US tightens Iran sanctions as talks falter

The move announced Friday is part of the administration's threat to impose secondary sanctions on entities doing business with Iran in an effort to cut off Iran's oil exports, which are a key source of its revenue.

Pakistan's top political and military leadership is continuing to mediate between the US and Iran, with indirect ceasefire talks still alive despite mounting tensions between the sides, two Pakistani officials said Sunday.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi left Pakistan on Saturday evening, officials said. Iran's state-run IRNA news agency said Araghchi is expected back in Pakistan's capital, Islamabad, on Sunday.

Trump said Thursday that Israel and Lebanon agreed to extend a ceasefire between Israel and Hezbollah by three weeks after talks at the White House. The meeting was the second high-level negotiation between the two countries this month. The initial 10-day ceasefire had been due to expire on Monday.

Airlines worldwide have begun cancelling flights as the war in the Middle East strains jet fuel supplies and pushes up prices. Experts have offered information to travellers about what to do if a flight is cancelled.

Swiss plane hit by engine fault in Delhi, four...

Details about how the passengers suffered injuries could not be immediately ascertained.

Shortly after 1 am local time on April 26, an issue occurred with one of the engines during the takeoff of flight LX147 in Delhi.

"The crew aborted the takeoff and, after assessing the situation, decided as a precaution to evacuate the aircraft," the spokesperson said. Sources said smoke was observed from the port side of the main wheel and initially, the input was that there was smoke from one of the landing gears.

Delhi airport operator DIAL said the operations at the airport remained unaffected due to the incident involving the aircraft.

In an earlier statement, the airline spokesperson had said all passengers and crew evacuated the aircraft via the emergency slides.

"Six passengers are undergoing medical evaluation. For a small number of individuals who were unable to use the slides, stairs were provided," the spokesperson had said.

Swiss International Air Lines is known as Swiss.

The sources said initially, a call regarding full emergency and the aircraft suffering tyre burst

was received from the Air Traffic Controller (ATC). After the checking was done by the airside team, it was confirmed that during the rejected takeoff, smoke was observed originating from the port side of the main wheel, they added.

Delhi airport operator DIAL said in the early hours of Sunday, a full emergency was declared for flight LX147 on Runway 28/10.

"All prescribed safety protocols were promptly executed, and passengers were safely evacuated. Airport operations remained unaffected," DIAL said in a post on X.

The airline spokesperson said it was determined to fully understand what led to this incident, including what led to the engine problem.

Regretting the inconvenience caused, the spokesperson said, "We are aware that such an event can be stressful and traumatic for those affected. Our teams remain in close contact with our passengers and continue to support them even beyond the immediate situation."

The spokesperson, earlier, said Swiss technical specialists will travel to Delhi to inspect the aircraft and initiate the next steps.

Passengers have been accommodated in hotels and rebooked onto alternative flights.

"We were able to find an individual solution for all guests to continue their journey and remain in contact with them," the airline spokesperson said.

NTA steps up NEET outreach

With every year's entrance of NEET (UG) mired in controversies with raging debates across and throughout the year, including litigations, this time NTA has taken active outreach across social media platforms with real-time engagement and response to candidates' queries.

NTA officials said there has also been a launch of an official WhatsApp public channel, which has garnered over 2.65 lakh subscribers within the first week, providing verified and timely updates. Besides, there is an ongoing effort to integrate Artificial Intelligence (AI)-enabled chatbots to address unstructured queries and provide instant assistance to candidates.

Special facilitation for candidates appearing at international centres, particularly in Kuwait, the UAE, and other regions impacted by ongoing conflict, with genuine requests for last-minute centre changes, is being considered sympathetically, subject to feasibility.

In view of the prevailing high temperatures, candidates are encouraged to stay well-hydrated and wear light, comfortable clothing, it added. Necessary arrangements for drinking water and shaded waiting areas have been ensured in coordination with centre superintendents and district administrations. Candidates have been advised to strictly adhere to the examination guidelines to facilitate smooth and orderly conduct of the examination.

UP means surety of safety and stability: CM Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday presented Letters of Comfort (LoC) to 17 pharmaceutical companies and said the day marks a historic milestone for the state's industrial and healthcare sectors.

He, according to an official statement, assured investors that UP guarantees safety, stability, and speed and is now being recognised for trust and timely delivery.

He emphasised that the state stands firmly with every reliable policy partner.

Adityanath said, "Under the visionary leadership of Narendra Modi, a 'New India' is emerging, with the country's economy reaching new heights. India is supplying



affordable and high-quality medicines to around 200 countries." Referring to the recent Pharma Conclave, he said it has elevated Uttar Pradesh's position on the global health-tech map.

Addressing investors, he noted that their investment is not just in pharma and medical devices but is also connected to the trust of 25 crore people in the state.

An investment of nearly ₹2,000 crore in research and development will help take Uttar Pradesh to new heights and is expected to generate employment for over 10,000 skilled and unskilled youth.

He stated that the results of collective efforts are now visible on the ground, with investments creating new opportunities.

Over the past nine years, due to clear policies and clean intent, Uttar Pradesh has transformed from a "BIMARU" state into the country's growth engine. The state's GSDP has risen to ₹36 lakh crore.

Special arrangements have also been made to ensure a comfortable and stress-free experience for candidates like reliable power backup at all centres to ensure uninterrupted examination conditions, adequate drinking water facilities for all candidates, clean and functional sanitation facilities, including separate arrangements for female candidates, medical support and emergency response readiness at centres, advance city intimation to help candidates plan travel and logistics.

To ensure "Zero Leak, Zero Disruption, Zero Unfair Means," a comprehensive multi-layered security framework has been implemented, which includes End-to-end secure question paper handling, from printing to post-exam logistics, GPS-tracked transportation with CAPF and Police escort, Double-lock strong rooms with 24x7 CCTV surveillance, Four-layer CCTV monitoring system across centres (~1.85 lakh cameras), Aadhaar-based biometric authentication (fingerprint + facial recognition) for candidates,

Two-layer frisking using hand-held metal detectors, deployment of signal jammers at sensitive centres and real-time monitoring through NTA Command Centre and district-level control rooms. Interestingly, to avoid any logistical issues including last minute travel reservations in rail, air or other mode, this year a prior intimation of the city of centre of examination have been shared to the aspirants almost a fortnight ago and the exact venue will be shared in the next couple of days.

The conduct of NEET involves coordinated efforts across multiple agencies from the State Governments and Police ensuring law & order, secure transit, and the centre security, District Magistrates and Superintendents of Police overseeing local preparedness, Activation of State-Level and District-Level Coordination Committees (SLCCs & DLCCs), Continuous intelligence monitoring and social media surveillance to detect any malpractice attempts.

"NTA is fully prepared for the smooth, secure, and fair conduct of NEET (UG) 2026, scheduled on Sunday across 551 cities and over 5,400 examination centres nationwide, covering approximately 22.8 lakh candidates. NTA reiterates its commitment to conducting NEET (UG) with the highest standards of integrity, transparency, and fairness, ensuring a level playing field for all candidates," said Abhishek Singh, Director General, NTA, Government of India.

NEET (UG) remains one of the largest entrance examinations globally, conducted in a single day and single shift in pen-and-paper (OMR) mode, requiring meticulous planning and coordination at national, state, and district levels.

Ahead of the examinations, all centres have undergone rigorous third-party verification. Centres linked to coaching institutions or with inadequate infrastructure have been excluded while Government officials have been appointed as Centre Superintendents, Observers and City Coordinators. Live Dashboards and real-time monitoring systems are in place for oversight.

GRAPEVINE

Has BJP add-on rattled MoS Ravneet Bittu?

As the BJP is trying to make inroads in Punjab, a lot more activities are awaited for the party's consolidation in next few months. The recent merger of AAP Rajya Sabha MPs led by Raghav Chadha into the BJP has set alarm bells ringing in the existing set-up of "reorganised" BJP in the State. Some of the party's stalwarts who left Congress to join BJP, including Union Minister of State for Railways Ravneet Singh Bittu, National Spokesperson Jaiveer Shergill, are yet to share their joy of 'welcoming' Chadha and team MPs in the BJP camp. While Bittu's camp is apparently in a tizzy about the fate of his continuing in the Council of Ministers, if there is a shake-up, grapevine has it that Shergill, too, was awaiting some bigger responsibilities as he had scaled fairly enough in the Punjab circuit.



Congress leaders speculate who will be Kerala CM

Sensing victory, Kerala's Congress is abuzz with the names for new Chief Minister. Senior Congress leader Ramesh Chennithalla, Opposition Leader VD Satheesan, AICC General Secretary KC Venugopal's names are in the forefront in the race for the Chief Minister post. Due to proximity with High Command, many argue Venugopal who has not contested election is expected to win the race. His opponents argue that, if he is chosen, unnecessarily by-election for his Parliament seat have to be enforced and the race will be between those who contested in the Assembly polls. Speculations are rife as who - Ramesh, Satheesan, Venugopal - will emerge as the choice of Congress High Command.



Floor can cross you before you cross the floor!

The corridors of Parliament House saw more shifting than a Delhi summer power grid this week, as seven AAP Rajya Sabha MPs led by Raghav Chadha took a one-way trip to the BJP. Political pundits say the move was "less ideological realignment and more tactical relocation". One senior AAP leader, sipping cold coffee to beat both the heat and the news, muttered, "Our Upper House strength just went on a diet." BJP managers, meanwhile, were seen doing quiet math with extra sugar in their tea. With seven new additions, the party is now just a few seats short of a Rajya Sabha majority without allies. The official AAP line is "people will decide." Punjab functionaries who are not muted, are asking Delhi why their hard-won seats are being gifted away. Congress, for once, had the easiest press brief: "No comment," followed by a grin. As one veteran journalist put it, "In politics, the floor can cross you before you cross the floor."



Nastiest versus Nicest pep talk

At a high-profile diplomatic gathering last week, a notable exchange on India's foreign policy direction took place between a former Congress minister who previously handled External Affairs and a senior MEA official. According to sources present at the event, the former minister informally engaged the official in a conversation regarding the trajectory of India's foreign policy under the current Government. During the discussion, the former minister reportedly questioned the broader direction and strategic intent guiding recent diplomatic decisions. "Where is our foreign policy heading under the present Government?" the former minister is said to have asked, reflecting concerns that have occasionally surfaced within Opposition circles. In response, the senior official maintained a measured stance, emphasising continuity and national priorities. "We are following our established standards and acting in the best interests of India at all times," the official replied.



Grassroots biodiversity project launched in Meghalaya, TN

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Environment Ministry and the National Biodiversity Authority have launched a five-year project in Tamil Nadu and Meghalaya to strengthen grassroots biodiversity governance, officials said on Sunday.

This will be done by empowering local communities and institutions through the greening of Gram Panchayat Development Plans and innovative financing.

"A key objective of the project is mainstreaming



biodiversity in local development plans to strengthen Panchayati Raj Institutions and Biodiversity Management Committees," an official said.

The project aims to build landscape-level multi-stakeholder platforms that bring together forest departments, revenue authorities, elected

better it is for the country. In a freewheeling interaction, where he answered several queries from students, the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha said that Gen Z women will lead the way for the country and it is everyone's duty to open every door for them. Really enjoyed meeting the young women from Gargi College and Delhi University. "Two things are clear: The magician has run out of tricks. Young India can see right through him, and Gen Z is our

India at epicentre of global heatwave as 98 cities top world heat list

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With temperatures soaring to dangerous levels across the country, India is witnessing severe heatwave conditions, with 98 of the world's 100 hottest cities currently located in the country, raising concerns over the impact of rising temperatures.

According to data from AQI.in, India is experiencing record-breaking heat, placing it at the epicentre of a global heatwave.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD) data, Akola recorded 46.9 degree Celsius, followed by Amravati 46.8 degree Celsius, Banda 46.6 degree Celsius, Barmer 46.4 degree Celsius, Jaisalmer 46 degree Celsius and Prayagraj 45.7 degree Celsius on Sunday.

Temperatures in many regions have surpassed 40°C, with some locations nearing 45°C, pointing to a trend of increasingly intense heatwaves. Cities recording temperatures well above normal include Orai and Auraiya in Uttar Pradesh, and Jaisalmer and Phalodi in Rajasthan, among others.

According to the latest weather update, heat wave to severe heat wave conditions were observed at isolated places over Himachal Pradesh, while several parts of Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, and West Uttar Pradesh also experienced heat wave conditions.

India's peak power demand hit an all-time high of 256.11 GW on Saturday due to an intensifying heat wave, which increased the use of cooling devices such as air conditioners and desert coolers, according to the latest power ministry data.

The peak power demand on Saturday eclipsed the pre-



An area engulfed in dust amid strong winds and heat wave conditions on a hot summer day in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh on Sunday

PTI

vious record of 252.07 GW, hit just a day earlier on Friday, April 24, at 15:48 hrs.

In Uttar Pradesh, Banda was the hottest place in the State, where mercury touched 46.6 degrees Celsius (4.4 degrees above normal), followed by Prayagraj, which recorded a high of 45.7 degrees Celsius (4.8 degrees above normal).

Other places in the State where the mercury breached the 44-degree mark are: Fursatganj (in Amethi district) — 44.7 degrees Celsius, Hamirpur — 44.2 degrees Celsius and Kanpur — 44.1 degrees Celsius. Jhansi and Varanasi recorded a high of 44 degrees Celsius each.

The MeT department has also warned of warm night conditions in several districts, particularly in western Uttar Pradesh, including Meerut, Ghaziabad, Hapur, Bulandshahr, Aligarh and Agra, among others.

Meanwhile, Lucknow recorded a maximum temperature of 43 degrees Celsius (3.5 degrees above normal) and a minimum of 26.8 degrees Celsius (3.7 degrees above

normal), the meteorological department said on Sunday. From April 28 onwards, a change in weather is expected under the influence of a western disturbance, bringing thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and gusty winds with speeds of 30-40 kmph at isolated places across the State. The wind speed may increase to 40-50 kmph on April 29, officials said.

Sizzling heat continued to sweep through Haryana and Punjab on Sunday, with Narnaul and Faridkot turning out to be the hottest places in both States. Most places in the two States recorded above-normal maximum temperatures.

In Haryana's Narnaul, the mercury settled at 44.2 degrees Celsius, according to the MeT here. Among other places in Haryana, Rohtak recorded a high of 43.6 degrees Celsius, Hisar 42.2 degrees, Karnal 42.2 degrees, Ambala 41.6 degrees, Bhiwani 43 degrees, Sirsa 43 degrees, while Gurugram's maximum settled at 40.3 degrees Celsius.

In Punjab, Bathinda sizzled, recording a day temperature

of 43.7 degrees Celsius. Amritsar recorded a high of 39.3 degrees Celsius, Ludhiana 42.4 degrees, while Patiala's maximum also settled at 42.4 degrees Celsius.

Besides, Bihar, Odisha, Maharashtra, Gujarat, several southern States also witnessed heat wave conditions where temperatures soared to over 40 degree Celsius on Sunday.

Amid the rising temperatures, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued advisories urging people to take precautions against heat-related illnesses.

Prolonged exposure to extreme heat can lead to serious health risks, including heatstroke, while also contributing to higher electricity consumption and potential water shortages. The ongoing heatwave has also renewed concerns over climate change and the increasing frequency of extreme weather events.

Additionally, hot and humid weather is expected in coastal and eastern regions, while warm nighttime conditions are likely in parts of north India, further increasing discomfort and health risks.

PM's praise for blackbuck conservation matter of pride: CM Sai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Sunday termed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's praise for the State's blackbuck conservation efforts in the 'Mann Ki Baat' address as a matter of pride, saying it will boost public morale.

Sai, who heard the 133rd episode of the programme at Vinayak City in Bhatagaon here, said that Chhattisgarh's conservation initiative is emerging as a model for other States.

PM Modi, in his Mann Ki Baat address, said, "There is good news from central India. Blackbucks are now seen again in Chhattisgarh. At one time, their numbers had



declined drastically, but sustained efforts were undertaken to conserve them. Today, they are running freely in open fields. This marks the return of our lost heritage."

Reacting to the praise, Sai said the recognition reflects the State's strong commitment to environmental protection and biodiversity conservation.



"It is a matter of great pride that the Prime Minister mentioned and appreciated Chhattisgarh's blackbuck conservation efforts," he said, adding that the acknowledgement strengthens the State's identity and boosts public morale.

An official from the State forest department said that blackbucks had disappeared

in the State by the 1970s and remained locally extinct for nearly 50 years.

However, a new chapter began in 2018, when the department initiated a reintroduction programme in Barnawapara Wildlife Sanctuary in Balodabazar-Bhatapara district, said Dhamshil Ganveer, Divisional Forest Officer (DFO) of Balodabazar forest division.

With permissions from authorities, 77 blackbucks were translocated in 2018 to Barnawapara, including 27 from Kanan Pendari Zoological Garden in Bilaspur and 50 from the National Zoological Park, New Delhi, he said.

The official said that the animals were first housed in

PM Modi urges citizens to make Census 2027 a success

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Underlining the importance of the ongoing Census exercise in the country, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said the ongoing process is not just a Government task but a responsibility of all citizens and participation of everyone is vital.

In his monthly radio address 'Mann Ki Baat', Modi also assured the people that all information provided by them during the Census will remain secure and confidential, and appealed to all citizens to participate in the process and make the Census 2027 a success.

"Friends, the national Census is not just a Government task; it is a responsibility for all of us. Your participation is vital. The information you provide remains completely secure and confidential, protected by robust digital security," he said.

The prime minister said the Census is a very important campaign currently underway in the country, and every Indian must be aware of it. He also noted that the Indian Census exercise is the largest such exercise in the world.

"Census 2027 has been

made digital. All information is being recorded directly through digital means," he said. Modi said the personnel visiting people's homes are equipped with a mobile app, and they will speak to everyone and enter the information right there.

"Friends, your participation in this Census has also been made easier. You can now record your information yourself. A self-enumeration facility will be available to you 15 days before the official visit. You can fill in the details at your own convenience," he said.

Once completed, the applicant will receive a unique ID via mobile or email, he said. "Later, when the official arrives at your home, you can simply show this ID to confirm your details," he said.

Modi said this eliminates the need to provide information twice, saving time and making the process seamless. He said in States where self-enumeration has been completed, the work of house-listing by Census officials has already begun. So far, the house-listing for approximately 12 million (1.2 crore) families has been completed, he said. Modi said for those who have been through this process before, their experience this time is going to be different.



President on 5-day summer sojourn to Himachal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu will visit Himachal Pradesh on a five-day summer sojourn beginning Monday, her office said. During her visit, President Murmu will stay at the Rashtrapati Niwas, Mashobra, Shimla, it said.

The President will visit Himachal Pradesh from April 27 to May 1, 2026, for the summer sojourn, the Rashtrapati Bhavan said in a statement issued on Sunday.

On April 28, she will attend a banquet hosted by the Himachal Pradesh governor at Lok Bhavan, Shimla. On April 29, she will visit the Atal Tunnel, the statement said.

Murmu will grace the convocation ceremony of Chaudhary Sarwan Kumar Himachal Pradesh Krishi Vishwavidyalaya at Palampur on April 30.

On the same day, she will host an 'At Home' reception at Rashtrapati Niwas, Mashobra, it said. "On May 1, the President will visit the Army Training Command, Shimla, before leaving for Delhi," the statement added.

Jitendra Singh reviews plans for space labs in colleges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister Jitendra Singh on Sunday reviewed plans to set up space laboratories in universities and colleges across India, according to a statement released in New Delhi.

The initiative involves establishing seven such labs, which would provide hands-on exposure to students in satellite systems, rocketry and mission design.

"The aim is to build a strong pipeline of skilled youth for India's expanding space sector, which has attracted over \$600 million in private investment over the past five years following



the opening up of the sector to non-Government entities," an official said.

Singh also reviewed the progress made in India's space reforms and the growing participation of private players across the value chain.

The country's private space ecosystem has expanded rapidly, with the number of startups increasing from a single digit in 2019 to more than 400 by early 2026.

"These startups are now active across launch vehicles, satellite and payload manu-

Magician out of tricks, youth sees through him: Rahul

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday said the "magician" has run out of tricks and young India can now see through him, as he attacked the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led Government over the women's reservation issue. Gandhi met a group of young women from Delhi University and said the more the women of India are empowered, the

better it is for the country. In a freewheeling interaction, where he answered several queries from students, the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha said that Gen Z women will lead the way for the country and it is everyone's duty to open every door for them. Really enjoyed meeting the young women from Gargi College and Delhi University. "Two things are clear: The magician has run out of tricks. Young India can see right through him, and Gen Z is our



future and Gen Z women will lead the way. It is our duty to open every door for them," the Congress leader said in a post on X. "The future of our country is in safe hands," he said.

Gandhi had targeted Prime

Minister Modi during the debate in the Lok Sabha on the women's reservation bill, calling him a "magician", but the Congress leader's remark was later expunged from records.

The Congress leader also expressed his bias in favour of empowering women, saying they are more effective than men. He lauded BSP chief Mayawati and former Tamil Nadu chief minister J Jayalalitha for their role in their respective States.

Beating Retreat music now available on WAVES OTT: PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

For the first time, the music of Beating Retreat has been made available on WAVES OTT, and in the future, it will be made available on other platforms too, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Sunday.

In his monthly radio address 'Mann Ki Baat', Modi said that over the past few years, the inclusion of Indian music in the ceremony has



increased, which is being liked by people across the country.

This year's Beating Retreat

ceremony was very memorable as the Air Force, Army, Navy, and CAPF bands gave excellent performances, he said.

The prime minister said the Air Force band composed the Sindoor formation while the Naval band composed the 'Matsya Yantra' formation.

The Army band's performance showcased 150 years of Vande Mataram as well as India's success in cricket, he said.

"You may have noticed that this ceremony showcases the diverse musical traditions of different bands. This programme of splendid formations, along with vibrant music, is sure to draw everyone's attention," Modi said.

After the Beating Retreat, all this hard work and achievements used to fade away, but now a highly commendable initiative has been undertaken pertaining to it, he said.

Shah promises UCC, end to ‘syndicate raj’ in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday said the BJP will end “goonda raj” and “syndicate raj” in West Bengal if the party comes to power in the State.

Addressing a public rally at Tehatta in Nadia district, Shah also claimed that voters “wiped out” the Mamata Banerjee Government in the first phase of the Assembly polls itself.

“The BJP has already won 110 seats in the first phase of polls held on April 23,” he said.

“There will be an end to ‘goonda raj’ and ‘syndicate raj’ in West Bengal if the BJP assumes power in the State. Do not be afraid to step out



Union Home Minister Amit Shah waves during a public meeting amid the ongoing West Bengal Assembly elections in Tehatta, Nadia district

and cast your votes, as the Election Commission has made ample arrangements. Nobody will be able to stop you from voting,” Shah said.

He said if the BJP is voted to power, it would identify “infiltrators hiding in the State” and take necessary action

against them.

The senior BJP leader had to cut short his speech because of sudden heavy rainfall despite a large gathering at the venue.

Later, speaking at another gathering in Ranaghat in the same district, Shah

alleged that most of the cattle smuggling takes place through Nadia.

“After forming the Government in West Bengal, we will form a special squad to stop cattle smuggling,” Shah said, lambasting the Mamata Banerjee dispensation for allegedly helping the crime flourish.

Shah promised that women and unemployed youth would get a monthly allowance of ₹3,000 and said that women would also get free rides in all State transport vehicles after the BJP assumes power in the State. Shah said if the BJP is voted to power in West Bengal, it would implement the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), end polygamy and enforce the ban on triple talaq.

Kejriwal alleges BJP-ECI plot to delete 27 lakh Bengal voters

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

AAP leader and former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal on Sunday alleged that the BJP-ECI conspiracy led to the deletion of the names of 27 lakh voters from the West Bengal electoral rolls under the SIR exercise, claiming that it was part of a larger plan to target their citizenship documents.

Addressing an election rally in Ballygunge, Kejriwal also accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of “insulting” the people of the State by deploying 3.5 lakh security personnel for the Assembly polls.

He urged those whose names were allegedly deleted from the voters’ list to support the Trinamool Congress.



“Go and tell your friends, relatives and neighbours to vote for TMC candidates in this election. Didi has to win this fight against the BJP, which wants to take away your citizenship rights as part of a bigger game plan to win the polls,” he said.

“Remember, they (BJP) will get your citizenship docu-

ments, such as ration cards, cancelled, and only Mamata Banerjee can help you. She will stand by you,” he said.

Alleging that Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah were bringing people from outside the State to influence the polls, he said several BJP-ruled States’ chief ministers were campaign-

ing in the State.

“This shows how a woman of short height stands tall against Modi and Shah and is challenging the BJP,” he said.

“Modiji has deployed central agencies such as the ED, CBI and also 3.5 lakh security personnel for an Assembly poll. What is happening? Are people of Bengal terrorists?” he asked.

Accusing the BJP leadership of using central agencies to target political opponents, Kejriwal said, “A year ago, they filed a corruption case against me and put me in jail for six months. After a year, the court said there was not a shred of evidence against the fabricated charges. Please don’t allow this revengeful Government, which believes in vendetta politics, to come to power in West Bengal.”

Vijay asks TVK candidates to inspect strong rooms on rotation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

TVK leader Aadhav Arjuna on Sunday said his party chief Vijay has instructed all the contesting candidates of the April 23 Assembly elections in Tamil Nadu to inspect the strong rooms on a rotation basis to ensure all the EVMs were safe and secured.

The elections to 234 constituencies were held on April 23 with a record turnout of over 85 per cent, and the Electronic Voting Machines have been shifted to strong rooms.

“Our leader (Vijay) has instructed all the candidates to visit the strong rooms



three times a day in their respective areas”, Arjuna said after visiting the counting centre at Loyola College. He is contesting from Villivakkam in the city.

Urging the election officials to ensure the counting process was held in a trans-

parent manner, he claimed that, though all the security measures were intact, the counting rooms were small. Therefore, the authorities should also allocate adequate time for each counting round and ensure accurate announcements.

Arjuna also wanted officials concerned to provide sufficient security to maintain law and order on May 4, the counting day.

To a question on reports that Vijay is likely to visit Australia like other political leaders, including DMK chief MK Stalin, who have taken a break post polls, Arjuna said the TVK founder is actively involved in party activities.

Congress alleges ‘political murder’ in Asansol

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The Congress’ West Bengal unit chief, Subhankar Sarkar, on Sunday described the killing of a party worker in Asansol, where polling was held on April 23, as “political murder” even as the police said it was a fallout of an altercation over car parking.

In Delhi, the Congress said the victim, Debdeep Chatterjee, was closely associated with Asansol Uttar Assembly seat’s party candidate Prasenjit Puitandi and termed the killing as post-poll violence. Senior party leader Rahul Gandhi strongly condemned the killing, and said his party will not bow before this politics that



Congress West Bengal unit chief Subhankar Sarkar

stains India’s non-violent tradition.

Puitandi claimed that Chatterjee was “murdered by TMC goons sheltered by local councillor Animesh Das”, a charge the corporator denied. Chatterjee’s wife

claimed that she, along with her husband and their 10-year-old son, were returning home after attending a family function when an altercation broke out with the youths who had parked their two-wheeler right at

the entrance of their housing complex. The situation escalated when Chatterjee stepped out of his car, and the youths thrashed him, she claimed.

A senior police official said that upon being trashed, Chatterjee fell to the ground, hit his head on a concrete slab and became unconscious. He was rushed to a nearby hospital, where doctors declared him ‘brought dead’, the official said. Puitandy said Chatterjee, an active Congress worker in the area who had campaigned intensively for the party in the assembly polls, was “murdered by TMC goons sheltered by local councillor Animesh Das”.

ECI orders probe into Diamond Harbour voter intimidation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Sunday ordered a probe after a video purportedly showing bike-borne men intimidating locals in the Diamond Harbour Assembly constituency ahead of the second phase of polls in West Bengal surfaced on social media, a senior official said.

Soon after the matter came to light, the poll panel lodged a formal complaint at the Diamond Harbour police station. Officials said a case



has been registered and an investigation has been initiated.

“The ECI is addressing the matter so that these threats

get curbed by today,” the official said. Campaigning for the second phase of the Assembly polls on April 29 will end on Monday evening.

Police said the case was registered at the Diamond Harbour police station on Sunday under sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) dealing with criminal intimidation and unlawful acts.

This came days after the State Government, acting on a directive from the poll panel, suspended five officers posted in the Diamond Harbour police district and initiated disciplinary proceedings against them for alleged “serious misconduct” and failure to maintain neutrality.

Violence in West Bengal ahead of phase 2 polls; clashes reported

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Sporadic incidents of violence were reported in Howrah and Haroa areas of West Bengal in the run-up to the second phase of polling on April 29, a senior police official said on Sunday.

In Howrah town, clashes broke out between Trinamool Congress and BJP supporters over the chanting of slogans during a roadshow of the saffron party’s



BJP and TMC workers clashed in West Bengal’s Howrah

Uttar Howrah candidate Umesh Rai. As the roadshow passed by a TMC election office in the area on GT Road, TMC supporters chanted its poll slogan ‘Joy

Bangla’ that was countered by BJP supporters with the “Jai Shri Ram” chant.

This led to an altercation between two groups, leading to a scuffle that prompted central forces to baton-charge both BJP and TMC supporters, a police official said.

BJP MP and actor Ravi Kishan was heading the roadshow. However, by the time the scuffle took place, his vehicle had already crossed the spot.

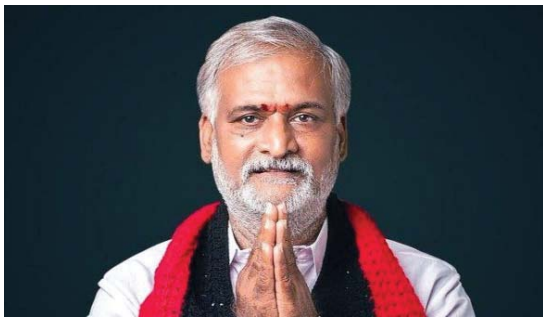
States Focus



MAMATA LEADS MASSIVE PADYATRA IN BHABANIPUR

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Sunday led a ‘padyatra’ in her Bhabanipur Assembly constituency in south Kolkata, accompanied by thousands of party supporters, as the election campaign entered its final phase. Amid the playing of the song ‘Jotoi Koro Hamla Abar Jitbe Bangla’ (No matter how much you attack, Bengal will triumph), Banerjee interacted with people along a one-km stretch from Lansdown Crossing to Kalighat Fire Services Station.

Amid shouts of ‘Didi Didi’, she shook hands, accepted garlands from people, and stopped security personnel from removing those who touched her feet during the colourful road show featuring ‘dhak’ (traditional drum) and the traditional ‘chou dance’ of Purulia.



DMK TO FORM GOVT FOR SECOND TERM: SEKAR BABU

DMK leader and Tamil Nadu Minister PK Sekar Babu on Sunday expressed confidence that the party will come back to power in the April 23 Tamil Nadu Assembly elections. Sekar Babu, who is contesting in Chennai’s Harbour constituency for the second time, said DMK chief MK Stalin will come “bright in this election”.

Speaking to the reporters in this district, the Minister for Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments claimed that after counting on May 4, “for the second time, Muthuvel Karunanidhi Stalin’s voice will echo in the governor’s house (Lok Bhavan),” in an apparent indication of the swearing-in ceremony.

100 crude bombs seized in South 24 Parganas



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Police on Sunday recovered around 100 crude bombs from the house of a person, allegedly a TMC worker, at Bhangar in South 24 Parganas district, days ahead of the second phase of the Assembly polls in West Bengal, an official said. The explosives were recovered during a search at the residence of Rafikul Islam following specific inputs, he said.

“A stern message has been issued to the Commissioner of Police, Kolkata, all DCPs, SPs and officers up to the rank of OC and IC that if any such explosive is found or threatening tactics are used by any person in their jurisdiction, the concerned officer will face action,” the Election Commission official said.

Surveillance and area domination would be intensified in vulnerable pockets to ensure that voters can exercise their franchise without fear, he added.

Bengal polls: Bhabanipur becomes battleground for prestige

PRADIPTA TAPADAR
■ Kolkata

In West Bengal’s political imagination, Bhabanipur is no longer just another south Kolkata Assembly seat. It is Mamata Banerjee’s political refuge and home turf, the BJP’s chosen psychological battlefield, where the stage is set for what many in Bengal are calling the “mother of all electoral contests”.

With Banerjee, the chief minister and three-term MLA from the constituency, locked in a direct contest with Leader of Opposition and BJP heavyweight Suvendu Adhikari, the April 29 election

has turned Bhabanipur into the State’s most closely watched prestige fight.

Bhabanipur is effectively bracing for a symbolic rematch of Nandigram, where Adhikari defeated Banerjee, his once political mentor, in 2021 after quitting the TMC and joining the BJP.

Five years later, the duel has shifted to Banerjee’s own bastion. For the TMC, retaining Bhabanipur is about protecting the chief minister’s political authority in her own backyard. For the BJP, breaching it would mean puncturing the aura of invincibility around Bengal’s most powerful leader.

Spread across eight Kolkata Municipal Corporation wards, Bhabanipur is often called ‘mini India’ - a constituency where Bengalis coexist with Gujarati traders, Punjabi and Sikh households, Marwari and Jain families, alongside a sizeable Muslim electorate. Migrants from Bihar, Odisha and Jharkhand add another layer to the social mix.

Around 42 per cent of voters are Bengali Hindus, 34 per cent non-Bengali Hindus and nearly 24 per cent Muslims, making the constituency socially diverse and politically sensitive. It is precisely this arithmetic that appears to have encour-



Supporters carry large cutouts of West Bengal Chief Minister and TMC candidate from Bhabanipur constituency Mamata Banerjee during a roadshow in Kolkata

aged Adhikari to challenge Banerjee on her home turf.

For months, the BJP has mapped Bhabanipur booth by booth. Party leaders claim

Kayasthas make up 26.2 per cent of the electorate, Muslims 24.5 per cent, eastern Indian migrant communities 14.9 per cent, Marwaris 10.4

per cent and Brahmins 7.6 per cent.

The exercise, party insiders said, helped identify where Bengali Hindus dominate, where Hindi-speaking trader communities are concentrated, and which booths are likely to be influenced by Muslim voters, turning the constituency into a finely calibrated caste-community contest rather than a conventional urban seat.

Its political history mirrors Bengal’s own transformation. Once a Congress citadel represented by heavyweights like Siddhartha Shankar Ray, Bhabanipur disappeared after delimita-

tion in 1972 and was revived only in 2011, the year Banerjee ended the Left Front’s 34-year rule.

Her close aide, Subrata Bakshi, first won the seat, vacated it, and Banerjee entered the assembly through the bypoll that effectively became her coronation as an MLA after being sworn in as chief minister. She retained the seat in 2016.

In 2021, she shifted to Nandigram but, after losing to Suvendu Adhikari by 1,956 votes, returned to the assembly through the Bhabanipur bypoll, defeating BJP’s Priyanka Tibrewal by more than 58,000 votes.

That history explains why, within the TMC, Bhabanipur is viewed not merely as a safe seat, but as Banerjee’s political insurance. Her Kalighat residence lies within the constituency, and long before it became her assembly fortress, its lanes and community clubs were central to her rise from Kolkata South MP to Bengal’s most dominant politician.

“This is not just another seat. People here have repeatedly stood by Mamata Banerjee’s politics of development and inclusiveness,” Kolkata Mayor and senior TMC leader Firhad Hakim said. (PTI)

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Order Order

Court can reject anticipatory bail but cannot direct accused to surrender: SC



A court can reject anticipatory bail of an accused but it has no jurisdiction to direct him to surrender before the trial court, the Supreme Court has said. A bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and Ujjal Bhuyan made the observation while hearing a plea filed by a man accused of cheating and forgery. "If the court wants to reject the anticipatory bail, it may do so, but the court has no jurisdiction to say that the petitioner should now surrender," the bench said.

The Jharkhand High Court had rejected anticipatory bail plea of the accused and asked him to surrender and seek regular bail. In this case, a complaint had been filed before a magistrate alleging offences under Sections 323 (voluntarily causing hurt), 420 (cheating), 467 (forgery of valuable security), 468 (forgery for purpose of cheating), 471 (using forged document) and 120B read with 34 of the IPC, in connection with a land dispute. The High Court had dismissed the second anticipatory bail application of the accused on the ground that no new circumstances were shown.

It had relied on its earlier order rejecting his first anticipatory bail plea, in which the court directed the petitioner to surrender before the trial court and seek regular bail in terms of the decision in *Satender Kumar Antil v CBI*.

No events in Delhi parks for more than 10 days: NGT



The National Green Tribunal has said the authorities in the national capital must ensure that designated parks are not used to hold events for more than 10 days a month in compliance with the Supreme Court's order.

The green body was hearing a case about the alleged illegal installation of swings and commercial mismanagement of a district park in Rohini. It had earlier asked the Delhi Pollution Control Committee to submit a report after conducting a spot inspection.

In a recent order, a bench of NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert member Afroz Ahmad said that the committee had submitted its report, according to which the park was found vacant and no activity of any kind was observed.

"At one of the places within the ground, a heap of solid waste was lying. Further, after local inquiry, it came to knowledge that the ground belongs to the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) and is being given for mela/festivals from time to time," the bench said, citing the report.

Nashik court sends godman Kharat in judicial custody till May 9

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nashik

A Nashik court on Sunday sent self-styled astrologer-cum-godman Ashok Kharat in judicial custody till May 9 in the sixth case of sexual exploitation registered against him.

Kharat, who was arrested on March 18, is accused of sexually exploiting several women and indulging in large-scale financial fraud by claiming to have divine powers and knowledge of black magic.

In the sixth case, he is accused of sexually exploiting a young woman who had approached him seeking a solution to her personal problems. Kharat allegedly threatened the woman, warning of using his "divine powers" to destroy her family. He had also taken Aadhaar, PAN card and other documents of her family members, police said. The special investigation team (SIT), investigating 12 cases of sexual exploitation and financial fraud registered against Kharat in Nashik and Ahilyanagar districts, on Thursday filed a request application in the court demanding his custody in the sixth case. As the court granted permission,



the SIT took Kharat's custody and produced him in court in the sixth case on Friday.

The court had then remanded him in police custody till Sunday. He was produced in the court on Sunday at the end of his police custody. Due to security reasons, the proceedings of the court were held through video conferencing on Sunday and Kharat was not produced in person.

During the hearing, the police demanded judicial custody for Kharat. Later, the court remanded Kharat to judicial custody till May 9. The SIT will produce Kharat in court on Monday

again and demand his police custody in a seventh case, pertaining to sexual harassment of a woman. Meanwhile, the SIT has found some more objectionable and suspicious videos from Kharat's farmhouse in Sinnar taluka of the district, a police official said. Police registered one more case against Kharat on Friday, wherein he is accused of cheating his then Chartered Accountant of ₹8.76 crore during 2018-23.

The victim was once a confidant of Kharat and served as a trustee of his Shivanika Trust that managed the affairs of a temple in Sinnar taluka.

The FIR stated that Kharat had allegedly told the victim that his parents may die and to avoid the impending event, specific rituals needed to be performed. As per the CA's complaint, he appointed a cook at the farmhouse where the latter worked as a spy. The cook did not switch off CCTVs there despite Kharat's instructions and the latter's alleged obscene activities were recorded, the complaint claimed.

The 12 cases registered against Kharat so far include eight offences of sexual exploitation of women and four cases of cheating. Seven more cases have been filed in various cities in Maharashtra.



Allahabad High Court contradictions on live-ins and reductionism



SEEMA SINDHU

Two diametrically opposite orders by different benches of the same High Court are a glaring example of how people are at the mercy of judges in personal matters litigation like divorce and live-in relationships. It paints a dismal picture of law and justice in the country for personal freedom and individual rights advocates. And there's a deeper problem which neither Govt nor Courts are acknowledging.

A single judge bench of Allahabad HC refused to give protection from interference to a live-in couple where both the partners were already married. It said: If the petitioners are already married and have their spouse alive, he/she cannot be legally permitted to enter into live-in relationship with a third person without seeking divorce from the earlier spouse."

Few days later, a division bench of the same HC ordered protection from interference to a live-in couple where one partner is married saying: morality and law have to be kept apart and a married man commits no offence by having a live-in relationship.

The single judge order is outrightly against the established position of law in *Indra Sarma Vs VKV*



Sarma where in Supreme Court legally recognised the personal freedom of individuals to be in live-in relationships, including married persons. The judgment only stopped short of giving maintenance and other legal remedies to a suchpartner which are available to a wife. But it doesn't bar protection from interference.

That would be regressive and unconstitutional as it infringes one's Right to Life protected under Article 21 of the Constitution.

The larger question that arises here is why such incidences are on rise? Blaming it on Western influence or depleting moral values is



REDUCTIONISM. Divorce is integral to marriage. Marriage may or may not work like all other relationships. Times have changed a lot since 1955 when the concept of divorce was introduced in Hindu Marriage, but laws haven't. Divorce in India is a myth if you look at data. India has just one per cent divorce rate, though cases

are increasing and Family Court boards each day run into 40/50 cases per day. Govt and courts virtually make the remedy of divorce non-existent.

If it's not by mutual consent, a person may lose his whole youth and life in fighting uptil Supreme Court. To tell you the grimmer side, a lawyer can predict the fate of the case in Supreme Court/ court where he/she practices the moment he/she knows which bench or judge would hear the matter. It's totally at the mercy of the judge- his personal

beliefs and moods. Contested divorce is a battle of life time in India. The non-consenting partner has all the law by his/her side to keep it going forever for money or "teaching lesson". What remedy a person wanting divorce is left with then? Live-in. Had divorce been fast and at invocation of one party (no-fault theory divorce like in many countries), people in bad marriages wouldn't be forced to opt for live-in while having a subsisting marriage.

In October 2025, Delhi HC issued summons to a spouse's lover for compensation for interference in marriage and causing loss of affection and companionship between spouses on basis of a foreign tort (civil wrong) Alienation of Affection which was REPEALED in England in 1970.

The judge fell for populism and failed to apply his mind to the question that had there been affection and love, it was impossible for a third person to enter the marriage. Extra marital relations are mostly an effect of bad marriage and not cause. Govt and courts must stop taking the divorcing spouse as gullible or wanton. People are reasonable and it is for them to decide what is best for them. Everyone has a right to happiness and forcing people in toxic marriages is a state-sponsored misery. There's immediate need to review divorce laws and timelines.

The writer practices law at Supreme Court @SeemaSindhu

HC asks Delhi Government to explain why chairman, member posts vacant in minority panel since 2023

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has asked the city Government to explain why vacancies in the posts of chairman and members in the Delhi State Minorities Commission have not been filled since 2023.

A bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia observed that merely because the law stipulates that vacancies must be filled "as soon as may be", the posts cannot be "kept vacant perennially", and asked the authorities to initiate the appointment process.

It also directed the Delhi



Government to file an affidavit disclosing the steps taken and the timeline within which the vacancies in the Commission would be filled.

The court passed the order on April 22 on a public

interest litigation filed by Salek Chand Jain.

The petitioner's counsel stated that since August 24, 2023, no one has been occupying the posts of chairman and members in the

Commission. Issuing a notice to the Delhi Government on the petition, the court said, "We call upon the respondent, GNCTD, to file an affidavit to be sworn by an appropriate officer, who shall not be below the rank of principal secretary/additional chief secretary, to explain as to why the vacancies in the Commission have not been filled in since August 24, 2023."

"The averments made in the writ petition are to the effect that neither any member nor the chairperson has been appointed in the Commission from August 24, 2023 till date, which is quite a long period.

Parrots are wild animals, rules HC; orders Maharashtra Government to compensate farmer for crop damage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nagpur

The Bombay High Court has ordered the Maharashtra Government to compensate a farmer for pomegranate trees damaged by parrots, ruling the birds are "wild animals" under the Wild Life (Protection) Act and the state must reimburse citizens for losses caused by its property.

The Nagpur bench of Justices Urmila Joshi-Phalke and Nivedita Mehta noted that if farmers are not compensated for losses caused by protected species, they might resort to measures that harm wildlife, thus defeating the very purpose of the Act, which explicitly covers parrots.

A copy of the order passed on April 24 was made available on Sunday.



The court passed the order on a petition filed by Mahadeo Dekate (70), a farmer from Hingi village in Wardha district, who claimed that his pomegranate trees were damaged by wild parrots from the nearby wildlife sanctuary in May 2016, and sought compensation for the same.

The court has ordered the Government to pay Rs 200 per tree for damages caused to 200 trees. The State Government opposed the plea, claiming that Government resolutions issued in the past stated that compensation can be granted only when wild elephants and bison damage fruit-bearing trees.

The court, however, refused to accept this contention, pointing out that the objective of issuing such resolutions was to compensate affected farmers for losses they suffered. "When such an objective has been expounded, it makes no sense to consider loss caused only by a few species of wild animals and ignore the loss caused by other species of wild animals for the purpose of payment of compensation," it stated.

Panel suggests safer fireworks patterns after Mundathikode blast

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

Justice CN Ramachandran, heading the judicial commission probing the explosion at a fireworks manufacturing unit in Mundathikode in Thrissur district, on Sunday said changes in fireworks patterns should be considered to improve safety and reduce the severity of such accidents. Speaking to reporters at his residence here, the retired Kerala High Court judge said the commission would hold discussions with the Thrissur District Police Chief and the District Collector as part of the inquiry.

"Apart from that, we will visit the injured persons and the place where the explosions took place," he said.

Ramachandran said the Government was not looking to prohibit fireworks, but to make them safer.

"If the Government wants to prohibit fireworks, it can enact a law for that. Even after fireworks mishaps, they continue to take place. So I am not aware of any move on the part of the state Government to prohibit fireworks," he said. He said modifications in fireworks displays could help reduce risks.

"The fireworks pattern



has to be changed. By making it more of a light show, accidents can be reduced. At least the gravity of such accidents can be reduced," he said.

Following the 2016 Puttungal temple fireworks tragedy, in which 110 people were killed, the state Government had constituted a judicial commission led by Justice PS Gopinathan, which later submitted its report.

Opposition parties have criticised the Government for not yet implementing the Justice Gopinathan Commission's recommendations. Multiple explosions occurred on April 21 at Mundathikode while fireworks for the Thiruvambady Devaswom, as part of the Thrissur Pooram, were being manufactured.

Of the 38 people believed to have been present at the site, 15 have died, while four remain missing.

HC fines man ₹15 lakh for hiding facts in maintenance case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has dismissed a petition filed by an advocate seeking expeditious disposal of a maintenance case against his wife, terming the litigation "vexatious" and "born out of pretences".

Justice Vinod Diwakar imposed a compensatory cost of ₹15 lakh on the petitioner-husband for suppressing material facts in his affidavits and subjecting his wife to systemic depletion.

The court observed that the man, an able-bodied practising advocate, had not only concealed a prior maintenance order in his favour, but also diverted substantial personal loans taken by his wife for his own "luxurious life" and "alcoholic drinks".

According to the facts of the case, the petitioner and the respondent were married on May 18, 2019. At the time, both were preparing for competitive examinations. Shortly after, the wife secured a job



as an additional private secretary in the Allahabad High Court, while the petitioner, despite being a law graduate and a registered advocate, remained unemployed.

Soon disputes arose, leading to multiple litigations. The husband filed a maintenance application before a principal judge in the family court in Etawah.

He then approached the High Court with a prayer to expedite the proceedings, claiming that he had no independent source of income for survival.

It was submitted on behalf of the wife that on November 10, 2020, her husband took a personal loan of ₹11.50 lakh from her salary account in the SBI having a branch in the Lucknow bench of the High Court by "fraudulently" taking her into confidence on a false promise to purchase a plot of land.

On October 6, 2022, the petitioner again took a personal loan of ₹13.56 lakh to be repaid in six years from the respondent's salary account in the Jhalwa branch of the SBI in Prayagraj.

The respondent-wife has been paying a monthly EMI of ₹26,020 since then, which she will pay till October, 2028.

According to the respondent, the loan was taken under the guise of purchasing a plot, but the petitioner fraudulently kept transferring the loan amount into his personal account through UPI and exhausted it on alcoholic drinks, luxurious lifestyle, and other nefarious activities.

It was also argued that "fed up by the petitioner, the wife filed a divorce petition, and on May 20, 2025, her husband filed an application for maintenance based on concocted and false averments".

Allowing the application, the family court on September 15, 2025, directed the wife to pay ₹5,000 per month as interim maintenance and ₹10,000 towards litigation expenses. Challenging the order, the wife filed a review application, which is pending before the family court in Prayagraj.

Editor's TAKE

AAP's moment of reckoning

The defection of seven Rajya Sabha MPs from the AAP raises serious questions about its leadership, internal cohesion, and the limits of anti-defection framework

Aam Aadmi Party that had a meteoric rise is now facing its worst existential crisis. The party that claimed inclusivity and ideological cohesion is splitting down the middle. What began with the rebellion of its Rajya Sabha member Raghav Chaddha who eventually joined the Bharatiya Janata Party has snowballed into an enmass defection in Rajya Sabha eroding its prestige and parliament presence. The defection of seven Rajya Sabha MPs from the Aam Aadmi Party to the Bharatiya Janata Party has triggered more than a political embarrassment—it has exposed the vulnerability of AAP. For a movement born out of anti-corruption protests and positioned as an alternative to entrenched political culture, AAP has increasingly shown that the rank and file of the party are not happy with the party leadership which is being accused of adopting autocratic-style of functioning. The defection of AAP MPs enmass also triggers a constitutional situation and big question being asked is if the anti-defection law applies to these seven MPs and should they be disqualified? The immediate battle now shifts to the office of C. P. Radhakrishnan, where AAP plans to seek disqualification of the defecting MPs. The party's argument leans on the sanctity of the Tenth Schedule of the Indian Constitution, asserting that any defection—regardless of numbers – is unconstitutional. However, the defectors have thought it through. If two-third of the MPs defect then it is not defection but a “merger.” So AAP may not be able to disqualify these seven MPs as they are constitute more than two third of MPs of AAP's 10 MPs in the Rajya Sabha. This is not merely a legal contest; it is a political reality check. AAP's leadership, including figures like Sanjay Singh and Bhagwant Mann, has framed the defections as coercive and unethical. Yet, voices from within the breakaway faction tell a different story – one of alienation, inaccessibility of leadership, and dissatisfaction with governance, particularly in Punjab. Allegations of marginalisation of key leaders and the concentration of decision-making suggest deeper organisational fissures. The crisis, therefore, is not sudden; it is symptomatic. AAP's rapid rise—from Delhi to Punjab—created a structure that is still fragile and vulnerable. What lies ahead for AAP is a test of political maturity. The party can choose to treat this as an external sabotage, or it can confront uncomfortable internal truths. Rebuilding trust within its ranks, decentralising leadership, and addressing governance concerns—especially in Punjab—will be crucial. The alternative is a slow erosion of credibility. The larger lesson extends beyond one party. India's anti-defection framework, conceived to ensure stability, has paradoxically legitimised large-scale defections. It punishes the lone dissenter but rewards the organised rebellion. Until this contradiction is addressed, such political migrations will remain a recurring feature. Besides, it is also a telling reflection of the declining standards of Indian democracy, where money and coercion are deployed by ruling parties to fracture the Opposition—a situation that warrants a serious rethink on the limits of morality and the high standards that once defined Indian politics.

Japan: The Rise of a New Security State

Strategic anxieties over China's rise, North Korea's provocations, and shifting Indo-Pacific alliances are pushing the country toward a more assertive military role—despite deep public resistance

SANTHOSH MATHEW

A nation that once renounced war now stands at the edge of rewriting its identity. Japan, shaped by the ashes of World War II, built its global reputation on peace, restraint, and constitutional idealism. Today, that very foundation is shifting. The winds of change blowing through Tokyo signal more than a policy adjustment. They point to a historic turning point that could redefine Asia's security landscape. Japan's Parliament, the Diet, has moved closer to approving changes to its pacifist Constitution. Both chambers—the House of Councillors and the House of Representatives—support the move. Public sentiment tells a different story. Surveys conducted by Kyodo News reveal that nearly 80 per cent of Japanese citizens oppose amending the country's Constitution. A deep divide has emerged between the political leadership and the people. At the centre of this debate stands Article 9, a clause born out of unimaginable destruction. The atomic bombings of Hiroshima bombing and Nagasaki bombing forced Japan into a moral reckoning. The Constitution that followed rejected war as a sovereign right and ruled out the maintenance of military forces for the purpose of combat. Article 9 became more than a law. It became a symbol of hope in a war-torn world. Japan's strategic environment has transformed rapidly. The rise of China as a global power has altered regional dynamics. Maritime disputes in the South China Sea continue to intensify. North Korea keeps the region on edge with missile developments. These realities shape the arguments of those calling for constitutional revision. Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi and her allies present a clear case. They argue that Japan must build stronger defence capabilities to protect its sovereignty and contribute to regional stability. Their vision includes transforming Japan's Self-Defence Forces into a more conventional military. The language of deterrence now replaces the language of restraint. A stronger Japanese military presence could trigger an arms race across East and Southeast Asia. Joint military exercises involving Japan, the United States, and the Philippines near Luzon highlight a growing security alignment. The Indo-Pacific region begins to resemble a high-stakes arena where alliances deepen and rivalries sharpen. The phrase “roller coaster relations” captures the uncertainty shaping the region. Economic factors add another layer to this transformation. Japan once dominated the global economy. In 1994, it accounted for 17.8 per cent of global GDP. That share now stands near 3.4 percent. China, in contrast, has surged to nearly 19 per cent. This dramatic shift fuels concerns about national decline and global influence. Inside Japan, structural challenges continue to mount. The country faces an aging population and a declining birth rate of around 1.2. Public debt exceeds 200 per cent of GDP. Industries struggle to maintain growth. These pressures shape the national mood. Increased defense spending, now nearing 2 percent of GDP, places additional strain on public finances. Budget cuts in healthcare, education, and welfare have sparked protests across the country. The alliance with the United States plays a decisive role in Japan's strategic thinking. Washington views a stronger Japan as vital to maintaining balance in the Indo-Pacific. Military cooperation between the two nations continues to expand. American bases across Japan, including those in Okinawa, form a critical part of this partnership. This relationship shapes Japan's evolving defence posture. A more capable Japanese military supports broader efforts to counterbalance China's growing influence. The Indo-Pacific strategy of the United States depends on reliable regional partners. Japan fits that role with its technological strength and strategic location. The devastation caused by nuclear warfare left scars that have not faded. More than 300,000 people lost their lives in the atomic bombings. Survivors, known as Hibakusha, endured decades of suffering due to radiation exposure. Their stories continue to serve as powerful reminders of war's human cost. The global movement for nuclear disarmament drew inspiration from Japan's experience. Thinkers such as Bertrand Russell and scientists like J. Robert Oppenheimer reflected deeply on the consequences of atomic weapons. Oppenheimer's recollection of a verse from the Bhagavad Gita during the first nuclear test captured the enormity of that moment. The decision to allow arms exports marks a significant policy shift. Advanced military equipment, including warships, fighter jets, drones, and missiles, will now be supplied to partner nations. Seventeen countries stand to benefit from these exports in the initial phase. This move reflects Japan's willingness to play a more active role in global security. Countries aligned with Japan welcome its new approach. The Quad grouping—comprising the United States, India, Australia, and Japan—views this shift as strengthening regional stability. China and North Korea interpret it as a sign of containment and respond with caution. Southeast Asia emerges as a potential flashpoint. Territorial disputes, maritime tensions, and military build-ups converge in this region. Japan's growing involvement could influence the balance of power. The next theatre of war may well take shape in these contested waters. One path preserves the spirit of Article 9 and the moral authority it represents. The other embraces a more assertive role in global security. Both paths carry risks and opportunities. The choices made in Tokyo will resonate far beyond its borders. The idea of a “frozen peace” no longer holds. The calm that defined East Asia for decades begins to shift. Strategic competition intensifies. Military preparedness gains importance. Diplomatic engagement continues, though under increasing strain. The end of Article 9, if it arrives, will mark more than a constitutional change. It will signal the transformation of Japan from a pacifist state into a proactive security player. This transition will reshape alliances, redefine regional dynamics, and influence global stability. A nation that once chose peace above all now prepares to navigate a world where power and security dominate the conversation. The story of Japan enters a new chapter—one filled with uncertainty, ambition, and far-reaching consequences.

The CHOICES MADE IN TOKYO WILL RESONATE FAR BEYOND ITS BORDERS. THE IDEA OF A “FROZEN PEACE” NO LONGER HOLDS. THE CALM THAT DEFINED EAST ASIA FOR DECADES BEGINS TO SHIFT

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PIC TALK

A woman drinks coconut water to beat the heat on a hot summer day, in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh

PHOTO: PTI

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Do systems shape people, or do people shape systems?

SANJAY CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

My recent vacation in Germany left me with a lingering question: do people create systems, or do systems shape people? I wrote earlier about unruly behaviour in public spaces. This time, however, my experiences were not about people, but about systems—specifically, the much-regarded German railway network, Deutsche Bahn (DB). We were to travel from Prague to Berlin by train. Even before we had begun our journey from India, we received an email informing us that our scheduled train had been cancelled. An alternative was suggested, but it was either unavailable or not easily traceable on their website. Eventually, we decided to make the journey by road—a decision that turned out to be fortuitous, allowing us to take in the landscape along the way. For the final leg, from Berlin to Frankfurt, uncertainty con-

tinued. It was only upon reaching the station and checking the display board that we discovered our train would terminate about an hour short of the destination. What followed was a series of hurried adjustments—two train changes, heavy luggage in tow, and the added strain of limited communication with station staff due to language barriers. This was not the railway system I remembered from nearly three decades ago, when punctuality and efficiency were almost synonymous with it. Today, I found that DB had become, in some circles, a subject of quiet humour. These experiences led me to reflect on similar challenges that foreign travellers might face in our own country, particularly when navigating long-distance train journeys. There is much that still needs improvement. And yet, there are examples that point in another direction—instances where systems have not only functioned well, but have set benchmarks. I had the opportunity to be associated with the construction of the Delhi Metro in its early years. Its Managing Director, E. Sreedharan placed unwavering emphasis on punctuality—first in construction, and later in operations. More importantly, this emphasis was not enforced merely through rules, but internalised by the people who worked within the system. Each individual became a custodian of that culture, contributing to what eventually emerged as a world-class transportation network. Even in personal life, he would ask his driver to

continue circling a venue so as not to inconvenience the organizers if he was early. Japan offers another example. On one occasion, a mediator escorting us to a meeting ensured that we reached the vicinity well in advance, but deliberately made us walk around the block so that we would enter the office exactly at the appointed time. His reasoning was simple: arriving early or late would inconvenience the host and disrupt their schedule. Such experiences suggest that systems and people are not independent of each other. Systems may provide structure, but it is people who give them meaning. At the same time, well-designed systems can influence behaviour, nudging individuals towards discipline and consideration. Perhaps the real question, then, is not whether people create systems or systems shape people, but whether we are willing to take responsibility for both. It is easy to attribute failure to institutions and success to individuals, but in reality, each mirrors the other. Systems falter when people disengage, and people drift when systems lose clarity and purpose. If there is to be any lasting improvement, it will come not from expecting one to correct the other, but from recognising that discipline, accountability, and respect must flow in both directions—quietly, consistently, and without exception.

The Pioneer SINCE 1865

The writer is founder of Kala - Krazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

FROM PRAISE TO PUT-DOWN: TIME TO RECLAIM INDIA'S VOICE

Recent remarks by the Donald Trump, calling India a “hellhole,” reflect a troubling inconsistency in tone and diplomacy. Such statements contrast sharply with his earlier praise of India and its leadership, exposing a pattern of transactional engagement rather than genuine respect. This contradiction calls for introspection. A nation of India's stature cannot afford to appear reactive or overly accommodative in its foreign policy. Strategic autonomy must not give way to perceived submission—whether in trade negotiations, defence purchases, or geopolitical positioning. India today stands as a major economic power, yet its global posture often appears hesitant. The gap between aspiration and execution becomes evident when diplomatic signals are mixed or when global crises find India on the margins rather than at the centre. Reclaiming credibility requires a clear, principled foreign policy—one that balances national interest with global responsibility. Economic strength must translate into diplomatic confidence. Empowering domestic demand and leveraging India's vast market can strengthen its negotiating position internationally. India's global image will not be shaped by rhetoric or titles, but by consistency, dignity, and strategic clarity. Moments like these should serve as a wake-up call—to move from symbolic stature to substantive leadership. AG RAJMOHAN | ANANTAPUR

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Migration, citizenship and selective narratives

The claim that “infiltration” has forced Bengalis to migrate for livelihood raises uncomfortable questions about governance and constitutional rights. If such a narrative is to be believed, it implicitly admits failure on the part of the Centre to secure the Indo-Bangladesh border. At the same time, it unfairly stigmatizes ordinary Bengalis for exercising their constitutional right to move and work anywhere in India. Migration is neither new nor exclusive. Gujaratis, for instance, have built thriving communities across India and the world—from West Bengal to East Africa, the UK, and the United States. Their mobility is celebrated as enterprise, not questioned as compulsion. Why then is Bengali migration viewed through a different lens? This selective framing also raises deeper concerns. Is Bengal open to all, while Bengalis face invisible barriers elsewhere? Such thinking undermines the spirit of national unity. Equally troubling is the unresolved issue of Matua citizenship. Promises made before multiple elections remain unfulfilled, despite citizenship being a Central subject. After years of assurances, the delay demands accountability. The debate must move beyond rhetoric. It should reaffirm constitutional freedoms, ensure equal dignity for all communities, and deliver on long-pending commitments. KAJAL CHATTERJEER | KOLKATA

Remembering Pahalgam: Lessons learnt

The memory of the Pahalgam tragedy must translate into concrete measures to ensure tourist safety. One immediate priority is improving infrastructure, particularly the hazardous route from Pahalgam to Baisaran Valley. The narrow, uneven track poses risks that could be mitigated by constructing a wider road or introducing a ropeway, enhancing both safety and accessibility. Security, however, remains paramount. Tourist routes and destinations must be under constant surveillance, with adequate deployment of forces and installation of CCTV systems. Given the threat of attacks, often linked to cross-border terrorism, preventive vigilance cannot be compromised. Administrative measures are equally important. Mandatory registration of tourists, real-time data sharing by hotels, and clear operational protocols can help authorities respond swiftly in emergencies. Additionally, a state-backed insurance mechanism at nominal cost would provide reassurance and financial protection to visitors. Tourism is a vital lifeline for the region's economy, but it cannot thrive without trust. Safety must be treated as a non-negotiable priority. Remembering Pahalgam should not be symbolic—it must lead to systemic reforms that make every visitor feel secure. VINOD JOHRI | DELHI

When public protests disrupt public life

A recent political rally in Mumbai's Worli has reignited the debate over balancing democratic expression with public convenience. Organized in support of women's reservation, the march caused severe traffic congestion, disrupting daily life for countless commuters. The situation escalated when a local resident confronted state minister Girish Mahajan, voicing frustration over the blockade. Her spontaneous protest, widely shared on social media, struck a chord with many citizens who often bear the brunt of such disruptions. Her question was simple yet powerful: why not hold such events in designated open spaces? While both Mahajan and Mumbai mayor Ritu Tawde later apologized, the incident highlights a recurring issue in urban governance. Public demonstrations are essential to democracy, but their planning must account for the realities of densely populated cities. Citizens should not have to choose between democratic participation and daily survival. Authorities must establish clear guidelines to minimize disruption while preserving the right to protest. The episode serves as a reminder that governance is not just about intent, but also about execution—and respect for the everyday lives of ordinary people. BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

From hegemony to contestation: Unraveling of American primacy

From rising geopolitical rivalries to evolving forms of warfare, recent developments have exposed the limits of American supremacy. The question is no longer whether the United States remains powerful, but whether its dominance is giving way to a more complex, contested, and multipolar world



NANI GOPAL MAHANTA

The global order, long anchored in the unquestioned dominance of the United States, is entering a phase of visible transition. What once appeared as an unchallenged hegemony - military, ideological and institutional - is now being contested across regions and theatres of conflict. Recent developments in West Asia, particularly involving Iran and the United States, have brought this shift into sharp relief. The central question, therefore, is not whether American power remains significant, it clearly does, but whether its supremacy is beginning to retreat and transform into a more contested form of influence.

For decades, American global leadership rested on two pillars: strategic doctrine and ideological conviction. The Monroe Doctrine, originally confined to the Western Hemisphere, gradually expanded in spirit to justify a broader global role, especially after the Second World War. Alongside this was the idea of American exceptionalism, the belief that the United States represents the highest culmination of liberty, democracy and freedom, and therefore carries a unique responsibility to lead the world. However, recent events suggest that both these pillars are under strain.

There is a misalignment between the strategic goals of the United States and its ability to project power, given the relative decline in its economy and the rise of peer competitors. An overextension of American power occurred due to the expansion of military campaigns since 2001, alongside a cut in defence spending, nuclear capability and shipbuilding capacity. The wars, government bailouts and the stimulus response to the pandemic also drove the long-term sovereign debt of the country upwards. These challenges were also compounded with a de-industrialisation phase, leading to the closing down of jobs in the manufacturing sector domestically, affecting many of the Rust Belt communities. While America floundered, rival powers emerged as tough competitors, including a brazen China, an emboldened Russia, alongside threats from North Korea and Iran. Given the consequences of its recent military, economic and industrial policy choices, the US faces a problem identified as 'simultaneity' by the Pentagon - the possibility of war on multiple fronts without American capability to handle them.

Given these issues confronting the US, attempts to assert dominance through unilateral approaches have, instead of consolidating influence as has been the case in recent decades, exposed its vulnerabilities. The aura of inevitability that once surrounded American leadership is weakening, revealing gaps between perception and reality. The ideological claim of universal acceptance is also being challenged, as more regions assert their own political and cultural autonomy.

Nowhere is this shift more evident than in West Asia, a region where the United States has historically functioned as the principal security provider. Since the mid-20th century, American military presence and alliances have underwritten the stability of several Gulf nations, positioning Washington as an indispensable "umbrella power." Yet, recent confrontations have begun to challenge this assumption.

Iran's demonstrated ability to target American military installations and strategic assets in the region has exposed limitations in the United States' capacity to guarantee security. The long-held perception of America as an unassailable protector is no longer taken for granted. Regional actors are increasingly aware that reliance on a single external power may not ensure stability in an era of shifting geopolitical dynamics. A crucial dimension of this transformation lies in the emergence of a new form of warfare. Iran's strategy reflects a sophisticated model of asymmetrical warfare, combining decentralisation with adaptability. Instead of relying solely on conventional, centralised military operations, it has adopted a networked approach, deploying relatively low-cost technologies such as drones and missiles while simultaneously expanding the theatre of engagement.

This dual strategy of vertical and horizontal has redefined conflict. Vertical strikes enable targeted attacks on critical infrastructure, while horizontal operations extend the battlefield to actors and locations previously considered peripheral. The result is a dispersed and unpredictable mode of warfare that challenges traditional



assumptions about military superiority. It demonstrates that dominance is no longer determined solely by scale of resources, but by innovation, flexibility and strategic depth. In many ways, the present moment appears to echo Samuel Huntington's influential thesis of the "Clash of Civilizations." Huntington had argued that in the post-Cold War era, the primary source of conflict would shift from ideological rivalries to cultural and civilizational divides. He also cautioned that the West's belief in the universality of its values could provoke resistance from non-Western societies.

What we are witnessing today, particularly in West Asia, reflects elements of this tension: not merely as a clash of arms, but as a deeper contest over legitimacy, identity and global order. The resistance to externally imposed frameworks, the assertion of cultural and political autonomy, and the challenge to Western dominance resonate with Huntington's core argument.

Yet, the current reality is more complex than a simple civilizational binary. The emerging conflicts cut across alliances and geographies, involving actors that do not neatly fit into fixed categories. The situation suggests not just a clash of civilizations, but a fragmentation of the very idea of cohesive civilizational blocs, shaped by shifting interests, technologies and strategic alignments.

Another critical development is the fracturing within the Western alliance system itself. For decades, institutions like NATO, supported by strong transatlantic ties, formed the backbone of American-led global order. However, recent divergences between the United States and its European partners indicate a growing lack of cohesion. Statements questioning NATO's role and Europe's cautious response to certain American positions during the Iran war point to an evolving dissonance within the alliance. This weakening of collective alignment has significant implications. It reduces the amplifying effect that alliances once provided to American power and opens space for alternative centres of influence to emerge. When the foundational structures of a hegemonic system begin to show strain, the system itself enters a phase of recalibration.

At the same time, the notion of de-escalation in the current context remains uncertain. While diplomatic language may suggest restraint, developments on the ground indicate continued volatility. Both sides appear unwilling to concede strategic ground. Incidents such as targeted strikes, interception of vessels and retaliatory actions suggest that the conflict remains active, even if its intensity fluctuates. The situation around the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most critical energy corridors, further reinforces this instability. Its periodic disruption highlights how regional tensions can have immediate global consequences. In such a scenario, even limited confrontations carry the potential for broader economic and geopolitical impact.

Taken together, these developments point towards a reconfiguration of global power dynamics. The United States remains a formidable force, with unmatched military capabilities and significant economic and technological strength. However, its dominance is no longer absolute or uncontested. Given these conditions that the US is faced with, what is inevitably emerging is a more multipolar and fluid world order, where power is distributed across multiple actors and constantly negotiated. Regional players are asserting themselves with greater confidence, new forms of warfare are altering strategic calculations, and traditional alliances are being redefined.

The question, therefore, is not whether American supremacy is ending, but whether it is transforming into a more contested and negotiated form of influence. In that transformation lies the outline of a new global order, one defined less by singular dominance and more by complexity, competition and continual recalibration. Essentially this changing global order, where US hegemony is on the decline, presents a new set of challenges and opportunities for the global south particularly for India. Given the depth of India - US relations, and New Delhi relations with Iran, India's balancing act will be tested.



WITH THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ EFFECTIVELY A BATTLEFIELD, BRENT CRUDE HAS SPIKED TO \$115 PER BARREL, WITH PROJECTIONS REACHING \$130 IF THE BLOCKADE PERSISTS THROUGH THE SUMMER

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Challenges before the new chief minister Of Bihar



SUBODH KUMAR MEHTA

Atal Bihari Vajpayee's critical decision to back Nitish Kumar as the Chief Minister of Bihar in 1999-2000 was a strategic vision to dislodge the political dominance of Rashtriya Janata Dal in Bihar. The intent to combine the organisational strength of the BJP with the Administrative skills of Nitish Kumar, who happens to be from the Kurmi caste, which was part of Triveni Sangh Movement (Yadav, Koiri, Kurmi) . This Movement was started in 1933 for social empowerment and to remove the social evils and dominating structural norms of the society that was prevalence at that time. Atal Bihari Vajpayee faith in Nitish Kumar has brought fruitful results for the Bharatiya Janata Party in Bihar. After a long political struggle, the BJP has succeeded in installing Samrat Chaudhary as the 24th Chief Minister of Bihar. After 1990, the constituents of the Triveni Sangh Movement have dominated the state's politics of North India, and Bihar is not an exception.

The new Chief Minister has immense challenges in front of him as he has to carry forward the social investment along with economic development. The processes of democratisation of democracy will test his ability to incorporate the aspirations of weaker sections of society as a part of decision-making processes. The contemporary situation in Bihar demands major reconstruction in the form of policies and institutional perceptions so that the trust deficit between the government and people can be overcome. To begin with, the first demand, Samrat Chaudhary must carry forward economic participation along with social transformation and political participation. These demands are the result of the piecemeal "social engineering".

The second demand is to tackle the consequences created by the federal policies of pre- and post-Independent India. The policies include Permanent settlement, high land revenue, forced commercialisation (cash crops), fright equalization policy, New Economic Policies, which helped the developed states to grow faster, and Bihar faced the collapse of local industries. Due to these policy Bihar also faced inadequate infrastructure, which resulted in stagnant and weak institutional development.

These factors helped develop states, and Bihar lagged in benefiting from the New Economy Policy. These federal policies left peasants landless, trapped in debt, forced into low-paid agriculture and Migration. These policies has great side effects on Education, Health, Agriculture, Employment, and governance.

The planning commission aimed to plan India evenly, but this aim did not bring desirable results. India witnessed uneven development in different parts of India. The state, which was at the bottom of the development ladder at the time of independence still stagnating at the bottom of the Development Indexes. The task posed by these policies can only be tackled by a harmonious relationship with the central government. It's a great opportunity for Samrat Chaudhary to bargain for big projects and special economic packages to uplift the demography of one of the youngest states of India. We all know that Bihar stands at the bottom of the ladder in the Human Development Index and various other parameters of Niti Aayog and State Development Index.

The third demand is from the minority class to inculcate a sense of security so that they feel secure and their right to life and liberty is protected. Minorities in the last 35 years in Bihar have felt secure, this trust should not take a back seat. Thus, Samrat Chaudhary must develop a cautious approach towards minorities so that trust-building measures can help society in building harmonious relations amongst different groups. Moreover, the fourth demand is to restore the long-standing stagnating institutional crisis in the social sector that crippled the Health care, Education and Empowerment. The fifth, most crucial demand is to improve the financial capabilities of the state by reducing the high debt burden, as the state's public debt has risen sharply in recent years. As Bihar continues to depend heavily on central funds and the transfer of money.

New avenues must be created to generate adequate own tax revenue and should tackle the deficit through fiscal management. The sixth, demand has been brought by the leader of opposition Shri Tejaswi Yadav in the form need for institutional reform in the field of 'Education, Health, Empowerment, Agriculture and Governance. On all these parameters, Bihar has continuously lagged. The need of the hour is to reconstruct these sectors. The seventh demand is for farmers as they have the least income compared to farmers from different states.

The Agriculture Sector needs drastic steps so that the Primary Sector can become the fulcrum for development. The other demands include tackling floods in the Kosi belt, maintenance of law and order, police reforms, eradication of Corruption at various levels of state departments, programs like Satt Nishchay, building urban infrastructure, enhancing purchasing power of the masses, creating tourism infrastructure, social reform and women empowerment are the needs of the hour. Bihar should develop a political culture so that citizens can develop both Political inputs (Voting, lobbying) and Political outputs (Policy, Government Services). The present government must understand that Bihar should carry forward the objective of 'socially comprehensive development' along with the development of market mechanisms. This can only be done by strengthening the weak institutions. If steps are not taken in this direction speedily enough, then a state that John Houlton described as being 'the heart of India' will die unsung.

It is up to the new CM Samrat Chaudhary and his abilities to uphold the Gandhian vision that is the true objective of Democracy is that the weakest should have the same opportunity as the strongest.



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PRAFUL KUMAR SINGH

The Resolve to End Naxalism Becomes Reality *Praful Kumar Singh* A new chapter has been written in the history of India's internal security. Under Union Home Minister Amit Shah's policy of "zero tolerance" and his time-bound commitment to eliminate Naxalism, this long-standing challenge is now turning into a reality. Since assuming office, Amit Shah has pursued a dual strategy of "decisive action" and "inclusive development" to tackle Naxalism. He made it clear that Naxalism is not merely a law-and-order issue, but one of the greatest obstacles in the path of democracy. A key pillar of his strategy has been the establishment of security camps in areas once considered strongholds and safe havens for Naxal groups. The Ministry of Home Affairs has set up more than 330 new security camps in the remote regions of Chhattisgarh.

These camps have effectively restricted the free movement of Naxal elements and provided a significant strategic advantage to security forces. To weaken the Naxal

network, its funding mechanisms were specifically targeted. Central agencies such as the National Investigation Agency (NIA) and the Enforcement Directorate (ED) launched stringent action against levy collection networks and the so-called urban Naxal ecosystem. This crackdown severely disrupted their logistics and eliminated their ability to procure modern weapons. The government also granted operational freedom to security forces, resulting in a record number of Naxals being neutralised in encounters between 2024 and March 2026. Several high-value commanders were among those eliminated, leading to a near-total collapse of the Naxal leadership structure. From the beginning of 2024 to March 2026, more than 700 Naxals were killed, including hardened Maoists who had long symbolised terror in affected regions. Encouraged by the government's liberal rehabilitation policy, nearly 5,000 Naxals surrendered and chose to join the mainstream.

Additionally, over 2,200 Naxals and their associates were brought within the ambit of the law. Union Home Minister Amit Shah, soon after the formation of the BJP government in Chhattisgarh, laid out a comprehensive roadmap to make India Naxal-free by December 2025 in his very first meeting on January 21, 2024. This vision was formally articulated during his visit to the state in August 2024, when he announced



the target of ending Naxalism by March 31, 2026. To achieve this, the Union Home Minister directed the Chhattisgarh government to formulate a dedicated rehabilitation policy for Naxals, aimed at encouraging large-scale surrenders. In this regard, the 'Niyad Nellanar' (Your Good Village) initiative of the Vishnu Deo Sai government in Chhattisgarh proved to be a game-changer. Under this scheme, villages located within a 5-kilometre radius of security camps were connected with essential infrastructure such as roads, electricity, clean drinking water, ration

shops, and healthcare centres.

As villagers began to realise that the camps were meant to deliver development rather than repression, the Naxals rapidly lost their grassroots support base. At the same time, improved coordination was ensured between the state police and central armed police forces such as the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), Border Security Force (BSF), and Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), further strengthening the effectiveness of anti-Naxal operations. The government did not rely solely on the use of force; it also kept the door open for reform for "misguided youth."

For Naxalites who chose to surrender, the Chhattisgarh government implemented one of the most attractive rehabilitation policies in the country. Surrendered cadres were provided immediate financial assistance, land to build homes, free education, and skill development training.

Today, many former Naxals in Bastar are running small businesses or practicing agriculture, leading lives of dignity. The greatest beneficiaries of the end of Naxalism have been the tribal communities of Bastar. After four decades, schools are now functioning without fear in areas like Abujmad. Roads that had remained closed for decades are now reconnecting villages with towns.

Bastar is shedding its identity as part of the "Red Corridor" and is emerging as a hub of

tourism and art. Products like "Bastar Coffee" and "Dhokra Art" are now reaching global markets. The impact of rehabilitation efforts is also visible in social acceptance, as communities are embracing those who have surrendered. Women in Bastar who once carried weapons are now setting examples of self-reliance by running initiatives like "Bastar Cafe." Many former Naxals have even joined local security forces and are now protecting their own communities. Those who once waged war against the state are today part of the mainstream of development, working under the tricolour.

The visionary strategy of Amit Shah and the resolute, strong-willed leadership of Vishnu Deo Sai have demonstrated that with genuine coordination between the Centre and the State, even the country's most formidable internal security challenge can be eradicated from its roots.

March 31, 2026, has been etched in India's history as a landmark day of "freedom from terror." This is not merely a military victory, but a triumph of democracy, a victory of development, and a moment of justice for thousands of families who lost their loved ones to Naxal violence.

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BLASÉ CAPITAL

INDIA DOWN, ASIA UP

In a matter of days, two renowned brokerage houses have downgraded Indian equities, one to ‘neutral,’ and other from neutral to ‘underweight.’ In contrast, both contend that other Asian markets, specifically Taiwan, offer better odds and better bets. In the case of HSBC, the dragging down to underweight was the second cut in less than a month. In the case of JP Morgan, Taiwan offers the best opportunity, and other Asian and Latin American peers such as China, Brazil, and South Korea offer cheaper and exciting entry points. Of course, macroeconomics matters, as the risks of persistent inflation and slow growth in India “most closely resemble another bout of stagflation,” according to JP Morgan. In its note, HSBC stated that the Indian economy looks “less attractive” than North Asian peers in the “current macro setting,” with crude oil above \$100 a barrel, and the global prices up more than 40 per cent since the Iran war. In effect, the Nifty 50 and Sensex were the worst performing indices this year.

Obviously, this downturn in the Indian indices and equities must have made them more attractive, with cheaper valuations. But neither HSBC nor JP Morgan look at them in such a manner. Despite the deep corrections from their peaks, Indian stocks may appear more expensive than the global alternatives to HSBC as the downgrades of the corporate earnings continue to filter through over the next quarter. Indeed, they will be expensive, even at lower values, due to lower earnings. JP Morgan feels the same way. Indian premiums despite the moderation remain high. Although “India’s premium to MSCI EM (emerging markets) has compressed to 65 per cent... but peers... still offer cheaper entry points” and, hence, wider chances for profits. For the calendar years 2026 and 2027, JP Morgan lowered the collective India’s earnings per share growth to 11-13 per cent, as “energy supply disruptions are likely to pressure earnings through multiple channels.” HSBC believes that a 20 per cent hike in global crude prices knocks off 1.5 percentage points in India’s earnings growth.

In the JP Morgan calculations, technology has emerged as a crucial differentiator between India and Asian peers. The AI momentum has strengthened across Asia, and Asian AI stocks gained sharp acceleration in the recent past. Thus, the nations, or firms within a nation that adopt and adapt AI faster will see “improving developments around model capabilities” that will “raise future growth trajectory.” While this is true of many Asian nations, especially Taiwan, India lags. “India’s large-cap index has minimal AI, data centre, and semiconductor representation,” states JP Morgan. In addition, most of the recent IPOs (Initial Public Offerings) were mostly offer-for-sale issues that allowed profitable stake sales, and diluted holdings for large, existing investors.

It did not add to the internal resources for the start-ups, and new-age firms to scale up, and adopt AI and other technologies. What one witnesses among the large-caps in India are trends such as heavy issuance of equity for attractive exits, and limited exposure to the emerging sectors. Despite the talk of policy AI, the corporate AI ecosystem is weak, and yet to evolve and develop as in China and Taiwan.

Several brokerage houses are concerned about the ongoing, sometimes huge, net outflows of foreign money. According to HSBC, foreigners took out \$18.5 billion out of Indian equities in 2026, within four months or so, and withdrew an equivalent \$18.9 billion in the entire 2025. As JP Morgan states, “India’s structural growth story remains strong,” supported as it is by policy reforms, capex push, and manufacturing growth, but the short-term plot is more like an anti-climax. At present, other emerging markets are ripe for better returns, especially in technology-driven nations.

In the future, AI-led growth will shape up the economic destinies, and India will need to lead from the front. Ironically as it may sound, India mutual funds, which are focused on US tech stocks, have shown dramatic returns, even as the Indian indices slumped, largely due to their exposure to AI and tech stocks. However, most of the initiatives in Indian AI are seemingly-led by hardware, like data centres, which are capital-intensive, and require years. The software-led AI has faltered, as is evident from the falling stock prices of renowned Indian IT firms, and their chaotic earning guidance.

Despite the recent reports, it is not easy to write off Indian stock markets, or Indian equities. In the recent past, especially after the pandemic, Indian indices have shown resilience, and provided massive opportunities for attractive returns across large-caps, midcaps, and small-caps. Even the penny stocks have generated large profits.

The ability of the Indian stocks to bounce back, quite fast, and without any warnings, is remarkable. So do not be surprised if the Indian indices shoot up as soon as the Iran war is over, and especially after India and the US ink a mutually-beneficial bilateral trade pact. The combination will act like a volatile mix, which will take stock prices through the roof. The likes of JP Morgan and HSBC may need to update their reports and notes, maybe by May, or maximum by July, and upgrade India, maybe not once but twice within a few months.

The Pioneer

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BUSINESS

10

Iran’s checkmate in two moves?

Chess moves related to a secret letter, Trump’s confident claim

Finally, after a round of talks, and another one of failed discussions, the US President Donald Trump asked his officials to walk out, or rather not engage with Iran or Pakistan. He felt that there was no point in going back and forth, without an agenda, and Iran could always “call” if it wanted to come to the peace table. His confidence stems from a feeling that the Iranian leaders were “fighting like cats and dogs” among themselves to end the ongoing war. Trump’s view gains credence after reports of a secret letter surfaced in the media.

According to the letter, purportedly written by senior Iranian figures, which include the current prime minister and foreign minister, the leaders urged Mojtaba Khamenei, the son of the late Supreme Leader, to negotiate with the US, and end the conflict. The prime reason: The country’s economic situation was “severe and unsustainable.” The strain on the people and masses did not justify a war, which did not allow either side to retreat with its head held high. Hence, negotiations on the nuclear issue, as desired by the US, was a safer way out.

Immediately, three reactions emanated from Tehran once the contents of the letter went public. The first was, obviously, to dub it as “absurd and baseless.” The second was to define, or redefine the war as a national priority, rather than a fight on ideological issues. “In Iran, there are no hardliners or moderates. We are all Iranian, and revolutionary,” said one of the leaders, who was featured as one of signatories of the letter. Third, a warning was issued to the citizens to inculcate a sense of fear. A leak of ‘classified correspondence’ carried ‘severe legal consequences,’ which included jail of 10 years.

If Trump, and contents of the secret letter are to be believed, Iran’s economy, which was already under pressure in the pre-war period due to excessive sanctions, has begun to crumble because of the new American blockade on Kharg Island. The blockade, which is a counter to Iran’s attacks on the Strait of Hormuz, is aimed to shut down the exports of Iran’s crude oil, even as Iran disrupts global supplies. In chess parlance, the US move may have led to an ‘Armageddon game,’ which is guaranteed to produce a decisive result.

Despite Tehran’s expertise in smuggling oil across the high seas, as it did during the pre-war sanctions-led era, the heavy presence of the American Navy has limited the options. Or so it would seem from the secret letter. In response to the unsafe Strait, global suppliers have re-routed oil through alternate routes, and managed to push through a quarter or more of the oil that earlier flowed through this choke point. Consumers have reconciled to higher prices, restricted energy use, and found alternatives to the Middle-East suppliers. As we have repeatedly maintained, it is a case of who blinks first, the US or Iran?

Several experts draw the similarities between 2026 and 1988. In the latter year, during the final phase of the long-drawn-out Iran-Iraq war, “senior Iranian officials urged the then Supreme Leader, Ruhollah Khomeini, to accept a ceasefire, warning that the war was unsustainable.” Finally, under internal pressure, Khomeini, who wanted to continue the war, accepted a resolution of the United Nations Security Council, which ended the conflict.

However, the primary difference is the time

period. The war with Iraq dragged on for years. The current one with the US is not even a month-old.

Another difference is that while both Iran and Iraq were economically ruined in 1988, both sides claimed economic victories in 2026, after having repeatedly claimed military ones. Reports emanating from the US talk about the retail prices of petrol, which have inched up, and fears of inflation over the next few months. While petrol is up by a dollar per gallon, jet fuel is up by two dollars. The period of high prices is uncomfortably and scarily close to the forthcoming midterm elections in November. Hence, Trump wishes a peaceful reconciliation, of whatever

form, much before the elections to woo the voters.

Some experts indicate that in this war of military and economic attrition, Iran is likely to buckle faster than the US. According to one of them, “The clock is much faster on Iran’s economy side....” More importantly, unlike most leaders, Trump is willing to go further to bring Iran to its knees, although his clock is running only a bit slower, as he has a few months before a political crisis point in August or September. Indeed, Iran’s blockade of the Strait costs it \$500 million in lost exports, and the costs of the American ‘Kharg’ blockade may be higher.

Looking beyond growth, inflation, and energy costs, an analyst contends that Iran’s stock market is closed for eight weeks, which is an “unprecedented development.” This allows the leaders and policy-makers to live in a make-believe world that things are normal. But, in reality, the war “changed the value of companies, assets, and investor expectations.”

The stock market was in a crisis before the war, and the situation is worse “even though nominal gains had masked the impact of inflation above 70 per cent.” Banking was in shambles, and so were critical sectors like energy, petrochemicals, auto, and steel.

Of course, what Tehran will calculate are the pros and cons of war, or rather peace. Sustained war is not an option, unless Trump backs off, which he refuses to do. Peace is not a complete solution, as past experiences prove. Some experts indicate that the 2015 peace with the US facilitated global banking but only on paper. Banks refused to touch Iran’s money, and this was a case “not just (with) US banks, but little, tiny banks without any corresponding relationship with US banks.” In effect, Iran “put the funds on a pallet, and sent them in cash.”

Hence, the economics may pull down Tehran even if peace prevails. “If we have a democratic Government today, a transitional Government established in Iran today, and the Islamic Republic is gone, that transitional Government probably is not going to be able to pay Government salaries for more than a week or two,” says an expert.

Tehran knows this future scenario. So, both war and peace have consequences that go beyond the military and diplomatic. It is not about a face-saving retreat. It is about saving the nose or ears.

Left-Handed Economist

Swarm river like a school of fish

Hunt for new sources of ‘green’ energy are on; here is one in Germany

number is not important, and what is relevant is the energy over time, “since steady output is the whole point of using a river current.” German officials contend that 100 units can produce 1.5 GW-hours per day, which is 1.5 million kw-hours. In effect, this can supply power to 400-500 four-person households in a modern economy like Germany. One assumes that this implies that

Of course, the experiment or the small car-like turbines cannot work in every river, or every nation. In the case of Rhine, for example, the river currents reach 3.4-5 miles an hour, “which is fast enough to keep the (turbine) rotors moving.” Local geography matters. “Narrow valleys can squeeze large volumes of water through tighter channels, making currents more consistent than you might see on a wide, slow river,” states a media report. In addition, there are the real-world limits, which work on a large scale in the case of dams, and which have nothing to do with physics or science. A site lives with habitats and logistics.

However, one wonders the science or belief behind 124 turbines. According to reports, this

to fossil fuels. But the main attraction is the Climate Change impact. The carbon footprint of the project may be more than 500 tons of avoidable carbon dioxide. So, in terms of environment, it is safer and better, hopefully.

However, the real test will be in the long-term operations. Most of such experimental projects either perform admirably in controlled pilot projects, or in the short run. For these small turbines to generate power, day in and day out, for years, as the river changes its currents, courses, and other features, will hold the key.

In addition, the quantum of power, especially on a regular basis will matter because this will determine the electricity the project displaces on the local grid. If the project succeeds on both ends, it may herald a new era in hydro-power.

In the recent past, innovative experiments

in ‘green’ energy are on the increase. In a recent scientific publication, there were a few notable mentions. One of them included floating solar farms, which avoid the expensive land, and use the surfaces of lakes, reservoirs, even oceans. “Countries like China, Japan, and Singapore are leading the way with massive floating solar arrays, proving that renewable energy can expand into unexpected spaces while also supporting water conservation,” states a report. In India, for example, policy-makers have used drain covers, roof tops, and empty spaces next to railway tracks for panels.

Imagine a wind turbine that does not revolve around the horizontal axis, as you see along the coastlines, but around the vertical one. New designs now explore vertical-axis models that are “smaller, quieter, and more versatile. These turbines can be installed in urban areas where space is limited, and wind directions change frequently. Some companies are even developing micro wind turbines that can be attached to buildings, turning city skylines into energy producers without the need of sprawling wind farms.” Imagine wind turbines on rooftops in cities, as opposed to telecom towers!

Take this thought further, and think of giant home windows, which double up as solar panels. Today, solar window technology “embeds transparent photovoltaic materials into glass.” The concept will be a huge hit in Mumbai, where space matters, and most windows are slidable ones. It will be a bigger hit in Delhi, Bangalore, and Chennai, which have large sprawling bungalows, and equally-big apartments. Solar windows “allow light to pass through while also converting part of it into electricity.” It can transform “cities into massive energy-harvesting ecosystems, reducing dependence on fossil fuels.”

Now, let us go another step further. Let us talk about the building materials for homes. An innovative solution to store solar energy, which is a huge challenge, is to use energy-storing concrete, which involves the mixing of “concrete with carbon nanomaterials... that can act as giant batteries.”

This may “allow homes, bridges, and even entire city blocks to store excess renewable energy during peak times, and release it when needed, turning infrastructure into part of the energy grid.”

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Yoga-Kshema and India’s National Security: The Arthashastra Doctrine for Our Times



R K PACHNANDA
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TEJUSVI SHUKLA
ASSISTANT DIRECTOR (BHARAT KI SOCH)

शमव्यायामौ योगक्षेमयोर्योनिः ।
कर्मारम्भाणां योगाराधनो व्यायामः ।
कर्मफलोपभोगानां क्षेमाराधनः शमः ।
(Kautilya's Arthashastra: 6.2.1-2)

Kautilya's Arthashastra posits this as the singular fundamental goal of governance of any state working towards development and prosperity. In modern parlance, it is often understood in parallel with “national interest” or “core interests” by a few states. However, a nuanced understanding of the concept goes further beyond that. Yoga is the “acquisition” of resources for fulfilling national development goals-be it territory, technology, or economic depth. Kshema is the “protection” and efficient management of those gains. Together, they form a continuous loop of national advancement where one cannot exist without the other.

In contemporary terms, this architecture has long been tested by a total threat scenario. When India accelerates infrastructure along the border, it is reinforcing the Durga (fortress) limb. It is Yoga in action:

acquiring a strategic position that did not previously exist. It has a direct bearing on India's territorial and strategic policies. Kautilya is explicit that a vijigishu who aspires to advance must focus on what he requires for national development: fortifications, water-works, trade routes, settled lands, and resource-bearing territories.

India's assertive stand at Galwan in June 2020 was precisely a strong yoga conviction - refusing to cede ground. Similarly, the border infrastructure constructions since 2015, which provide all-weather connectivity to the forward areas, are a direct fulfilment of what Kauṭilya described as durga-samskara, or the strengthening of fortified positions. India's growing interest in maritime domain awareness, the construction of naval bases in Karwar (INS Kadamba), the installation of coastal radar chains, and new basing arrangements in the Indian Ocean similarly reflect the Yoga principle applied to sea power.

Kshema (protection and preservation) is the harder art. It demands sustained vigilance, proportional response, and the institutional discipline not to squander what has been won. Notably, the acquisition through Yoga is valuable because it serves Kshema-the protection and prosperity of the Janapada (the people and territory). Additionally, the shift toward Aatmanirbharta (self-reliance) seeks to build by reducing India's dependence on adversarial supply chains, particularly in critical minerals and defence manufacturing. This reflects the modern equivalent of securing the Kosha, ensuring that India's ability to defend itself is not held hostage by foreign supply chains. The most delicate balance between acquisition and protection is found in the application of military force. Kautilya was remarkably clinical: force (Danda) is the means of achieving Yoga-Kshema, but it must be calibrated.

This doctrine of Yathartha Danda, or proportional force, was visible in Operation Sindoor in May 2025. By executing precision strikes against terror infrastructure in response to the Pahalgam attack, India practised the art of Kshema. The objective was not total war, but the protection of the state's integrity through a calibrated signal of resolve.

Kautilya's six foreign policy instruments - sandhi (peace/treaty), vigraha (war), yana (marching),



asana (staying put), dvaidhibhava (double policy), and samshraya (seeking alliance) - collectively constitute the operational grammar of Yoga-Kshema in the international arena. The choice between them is governed by a clear principle:

शमव्यायामयोर्योनिः षाड्गुण्यम् ।
क्षयः स्थानं वृद्धिरित्युदयास्तस्य ।
(Kautilya's Arthashastra: 6.2.4-5)

India's abstention during United Nations votes on the Russia-Ukraine war and diplomatic outreach with often opposing sides during an ongoing international conflict are, from a Kautilyan perspective, a textbook case of dvaidhibhava: maintaining a dual policy as a policy expression for Kshema, or the protection of India's interests.

India's deepening of Quad partnerships with the United States, Japan, and Australia, while maintaining its historically independent stance, is a similar reflection of a deliberate foreign policy choice being deployed to extend India's strategic outreach without triggering bloc politics.

However, Kautilya's framework warns that the greatest threat to Kshema often comes from within. His dedicated study of Yogavrittam (focused on internal security) remains startlingly relevant. The government has astutely responded to the “invisible challenges” — information warfare, radicalisation, and technological subversion, with great aplomb.

The Arthashastra concludes that statecraft is for the “acquisition and protection of the earth”. For modern India, this “earth” is the aspiration of a Viksit Bharat-a developed, secure nation.

Yoga-Kshema offers a roadmap that is both ambitious and grounded. It demands that India continually strive for the capabilities (yoga) while maintaining the institutional discipline to safeguard what it has built (kshema). Two millennia later, Kautilya's message to the leaders of modern India remains the same: a serious nation does not merely react to the future; it acquires the tools to shape it and the wisdom to protect it. The reflection of this elaborate framework in governance policies testifies to the commitment and indomitable patriotism of our determined government, whose priority is the security of its nation and the safety and welfare of its citizens.

Fable with Moral

Clever rabbit and the lion

Panchatantra Book 1, Mitra bheda



In a dense forest lived a lion named Bhasuraka. He was a tyrant who killed animals indiscriminately, even when not hungry. To prevent their complete extinction, the forest animals made a plan that they would send one animal to his den every day if he promised to stop his mass slaughter. The lion agreed to the proposition.

One day, it was the turn of an old, wise rabbit. Though small, he possessed a sharp intellect. He deliberately lingered along the way, arriving at the lion's den long after the sun had peaked. Bhasuraka was famished and roared in a murderous rage, “Why are you late, you miserable creature? And why are you so small?”

The rabbit bowed low and said, “Lord, it is not my fault. Five other rabbits were sent with me, but we were stopped by another lion who claims to be the true king of this forest. He ate the others, but I escaped to warn you.”

Bhasuraka's ego flared. He demanded to be shown this rival immediately. The rabbit led him to a deep, clear well. “He is hiding in his fortress there,” the rabbit whispered.

Bhasuraka peered over the edge. Seeing his own reflection in the still water, he mistook it for the rival king. When he roared, the well echoed back an even louder challenge. Blinded by fury, the lion leapt into the deep water to attack. Unable to climb the smooth stone walls, he drowned. The rabbit returned to the other animals, proving that wit is far more powerful than brute strength.

Moral of the Fable

Intellect is power. A small mind with a plan can defeat a giant akin to Kautilya's principle relating to strategy over strength. The story demonstrates how a smaller, physically weaker state can neutralise a superior aggressor through intelligence and psychological manipulation.

Wisdom Word Search

S	G	U	P	T	A	C	H	A	R	A	W
K	D	A	N	D	A	O	J	P	S	W	I
A	L	Q	T	U	I	P	M	Q	L	N	K
S	P	A	A	R	S	Y	I	I	O	K	P
T	K	J	V	G	A	P	T	L	H	X	V
R	L	C	T	A	N	A	R	P	K	O	V
A	W	T	A	E	D	K	A	A	O	T	Y
A	Y	M	N	T	H	A	S	S	J	L	U
T	O	A	Q	P	I	Y	H	L	M	Y	H
O	R	A	K	S	H	A	L	A	I	D	A
I	P	G	P	R	A	N	A	I	S	U	U
O	I	F	S	E	N	A	H	Q	L	R	W

WORDS TO FIND

Astra, Danda, Durga, Guptachara, Mitra, Rajya, Raksha, Sandhi, Sena, Vyuha

ASTRA - Weapons used for defence, reflecting technological and strategic capability.

DANDA - Legitimate use of force to maintain order and protect sovereignty.

DURGA - Fortified spaces ensuring territorial defence and resilience.

GUPTACHARA - Intelligence networks gathering information for state security.

MITRA - Allies and strategic partnerships strengthening national security.

RAJYA - The state as a political entity requiring protection and stability.

RAKSHA - The act of safeguarding people, territory, and values.

SANDHI - Diplomatic agreements maintaining peace and strategic balance.

SENA - Organised military force defending the realm.

VYUHA - Strategic arrangement of forces in warfare and defence planning.

Marvels of India

BRAHMOS



A Marvel of Indian Strategic Ingenuity
The BrahMos supersonic cruise missile is one of Bharat's most impressive indigenous defence achievements, which was proven yet again during Operation Sindoor.

Technical Feat
It can be fired from land, sea, air and submarines. It reaches speeds of up to Mach 2.8-3.0 and a range that has grown from 290 to 450 km., and now 800 km. variants are under trial, after Bharat joined the Missile Technology Control Regime (MTCR) in 2016. Its two-stage engine, a solid-fuel booster followed by a ramjet, gives it exceptional speed.

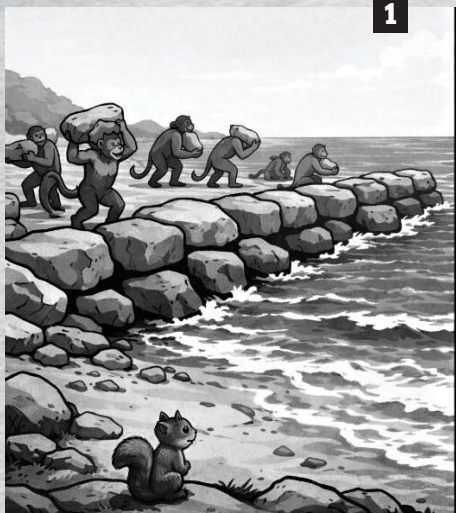
Operational Capability
The missile uses advanced guidance systems and works on a “fire and forget” principle, the launcher can move away immediately after firing. It can fly as low as 10 m., making it hard to detect or intercept.

Embodying New Bharat: A Progressive and Resilient Bharat
Inducted across the Army, Navy and Air Force since the mid-2000s and recently used in combat operations, it signals Bharat's shift from importing weapons to building and even exporting world-class defence systems.

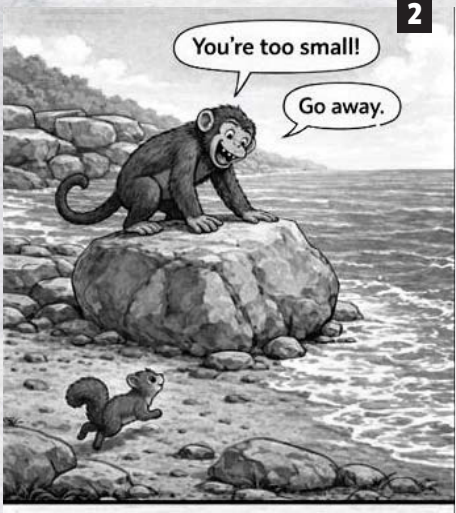
QUIZ National Security				
Questions	Option A	Option B	Option C	Option D
1 Who roamed around as Ascetics revered for their knowledge and favoured for their intelligence activity, forming one of the 5 types of spies in the Mauryan kingdom according to Chanakya?	Udasthita	Kapatikachha tra	Grihapaitika	Vaidehaka
2 Name the women bodyguards in the Imperial Chola kingdom who protected the king in times of war.	Anukkis	Padimagalir	Manayal	Adigaricci
3 Sam, Dam, Dand, Bhed are the 4 ancient strategies for conflict resolution and diplomacy applied sequentially, often ascribed to Chanakya. Which of them refers to winning over a rival through friendship, dialogue or rational persuasion?	Sam	Dam	Dand	Bhed
4 The North East India historically used several animals in warfare. Which one of them was the most frequently used?	Mules	Yaks	Horses	Elephants
5 Which of these traditional martial arts has been practiced widely by women, especially in South India?	Gatka	Sqay	Kalaripayattu	Sarit Sarak
Answers: 1 - A, 2 - B, 3 - A, 4 - D, 5 - C				

ramayana

The Smallest Helper

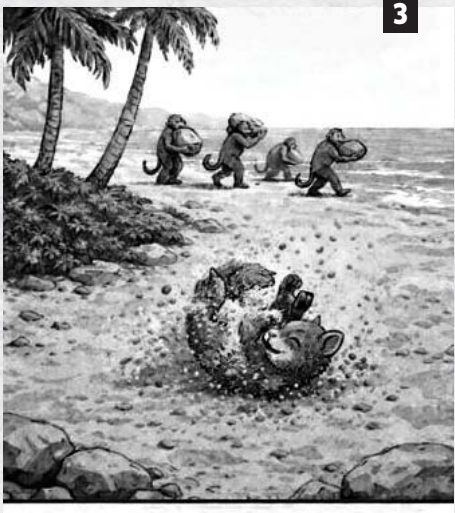


1 Vanara sena were building Ram Setu. A little squirrel wanted to help.

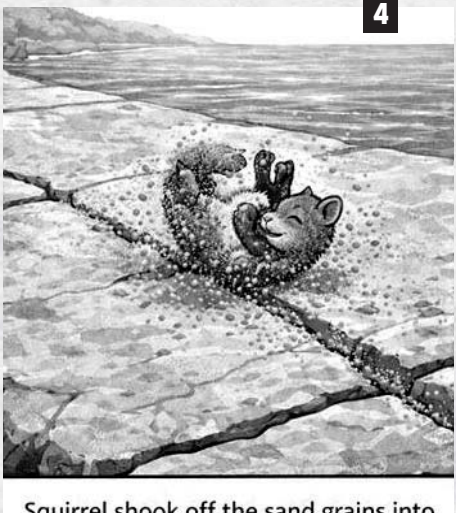


2 You're too small!! Go away.

But the squirrel was determined to help build the bridge.



3 The squirrel rolled in the sand and covered his fur with sand.



4 Squirrel shook off the sand grains into the cracks. This made the stone bridge smooth and safe.



5 You made the bridge safe for everyone. No help is too small!!

MORAL OF THE STORY: Even the smallest can make the biggest difference

FROM THE WORLD

CHINA

Pakistani satellite launched

China launched a Pakistani satellite from its Taiyuan Satellite Launch Centre in north China's Shanxi Province on Saturday night. The satellite named PRSC-E03 was lifted off at 8:15 pm (Beijing Time) by a Long March-6 carrier rocket and successfully entered its planned orbit, China's state-run Xinhua news agency reported. This is the fourth Pakistani satellite launched by China since last year. China launched three Pakistani satellites last year. China has been launching satellites for Pakistan in the last few years, broadening its all-weather alliance with Pakistan into the space arena. Separately, two Pakistanis who were selected by Beijing for astronaut training to participate in China's space mission training arrived here on April 24.

SRI LANKA

22 arrested for carrying narcotics

A group of 22 people dressed as monks has been arrested for allegedly carrying Kush and Hashish narcotics at the Bandaranaike International Airport here upon arrival from Thailand, Sri Lankan police said. The Narcotics Bureau said the haul worth 1.1 billion Sri Lankan rupees was the largest drug seizure at the airport. The 22 individuals were arrested on Saturday for allegedly carrying 120 kg of Kush and Hashish narcotics on false bottomed suitcases, police said. They had left for Thailand on April 22. According to police, the suspects are residents of Ampara, Horana, Boralesgamuwa, Wadduwa, Warakapola, Piliyandala, Homagama, Athuraliya, Ambalangoda, Kudispaththuwa, Madapatha, and Balangoda.

Explosive device kills 13, injures 38 on bus in Colombia

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bogota (Colombia)

An explosive device killed 13 people travelling on a bus in southwestern Colombia on Saturday, an attack the country's army chief described as a "terrorist act" that also left at least 38 injured as violence linked to drug trafficking in the region escalates. Octavio Guzman, the governor of the region of Cauca, said on X that the device was set off while the bus was travelling along the Pan-American Highway in the municipality of Cajibío. Five children were among the injured, Cauca Health Secretary Carolina Camargo told Noticias Caracol, a TV news programme. Gen. Hugo Lopez, commander of Colombia's Armed Forces, told a news conference that it was a

"terrorist act" and blamed the network of a man known as "Ivan Mordisco" — one of Colombia's most wanted figures — and the Jaime Martínez faction. Both are dissidents of the now-defunct Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia that operate in the region. Neither Ivan Mordisco nor the Jaime Martínez faction abide by the peace agreement signed with the state in 2016. Colombian President Gustavo Petro condemned the attack on X. "Those who carried out the attack and killed seven civilians — and wounded 17 others — in Cajibío — many of them Indigenous people — are terrorists, fascists, and drug traffickers," he wrote. The attack is the latest in a spate of explosions that have attempted to target public infrastructure. At least 26 incidents have taken



People gather around vehicles damaged in an attack on the Pan-American Highway in Cajibío, Colombia

AP

place in the past two days in southwestern Colombia, which Lopez said have only affected civilians. They included a shooting

at a police station in the rural area of Jamundi, and an attack on a civil a radar facility in El Tambo, where authorities took down three

explosives-laden drones earlier on Saturday. No one was hurt. On Friday, two vehicles rigged with explosives were

detonated near military units in Cali and Palmira, causing material damage. The escalation of violence in that region — a territory contested by illegal armed groups linked to drug trafficking — prompted the mobilisation of high-ranking officials on Saturday. Led by Defence Minister Pedro Sanchez, the delegation that includes regional governors and local authorities was meeting in Palmira when the deadly explosion occurred. "These criminals seek to instil fear, but we will respond with firmness," Sanchez said on X. Meanwhile, Francisca Toro, governor of Valle del Cauca, has called upon the national government to provide "immediate support." In a message on X, Toro called for a reinforcement of public security forces, enhanced intelli-

gence operations and "decisive actions" against crime in the face of a "terrorist-level escalation." According to authorities, Cauca and Valle del Cauca serve as a critical hub for illicit activities of illegal armed groups vying for control over sea and river access routes leading to the port of Buenaventura — a key transit point used to traffic drugs to Central America and Europe. The government has also offered a reward of more than 1 million dollars for information leading to the capture of "Marlon," who is identified as the leader of the region's dissident group. On Friday, local authorities offered more than USD 14,000 for information leading to the identification and location of those behind the attacks in Cali and Palmira.

Two former Israeli prime ministers agree to merge parties against Netanyahu

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Jerusalem

Two Israeli political heavyweights on Sunday said they would join forces in upcoming elections in a shared effort to unseat longtime Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. Naftali Bennett and Yair Lapid served as prime ministers in a rotation agreement as part of a coalition government they formed in 2021. They now plan to merge their parties into single faction headed by Bennett. "The move is intended to unite the bloc, put an end to internal divisions and focus all



efforts on winning the critical upcoming elections," Lapid's Yesh Atid party said in a statement. Bennett and Lapid scheduled a joint news conference later on Sunday. The 2021 coalition agree-

ment ended 12 years of Netanyahu rule. Bennett served as prime minister for the first year until their coalition fractured. Lapid then held the top job as caretaker prime minister for the final six months until new elections

brought Netanyahu back to power. Lapid has served as Israel's opposition leader since that time, while Bennett took a break from politics. The two men have ideological differences. Bennett is an Orthodox Jew with hard-line views toward the Palestinians, while Lapid is secular and seen as more moderate. But they enjoyed a close working relationship during their short-lived coalition. Their alliance is aimed at uniting a fragmented opposition that appears to have little in common beyond their shared hostility toward Netanyahu.

Bangladesh: Hindu man's body found hanging from tree

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

A Hindu temple caretaker was found hanging from a tree three days after he went missing from his home in southeastern Bangladesh, a minority group said and demanded stern action against the perpetrators. Nayan Sadhu, the 40-year-old resident of the Dohazari area under Sthanía Upazila of the Chhattogram district, was serving as a caretaker-cum-priest at a Shivakali temple in Khurushkul union in Cox's

Bazar Sadar Upazila, the Bangladesh Hindu Buddhist Christian Unity Council (BHBCUC) said late on Saturday. Two unidentified men took Nayan with them late on the evening of April 19, and three days later, his body was found hanging from a tree in a hilly area on the outskirts of the village, according to the police and residents in the Cox's Bazar neighbourhood. "We recovered the body when it had started getting decomposed," the Kaler Kantha newspaper said,

quoting an unnamed police official. The police are yet not sure if it was a case of murder or suicide, he said. In a statement, the council demanded stern punitive action against the perpetrators of his murder. "The Unity Council strongly condemns the incident and demands immediate arrest and exemplary punishment against the perpetrators," the forum said in the statement. "We just cannot understand what could be the motive of killing an ordinary caretaker of a relatively small

temple in a remote area," BHBCUC senior member Kajal Debnath told PTI. Bangladesh Puja Celebration Council's Cox's Bazar unit general secretary Jony Dhar said the body was recovered three days after Nayan went missing, indicating that he was murdered. Police said the body has been sent for an autopsy to determine the exact cause of the death. An investigation was launched following the missing person's report filed by the deceased's wife on April 19.

Plane crash in US kills legislator, pilot

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Minneapolis

A small plane crashed just after taking off from Crystal Airport north of Minneapolis on Saturday, killing a North Dakota state legislator and the pilot, authorities said. North Dakota state Rep. Liz Conmy, of Fargo, was killed in the crash, her colleague, state Sen. Tim Mathern, told the Star Tribune. The North Dakota Democratic–Nonpartisan League Party, an affiliate of the national Democratic Party, confirmed Conmy's death in a social media post, calling her a champion for public education, the environment, and transparency. "We are completely heartbroken and gutted by the loss of Representative Liz Conmy. Her death is a profound loss for our state," the party said in a post on X. Officers responded to a



report of a small airplane crash at 11:51 am and found an aircraft that had crashed and caught fire in a park in the city of Brooklyn Park, Minnesota, shortly after taking off, Brooklyn Park Police Inspector Matt Rabe said. Rabe said the plane crashed shortly after taking off. He wouldn't say how

many people were on the plane. The Federal Aviation Administration said in a statement that two people were aboard. The National Transportation Safety Board said it is investigating a crash involving a Beech F33A airplane and expects investigators to arrive at the scene soon.

Officer killed, another critically injured in US hospital shooting

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Chicago

A police officer died and another was critically injured after a shooting at a Chicago hospital on Saturday, according to officials. The suspect, who was not publicly identified, was taken in custody, Chicago police superintendent Larry Snelling said. "Officers transported an individual over to the Swedish hospital for an observation, at which time two of our officers were shot," Snelling said at a news conference in the afternoon. "One was shot critically. It (the death) was pronounced. The second officer right now is fighting for his life in the hospital behind us." The shooting was at the Endeavor Health Swedish



Hospital in Chicago at around 10.50 am. The hospital said its campus was placed on lockdown, and patients and staff at the health facility were safe. Snelling said there is an ongoing investigation, and he could not provide details. But the hospital said in a Facebook posting that an individual in custody of law enforcement was brought

to the emergency department for treatment and was "wanded upon arrival," following the protocols. He was escorted by law enforcement at all times, the hospital said. It said that the man later fired shots at the law enforcement officers and exited the hospital building. He was later apprehended.

Pak President visits SANY Heavy Industry unit

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing

Pakistan's President Asif Ali Zardari, currently on a visit to China, took a tour of SANY Heavy Industry Co Ltd in Changsha, Hunan province, on Sunday. He was briefed by the Chairman of Sany Group Tang Xiuguo, on the company's advanced manufacturing systems, product lines and ongoing investments in research and development, Pakistan's state-run APP news agency reported. Pakistan's Foreign Ministry said on Saturday that Zardari is scheduled to visit China from April 25 to May 1 with a focus on economic and trade cooperation as well as the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC). He will travel to Changsha,



Hunan province, from April 25 to 27, and to Sanya, Hainan province, from April 28 to May 1, the ministry said. The visit focused on exploring avenues for industrial cooperation, technology transfer and investment between Pakistan and China in the engineering and construction machinery sector, Pakistan's President Secretariat Media Wing said in a press release. (PTI)

Four vying to be next UN chief try to set themselves apart as race heats up

EDITH M LEDERER
■ United Nations

Four candidates vying to lead the United Nations have spent hours being grilled about their views on issues from restoring global peace to ending escalating poverty — in what the UN General Assembly president called one of the toughest job interviews in the world. There was no clear victor after Chile's Michelle Bachelet, Argentina's Rafael Grossi, Costa Rica's Rebecca Grynspan and Senegal's Macky Sall fielded questions from UN ambas-

sadors this past week. Plus, other candidates could wait until after the initial auditions to jump into the race to succeed UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres on January 1. "This role matters," said General Assembly President Annalena Baerbock, who presided over the question-and-answer sessions. "The secretary-general is not only the head of the UN and the world's top diplomat — she or he also represents all 8 billion of us, defending the UN Charter and leading on peace, development, human rights."

How the candidates view the UN's work All four said they would focus on those three pillars of the UN, especially its founding role following World War II of ensuring international peace and security and preventing conflicts — which it has not been able to do in Iran, Gaza, Ukraine, Sudan and other global hot spots because of wide divisions. They also pledged to spur reforms to the more than 80-year-old institution. Bachelet, 74, a two-time president of Chile and former UN human rights chief, told the ambassadors that the



UN must try to avoid crises and that she has the right leadership skills. "I stand before you to reclaim the urgent need for

dialogue," she said, stressing that the UN must anticipate, prevent and unite. The next secretary-general also needs to be "physically present in

the field" to help tackle problems, she said. Grossi, 65, a former Argentine diplomat who has been director-general of the International Atomic Energy Agency since 2019, said that with the world so polarized, "there are enormous, huge doubts about our institution" in solving global problems. Unless the UN has effective leadership and support from all countries, it won't regain a key place at the table, he said, "so we have to concentrate on that." He also said the next UN chief must visit global hot spots. Grynspan, 65, a former Costa

Rican vice president who has been secretary-general of the UN trade and development agency since 2021, said she knows how to stand up for principles while under pressure. As secretary-general, she said she would "continue to be the moral voice and the impartial voice that the secretary-general has to be." The UN has become "a risk-conservative organisation," she warned. "We need to take more risks — and I am ready to fail and try again." Sall, 64, who was president of Senegal for 12 years, said the UN needs to "regain its place at the global table."

If chosen, he said he would be "a bridge-builder" and that his first priority would be "to contribute to restoring trust, to calm tensions, reduce fragmentation and breathe renewed hope into our collective action." **Some candidates are facing pushback** Bachelet, a medical doctor, responded to a letter from 28 Republican US lawmakers calling her a "pro-abortion zealot" and asking Secretary of State Marco Rubio to veto her, saying the issue is controversial and that she respects every country's right to decide.

At least 16 dead in Russia-Ukraine war

SAMYA KULLAB ■ Kyiv

At least 16 people have been killed in strikes over the weekend across Ukraine, Russian-occupied territory and Russia, local authorities said, as the 40th anniversary of the Chernobyl nuclear disaster prompted fresh warnings about the risks posed by attacks near the plant during Russia's more than four-year invasion of its neighbour.

The death toll from Russian drone and missile strikes on the city of Dnipro rose to nine, regional head Oleksandr Hanzha said Sunday.

One man was killed in a Ukrainian drone strike on the port city of Sevastopol, in Russian-occupied Crimea, Moscow-installed authorities said Sunday.

Russia annexed the peninsula from Ukraine in 2014, a move that most of the world considered illegal, and has used it as a staging and supply point during the war. Leonid Pasechnik, the



Russia-installed governor in Ukraine's Luhansk region — of which Russia earlier this month said it had taken full control, a claim denied by Ukraine — said three people were killed in an overnight Ukrainian drone strike on a village, after reporting two people were killed in the early hours of Saturday. Ukraine did not comment

on either attack, which could not be independently verified by The Associated Press.

The latest strikes came after a woman was killed in a Ukrainian drone attack on Russia's Belgorod border region, according to local authorities.

Ukrainian forces also struck an oil refinery in Yaroslavl, deep inside Russian

territory, Ukraine's General Staff said Sunday.

The strikes sparked fires at the facility, which processes 15 million tons of oil a year and produces gasoline, diesel and jet fuel for the Russian military. Russia did not immediately comment.

Ukraine has developed its own long-range drones, which can reach targets

some 1,500 kilometres inside Russia. It has used them recently against Russian oil facilities as Moscow looks to boost its exports after the Trump administration gave it a temporary waiver from sanctions to ease supply constraints.

Kyiv officials complain that Russia will use the additional revenue on new weapons to hit Ukraine harder.

Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy marked the anniversary of the Chernobyl nuclear disaster to warn that Russian attacks risk repeating history.

"Through its war, Russia is once again bringing the world to the brink of a man-made disaster — Russian-Iranian Shaheds regularly fly over the plant, and one of them struck the confinement last year," he wrote on Facebook.

"The world must not allow this nuclear terrorism to continue, and the best way is to force Russia to stop its reckless attacks," he said.

Rafael Grossi, director general of the International Atomic Energy Agency, echoed those concerns during a visit to Kyiv, saying repairs to the plant's damaged outer protective shell must begin immediately. IAEA assessments show the damage sustained after a strike last year has already compromised a key safety function of the structure, he said, warning that years of inaction could heighten danger to the original sarcophagus beneath it.

The European Bank for Reconstruction and Development said repairs would require at least 500 million euros (\$586 million).

Ukrainian officials say a Russian drone struck the outer shell of the plant's New Safe Confinement structure - a \$2.1 billion archlike enclosure completed in 2019 over the remains of Reactor number 4 — in February 2025. Moscow denied targeting the plant, alleging Kyiv staged the attack. (AP)

Car-bomb explodes outside police station in Northern Ireland



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Police in Northern Ireland have condemned a car-bomb attack on a police station as an attempt to undermine the 1998 agreement that brought peace to the region.

The bomb, fashioned from a compressed gas cylinder, exploded as police were evacuating nearby residents in Dunmurry, on the outskirts of Belfast, on Saturday night, Deputy Chief Constable Bobby Singleton told reporters on Sunday.

"This clearly demonstrates that what this type of device may have lacked in terms of its sophistication and scale, it more than made up for in its reckless unpredictability," Singleton said. "For a device like this to have been deployed against police and in such proximity to the public was idiotic. It was absolute madness."

The incident took place at about 10:30 pm after the attackers stopped a delivery driver, placed an improvised bomb in his vehicle and ordered him to drive to the police station, Singleton said.

Brendan Mullan, chairman of the Northern Ireland Policing Board, said the device "was sent to kill officers and cause maximum harm in an attack which was in the heart

of a residential area."

"The people have spoken when they overwhelmingly endorsed the Good Friday Agreement" in 1998, Mullan said. "Such acts of violence have no place in a society committed to peace. We stand united in condemnation of those responsible for this terror, and in voicing support for the work of the officers and staff of the PSNI." It was the second incident at a police station in recent weeks.

On March 30, police foiled a similar attack on a police station in Lurgan, about 20 miles (32 kilometres) southwest of Dunmurry. Two masked men stopped a delivery driver, placed an explosive device in the trunk of his vehicle and forced him at gunpoint to take the device to the police station, according to authorities. Police carried out a controlled explosion after about 100 homes were evacuated.

The Lurgan attack was probably carried out by dissident Republican groups in a "pathetic attempt to remain relevant and provoke fear," police said.

The Good Friday Agreement largely ended decades of violence involving Republican groups opposed to British rule and others who wanted to maintain the region's ties to the United Kingdom.

Mali separatists confirm they joined Islamic militants in coordinated attacks

WILSON MCMAKIN
■ Dakar (Senegal)

Separatists in northern Mali said they joined Islamic militants in launching one of the biggest coordinated attacks on the Malian army in the capital and several other cities that left at least 16 wounded.

It was the first time that a Tuareg-led separatist group, the Azawad Liberation Front (FLA), said it had operated alongside the al-Qaida-linked militant group JNIM, which also claimed responsibility for Saturday's attacks on Bamako's international airport and four other cities in central and northern Mali.

"This operation is being carried out in partnership

with the JNIM, which is also committed to defending the people against the military regime in Bamako," FLA spokesperson Mohamed El Maouloud Ramadan said in a statement Saturday.

Mali government spokesperson Gen Issa Ousmane Coulibaly said on state television late Saturday that 16 people were wounded, including civilians and military personnel, and that several militants were killed. He did not provide a death toll.

The governor of Bamako's district, Abdoulaye Coulibaly, announced a three-day overnight curfew, from 9 pm to 6 am.

The separatists also called on Russia to "reconsider its



support for the military junta in Bamako, whose actions have contributed to the suffering of the civilian population."

Following military coups, the juntas in Mali, Niger and Burkina Faso turned from Western allies to Russia for

help combating Islamic militants. But the security situation has worsened in recent times, with a record number of attacks by militants. Government forces have also been accused of killing civilians they suspect of collaborating with militants. (AP)

INDIA ADVISES NATIONALS IN MALI TO STAY INDOORS, EXERCISE CAUTION

Johannesburg: India on Saturday advised its nationals in Mali to remain highly vigilant, exercise utmost caution and stay indoors due to recent security developments in the West African nation.

The Indian Embassy in Bamako, in an advisory, said, "Due to recent security developments and reported attacks in Kati and other parts of Mali, the Embassy of India in Bamako urges all Indian nationals residing in Mali to remain highly vigilant, exercise utmost caution, stay indoors, and strictly follow the instructions issued by the Malian authorities from time to time."

The embassy added that it was closely monitoring the evolving situation in coordination with Malian authorities and will issue further updates as required.

It urged Indian nationals to stay in touch with the embassy through its website and the embassy's official social media accounts.

It also advised Indian nationals to contact the Embassy at +223 78486019/94793705 in case of any emergency assistance. (PTI)

Meta, Microsoft join tech layoff tsunami

KAI RIEMER/SANDRA PETER
■ Sydney

Meta and Microsoft are the latest software companies to announce big cuts to their global workforce. Both companies are also making big investments in artificial intelligence (AI).

The link seems obvious. Meta's chief people officer, Janelle Gale, said the job cuts — about 10 per cent of staff or almost 8,000 workers — serve to "offset the other investments we're making". Meta boss Mark Zuckerberg has previously spoken about a "major AI acceleration" with spending in excess of USD 115bn planned this year.

Microsoft is also betting big on AI. The company also just announced early retirement packages for about 7 per cent of its US workforce.

The two tech giants join Atlassian, Block, WiseTech Global and Oracle, who have all made similar announcements this year, each evoking AI without outright blaming it. What is happening here? How we understand these layoffs depends on what we think AI is and what implications it will have.

Broadly speaking, there are three ways of looking at it: that AI is superintelligence, that it's mostly hype, and



that it's a useful tool.

The end of white-collar work?

In the first view, AI is an emerging superintelligence. It is a new kind of mind that learns, reasons, and will soon outperform humans at most cognitive tasks (hint: it's not!). The job losses are not just a corporate restructuring. They are an early tremor of something seismic.

In February 2026, AI entrepreneur Matt Shumer put this view vividly — comparing the current moment to the strange, quiet weeks before COVID-19 broke into global consciousness. Most people, he argued, haven't yet realised we are facing an "intelligence explosion".

The essay drew significant criticism. Commentators noted it contained little hard data and read at times like a

pitch for Shumer's company's own AI products.

But it captured a genuine anxiety. Something real is happening in software engineering, at least, where tasks are well-defined, and success is easy to verify.

But the leap to "all white-collar work will be automated" is a big one. The view that AI is a kind of universal mind that learns and improves itself is far-fetched.

And most professional work is far messier than coding: ambiguous briefs, competing stakeholder interests, outputs that are hard to verify, and shifting success criteria. Coding may be a canary in the coal mine, but coal mines and boardrooms are very different places.

Are tech companies winding back hiring spree?

The second view sees the conversation around AI as mostly hype. AI is being invoked as cover. Companies that hired aggressively during the pandemic boom and now face financial pressure are blaming AI as the more palatable explanation.

OpenAI CEO Sam Altman called this dynamic "AI washing": companies blaming AI for layoffs they would have made regardless.

For example, Meta

announced in March that it would shut down its Metaverse platform Horizon World by June. Reality Labs, the division developing the technology, employed 15,000 people as of January 2026.

We don't know in detail the make-up of the present job cuts, so Meta may just be repackaging earlier failures as AI-driven productivity gains.

Another cynical reading suggests that laying off workers in the name of AI is a way to drive up stock prices. When Block invoked AI and cut nearly 4,000 roles, its stock jumped the following day. Announce AI-driven layoffs, and you may find investors reward you for being future-focused. It is a historically familiar trick: technology has repeatedly served as a convenient cover for financial restructuring.

Are layoffs a way to make staff use AI?

The third view is more nuanced. It sees AI as a powerful tool, but one that companies will need to transform themselves to take advantage of. This has implications for what jobs are needed and in what quantities. We think this view has the most merit.

On this reading, the tech leaders believe AI will change how software gets built. (AP)

Syria's first public trial of Assad-era officials opens in Damascus

GHAITH ALSAYED
■ Damascus (Syria)

The first public trial in Syria of officials linked to the rule of former President Bashar Assad opened in Damascus on Sunday.

Atef Najib, a former Syrian army brigadier general who was head of the Political Security Branch in southern Syria's Daraa province under Assad, appeared in the courtroom to face charges related to "crimes against the Syrian people," state-run news agency SANA reported.

Najib was in that position in 2011 when teenagers who scrawled anti-government graffiti on a school wall in Daraa were arrested and tortured. The case became a catalyst for mass protests against the repressive policies of Assad's government security forces.

The protests were met by a brutal government crackdown and spiralled into a 14-year civil war that ended with Assad's ouster in December 2024 in a lightning rebel offensive. Assad fled to Russia, while most members of his inner circle also escaped Syria.



Assad himself and his brother, Maher, former commander of the Syrian military's 4th Armoured Division — which Syrian opposition activists have accused of killings, torture, extortion and drug trafficking, in addition to running its own detention centres — were charged in absentia, along with a number of other former high-ranking security officials.

Najib was the only one of the defendants who was arrested and present in person in court on Sunday for a preparatory session in the trial, which will continue next month.

Crowds gathered outside the courthouse to celebrate.

The government of interim President Ahmad al-

Sharaa has faced criticism over delays in launching a promised transitional justice process. Syria is struggling to heal following 14 years of civil war that left an estimated half a million people dead, millions more displaced, and the country battered and divided.

Authorities now appear to be moving more aggressively to prosecute officials linked to Assad.

Syrian authorities on Friday arrested Amjad Yousef, a former intelligence officer who appeared in a video leaked four years ago that purportedly showed him and his comrades executing dozens of blindfolded and shackled prisoners in the Damascus suburb of Tadamon during the country's civil war. (AP)

Humanoid robot creates flutter hugging student at a dance event in China

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

A humanoid robot performing at a university dance event in China startled the crowd when it suddenly moved closer to a female student and hugged her, prompting the staff to quickly pull it away.

The video of the event at the university in China's Shaanxi province went viral and sparked a debate in the Chinese social media about whether the robot developed autonomous behaviour or was manipulated by its handler.

The incident has prompted experts to work out enhanced safety measures as robots' participation in public events became "new normal" in China with the government's push to showcase the country's growing might in the field of Artificial Intelligence (AI).

Commenting on the incident, a staff member told the media that the joint performance between the robot and a student club was an attempt to innovate campus cultural activities. (PTI)

Inside world's largest art heist; when over \$500M of paintings were stolen from Boston museum

LEAH WILLINGHAM
■ Boston (AP)

For decades, the 1990 theft of 13 artworks from the Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum — now valued at more than \$500 million — has remained unsolved.

It remains the largest art theft in history — far surpassing more recent museum thefts, including a daylight heist at the Louvre that involved far fewer works and was resolved more quickly. In 2013, the FBI said it knew who was responsible for the Boston museum heist but declined to name them, fuelling speculation that persists today.

A former FBI agent who led the investigation for more than two decades is now offering the first detailed

account of how investigators reached that conclusion — and publicly identifying the men he believes were involved.

In a new book, Geoff Kelly traces how the artworks moved through criminal networks, where violence took the lives of key suspects and witnesses, and challenges long-circulating theories by revisiting key details.

The irony at the centre is that Gardner's intention was for the museum to remain frozen in time, stipulating in her will that nothing in the Venetian palazzo-inspired building would be changed after her death.

Gardner, who lived in the museum and died there in 1924, intended for the paintings, sculptures and architectural fragments to remain

exactly as she had arranged.

The empty gilded frames of the missing paintings still hang in the museum today — silent witnesses to what was taken.

The art heist

Early on March 18, 1990, as Boston wound down from St. Patrick's Day celebrations, two men dressed as police officers arrived at the museum and convinced a security guard to let them in, violating protocol.

The men handcuffed the guards in the basement and made their way to the museum's Dutch Room, where they cut Vermeer's "The Concert" and Rembrandt's "Christ in the Storm on the Sea of Galilee" from their frames, also taking works by Degas and Manet.

They also took a



Napoleonic eagle finial - a decorative metal piece of comparatively little value that investigators later found puzzling - and the museum's security videotapes.

The museum offered a USD 5 million reward that they then doubled a decade later for information leading to

the recovery of the works.

Boston-area network of criminals

Some tips pointed to the Irish Republican Army and to Boston mob figures, including notorious crime boss Whitey Bulger.

Kelly followed one lead to France, where he watched

through binoculars as FBI agents, posing as wealthy intermediaries, lounged on a yacht — drinking champagne and eating strawberries - in an effort to draw out suspected Corsican mob figures.

Closer to home, agents searched houses across New England, relying heavily on informants. A triple murderer known as "Meatball" who was terminally ill secretly recorded conversations with suspected associates in hopes of earning money for his family.

But none of the tips led to the paintings.

Violence complicates matters

In the decades since the robbery, several people believed to have ties to the heist were killed, and another died under suspicious cir-

cumstances.

Robert "Bobby" Donati, a Boston mob associate long suspected in the case, was found stabbed to death in 1991, his body left in the trunk of a car after his home had been ransacked.

Years earlier, Donati has visited the Gardner with another known art thief, Myles Connor, to scope it out for a robbery and said that if he ever took the museum's Napoleonic finial, it would be his "calling card." Years later, a jeweler told investigators Donati tried to sell a finial from the Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum but backed off, saying it was "too hot."

A separate line of evidence centered on George Reissfelder, who investigators believe owned the getaway car.

Kelly tracked down Reissfelder's brother, a retired military officer who had initially not believed his brother was involved. He broke down after being shown Manet's "Chez Tortoni," saying he recognized it as a painting he himself hung above his brother's bed.

Reissfelder later died under suspicious circumstances. When investigators searched his home, the painting was gone.

Both men had ties to TRC Auto Electric, a Dorchester shop linked to Charles "Chuck" Merlino's crew.

Investigation with limited resources

Though investigators believed they knew who was responsible, they had a difficult time finding definitive proof. (AP)

PROSPECT

CBI seizes ₹21 lakh cash from premises of CWC manager arrested in bribery case



The CBI seized ₹21 lakh cash and jewellery from the premises of a Central Warehousing Corporation (CWC) manager who was recently arrested in a bribery case, officials said on Saturday.

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) is looking into the role of other officials of the CWC in the case, they said.

"The CBI conducted searches at the residential premises linked to the accused manager, which led to the recovery of cash worth ₹21 lakh, a huge amount of jewellery, property papers and digital evidence from the premises," a CBI spokesperson said in a statement.

The accused manager had demanded a bribe of ₹1 lakh from a contractor to allow him to continue the awarded work.

FTA with New Zealand will provide benefit to domestic firms: Goyal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Agra

The free trade agreement (FTA) with New Zealand, scheduled to be signed on April 27, will provide huge opportunities for domestic firms, including leather exporters from the city of the Taj Mahal, Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal said on Sunday.

Goyal is here with the visiting New Zealand's Trade and Investment Minister Todd McClay.

The ministers held discussions with businesses from different sectors, including leather and sports goods.

The FTA aims to double bilateral trade and facilitate duty-free access to the island nation's markets for Indian companies, as well as bring in USD 20 billion of investment over the next 15 years.

"Goods exported from India to New Zealand will go without any tax, creating significant opportunities, including for Agra's leather



industry and other sectors," Goyal said, adding that the pact would help promote two-way commerce, which stood around USD 2.4 billion.

Agra is one of India's largest leather and footwear clusters, playing a key role in both domestic supply and exports.

It is dominated with MSMEs. The sector will get a duty-free access in New Zealand market, once the trade deal comes into force.

He added that India and New Zealand are set to sign a free trade agreement (FTA) on Monday, which is expected to boost trade between

India is a strategic priority for New Zealand and urged businesses to actively pursue joint ventures and investment in India.

Talking on political issues, the Union commerce and industry minister expressed confidence that NDA would form governments in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal.

He also criticised the Aam Aadmi Party.

"A corrupt group remains around Arvind Kejriwal, and it's natural that they (seven AAP's Rajya Saha MPs) left the party. It's possible that more people will leave in the future," he said.

Meanwhile, the two ministers visited the Taj Mahal here. They arrived around 7 am, accompanied by their spouses, and spent nearly two hours at the monument, where a guide briefed them about its history.

Goyal said McClay and his wife had expressed a desire to see the monument, following which the visit was scheduled.

ED raids against Raheja Developers



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate on Saturday conducted fresh searches against real estate company Raheja Developers as part of a money laundering investigation linked to alleged fraud with home buyers, officials said.

They said about seven premises in Delhi-NCR are being covered as part of the action. The agency had raided the company, its promoters and some others in June 2025 too as part of a similar investigation. The latest searches are being conducted in the matter of alleged fraud with the home buyers and non-delivery of flats in its project 'Raheja Revanta', according to the officials. The company,

however, denied any wrongdoing or fraud committed by it in this project.

The company has invested significantly more than customer collections, as confirmed by a RERA-supervised forensic audit, and no funds have been diverted. "The project delay is primarily due to the lack of essential government infrastructure, despite full payment of EDC/IDC," Raheja Developers said in a statement. It added that the possession for 61-storey structure cannot be safely delivered without critical services like water, electricity, sewerage, and firefighting systems.

Raheja Developers has developed many housing projects in Delhi-NCR. Some of its projects are delayed due to financial crunch.

Assam clinches title in North East Rising Cup against Tripura

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam emerged victorious in the final of the 2nd North East Rising Cup 2026 (Under-15 Girls), defeating Tripura by 11 runs by VJD method at the Judges' Field, Guwahati on Sunday. The tournament, hosted by the Assam Cricket Association with the support of all the Northeast Cricket Associations as part of its continued commitment to promote and strengthen women's cricket in the Northeast region, concluded successfully.

Winning the toss and electing to bat first, Assam posted a competitive total of 177 all out in 34.5 overs. For Assam, Ankita Chetri top-scored with 40 off 39 balls, followed by Aradhya Dutta (37 off 51 balls) and Murshana Baruah (22 off 24 balls). Tripura's bowlers put up a disciplined performance, with Diya Sarkar



returning figures of 2/39, while Purbha Chowdhury (1/23) and Riddhi Nama (1/29) provided crucial breakthroughs.

In response, Tripura were 51/2 in 15 overs, with Sayantika Sutradhar scoring 24 off 48 balls and Christina Rema adding 14 off 20 balls. Nousin Afra Anjum picked up 1/27 for Assam. However, rain interrupted play, and no further action was possible. As per the VJD method, the target for

Tripura was 63 in 15 overs, resulting in Assam winning the match by 11 runs.

The closing ceremony was graced by the presence of Devajit Saikia, Honorary Secretary, BCCI, as the Chief Guest and MKJ Majumdar, Member, IPL Governing Council & Convener, North East Rising Cup MKJ Majumdar expressed his sincere gratitude to BCCI Honorary Secretary Devajit Saikia for his vision and support in conceptualising the North East Rising Cup. He remarked that such initiatives are instrumental in creating a robust pathway for talent identification and development in the Northeast region.

Devajit Saikia, Honorary Secretary of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI), stated that the Board

Secretary, Sanatan Das, ACA Vice President, Romen Dutta, ACA Joint Secretary, Rajendra Singh, Apex Council Member, Mukutananda Bhattachariya.

The event was also graced by Tripura CA Secretary Lairenjam Geetranjan Singh, Meghalaya CA Secretary Rayonald Kharkamni, Manipur CA, Secretary Lairenjam Geetranjan Singh.

IPL Governing Council & Convener, North East Rising Cup MKJ Majumdar expressed his sincere gratitude to BCCI Honorary Secretary Devajit Saikia for his vision and support in conceptualising the North East Rising Cup. He remarked that such initiatives are instrumental in creating a robust pathway for talent identification and development in the Northeast region.

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AWARD WINNERS	
Best Batter of the Tournament: Sayantika Sutradhar (Tripura) – 5 Innings-211 runs	
Best Bowler of the Tournament: Purbha Chowdhury (Tripura) – 4 Innings- 11 wickets	
Player of the Tournament: Purbha Chowdhury (Tripura) -4 Innings- 11 wickets	
Player of the Match (Final): Ankita Chetri (Assam)- 40 runs off 39 balls	

continues to prioritise the growth of women's cricket and is dedicated to building a strong foundation across all regions of the country. He emphasised that initiatives like the North East Rising Cup play a crucial role in offering young cricketers structured opportunities and valuable competitive exposure.

NTPC exploring 2 nuclear power units of 1,400 MW in Bihar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



As part of its energy diversification plan, state-owned NTPC is looking to set up two nuclear units of 700 MW each in the Banka district of Bihar, which could entail an investment of around ₹ 25,000 crore.

At present, NTPC officials are conducting a feasibility study for two 700-MW nuclear units in the district, located around 250 km from Patna, a government official said.

The Bihar government has also assured full support for the project and water availability. Initial estimates suggest that around 1,000 acres of land would be required for these units, the official told PTI without

sharing any financial information.

According to industry estimates, a 1 GW nuclear plant requires an investment of ₹15,000-20,000 crore and typically takes at least three years from concept to commissioning.

A detailed project report (DPR) will be prepared after the feasibility report is completed, he said.

NTPC is looking to set up around 30 GW of company-owned nuclear projects across various locations in

the country in line with the government's ambition of having 100 GW nuclear capacity by 2047.

The power PSU is eyeing at least 2 GW of nuclear capacity as early as 2032.

NTPC is also setting up a nuclear project in a joint venture (JV) with Nuclear Power Corporation of India Ltd (NPCIL) in Rajasthan at an investment of about ₹42,000 crore.

The company, with an installed capacity of over 89,615 MW at the group level, has accelerated its nuclear plans, with recent legislative changes aimed at attracting investment in this space.

NTPC Ltd has steadily expanded and diversified into new energy sources, spanning coal, gas/liquid fuel, hydro and solar power.

DAILY SUDOKU

	2					9	7	1
		1	6					2
4					7			3
	6			3				7
9			2		4			8
1				6			9	
6			3					9
2								
3	9	4					8	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

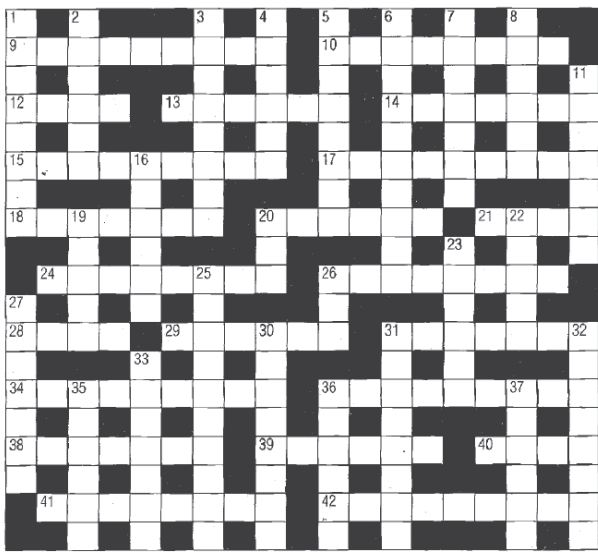
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.



SOLUTION (25.04.26)								
6	3	1	4	5	2	9	8	7
2	8	9	3	1	7	4	6	5
7	5	4	6	8	9	3	1	2
1	4	6	2	7	3	8	5	9
3	7	5	8	9	6	1	2	4
8	9	2	1	4	5	6	7	3
9	1	7	5	3	8	2	4	6
5	6	8	9	2	4	7	3	1
4	2	3	7	6	1	5	9	8

DOUBLE CROSSWORD MONDAY | APRIL 27, 2026



- ACROSS**
- 9 Patient's peevishness that the nurse laughs at? (3,6)
- 10 Rush off with the impetuous young person (8)
- 12 One page in writing follows, from "The Scamps" (4)
- 13 Go off to take a look at the material (6)
- 14 Returning, join in again with the followers (7)
- 15 Workers depressed easily (5,4)
- 17 Your destination when going to the country for a rest? (4,2,3)
- 18 Set to refuse (7)
- 20 Used cosmetics which compensated for? (4,2)

- DOWN**
- 1 Is he to find out it's all over? (8)
- 2 Wearing underwear, quickly don (4,2)
- 3 At fifty one, therefore, by myself and melancholy (8)
- 4 Determine that the hole I darn will be well stitched up (6)
- 5 Afraid from the beginning, was induced to (8)
- 6 OK. That's the right degree of impartiality (4,6)
- 7 Warning of, perhaps, a cut back first (7)
- 8 A shot gun (6)
- 11 Willingly again taking on the daily grind (7)
- 16 Is anything but dull and excels at (6)
- 19 Is bright, that's obvious (5)

- 21 Succumb to the temptation to take a drop (4)
- 24 Shown always to have hinged on a crooked deal (8)
- 26 Obligated to detain, having been caught (8)
- 28 A surprise item on the bill (4)
- 29 "A herb and nut mixture," to start with, is a falsification (6)
- 31 It comes with the delivery (7)
- 34 Anxious while it's still in the balance (9)
- 36 Life will cease in it when the poor old earth is dead (9)
- 38 Crying out for a job (7)
- 39 Knock off the alcove (6)
- 40 Providing she doubles back (4)

- 20 To get mother up would be absurd (3)
- 22 Change people notice, all round (5)
- 23 Maintain, for instance, the woman is making a comeback (6)
- 25 Tall like daddy? (4-6)
- 26 A good worker, the letter said (3)
- 27 Stop with the firm (7)
- 30 Doubly angry with the organisation (3,5)
- 31 Tired of walking round and round in the forest, lost (8)
- 32 Trapping the wild animals, I reckon (8)
- 33 Somebody knocking, but he's out (7)
- 35 The bar room, duck into (6)
- 36 In a cafe working, now, but it's just a front (6)
- 37 No, sir. The pinhead is back in jail! (6)

SOLUTION (25.04.26)		
ACROSS		
4, Ni-MB-le	21, Weathered	16, Nod
7, The-O-dora	23, D-ill	18, Pa-lais
8, Car-bon	24, Even	20, De-NS-e
10, Lance	26, Net	1, W-it
13, A-rt-s	27, AC-RE	22, Eve
14, Ewer	29, Shop	23, Det-ail
15, Fret	32, Lily	25, Cor
16, New	33, P-earl	28, Clove
17, EP-ic	34, Car-U-so	30, H-airy
19, I-dol	35, Victoria	31, P-le-ad
	36, All-ure	32, Lu-Lu
		33, Pate

JEE Mains results declared, new stars emerge under Army initiative in Manipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bishnupur

The air in Bishnupur, Manipur, is currently heavy with a complex mixture of grief and resilience. As of late April 2026, the state is grappling with a renewed wave of instability following tragic events, including a recent strike in the district that claimed young lives and sparked widespread protests and shutdowns. Yet, amidst this atmosphere of "turbulence" and the deep-seated ethnic tensions that have persisted for years, a profound "silver lining" has emerged to illuminate the path forward.

The success of students from the Indian Army's 'Super 50' program serves as a powerful testament to the region's enduring spirit — out of 10 students, 8 have cleared JEE Mains 2026, marking an impressive 80 per cent success rate — proving that even in the face of profound hardship, the youth of Manipur can achieve academic excellence and reclaim their futures.

A Legacy of Discipline and Excellence

The 'Super 50' program remains



a perfect support system for Manipur's youth, particularly those from underprivileged backgrounds and students who require basic support and resources to bridge the gap to higher education.

By offering free residential coaching for competitive exams like JEE and NEET, the program acts as a proverbial 'Guiding Light' for those facing significant financial barriers. The program's unique 'Army Discipline' factor, characterized by supervised study groups and a strictly monitored 6-8 hour daily intensive schedule, continues to be the 'secret recipe' behind these life-changing results.

The New Torch-Bearers of Success

Leading the wave of success this year are P Rohit and

Ningthoujam Rohan Singh, whose performances have set a new benchmark for aspiring students in Manipur.

■ P Rohit emerged as a top performer with an impressive 86.9 percentile, successfully qualifying for the JEE Advanced.

■ Ningthoujam Rohan Singh secured a strong 84.48 percentile, earning his spot to compete in the upcoming JEE Advanced.

"The Army has been providing us with security, but through Super 50, they are providing us with a bright future," remarked a parent during the interaction and a student remarked, "Super 50 has given us not just coaching, but the confidence to dream beyond our circumstances and work towards a better future."

Finance ministry asks PSBs to complete wage revision process in next 12 months

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Finance Ministry has asked public sector banks to initiate the process of negotiations for the 13th Bi-partite settlement in a time-bound manner and finalise it in the next 12 months. The wage revision for employees and officers of public sector banks would be due from November 1, 2027.

Public Sector Banks (PSBs) and financial institutions, including insurance companies, revise wages of their employees every five years. As part of the settlement, the Indian Banks' Association (IBA) is expected to engage in dialogues with the



employees' unions/associations and arrive at a mutually agreeable wage settlement.

As the timely conclusion of the settlements is essential for maintaining industrial harmony, the Department of Financial Services advised PSBs in a communication to their heads to initiate the necessary measures to commence negotiations for the

impending wage revision.

PSBs are advised to complete the negotiation process within a maximum period of 12 months, the communication dated April 20 said. Just before the last settlement process, the finance ministry had asked IBA to ensure that all future wage negotiations should be finalised before the beginning of the subsequent period so that the wage revision could be implemented from the due date itself.

It has been observed that on previous occasions, consequential amendments to the permanent regulations have been effected after a considerable delay following the settlement, it said.

BRIEFLY

Eren Dinkci dedicates goal to girlfriend with leukemia



Germany: Heidenheim goalscorer Eren Dinkci was unable to hold back tears while fans celebrated his team's win as he thought of his girlfriend with leukemia.

"The goal is for her, clearly," the 24-year-old Dinkci said after Heidenheim's 2-0 win over St. Pauli in the Bundesliga on Saturday. "And I hope that it made her happy and the goal also gives her a bit of strength." Dinkci, who's on loan at Heidenheim from Freiburg, announced through both clubs' websites this month that his girlfriend Cinja has leukemia and may need a stem cell donation.

Heidenheim organised a campaign with DKMS, a German-founded international charity helping people with blood cancer and blood disorders, to convince people to register as stem cell donors. Some 688 people registered around the team's game in Freiburg last weekend, and more were expected to do so around the game in Heidenheim on Saturday.

Roma's week of turmoil ends with Malen leading a win at Bologna



Milan: Roma put a turbulent week behind it to win at Bologna 2-0 in Serie A on Saturday and continue its push for the Champions League. The in-form Donyell Malen scored one and set up the other to help Roma close to within two points of fourth-placed Juventus, which visits AC Milan on Sunday. Roma fired special adviser Claudio Ranieri this week after his very public clash with coach Gian Piero Gasperini. However, it put issues off the field to one side and took the lead after less than seven minutes. Malen took one touch to control Neil El Aynaoui's through ball before firing past the onrushing goalkeeper and into the bottom right corner. It was Malen's 12th goal for Roma in 16 matches since joining on loan from Aston Villa in January.

Malen repaid the favor in first-half stoppage time by crossing the ball into the area for El Aynaoui to volley in from close range. Hellas Verona and Pisa can hold on to hopes of Serie A safety for another week.

Last-placed Pisa lost at Parma 1-0 early on Saturday to leave it hoping for a favor from Verona to avoid mathematical relegation. Verona managed a 0-0 draw against Lecce. Those results left Pisa 11 points below 17th-placed Lecce and safety, with four rounds remaining. Verona inched a point above Pisa. At Parma, substitute Nesta Elphege got the only goal eight minutes from time, controlling a header with his back to goal and turning to sweep in from close range.

Swiatek withdraws from Madrid Open after falling ill in match

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Iga Swiatek withdrew from the Madrid Open due to an unspecified illness while playing her round-of-32 match against American Ann Li on Saturday.

Li got the walkover win when the fourth-ranked Swiatek withdrew with Li winning 7-6 (4), 2-6, 3-0.

Swiatek, the 2024 Madrid champion, required a medical timeout while down 2-0 in the deciding set. She returned to the court but called it quits after Li held serve.

The Polish star beat Daria Snigur in straight sets in her second-round opener on



Thursday. Li, who is ranked 34, recorded a second career win over a top-10

Kwizera sets record, Florence wins women's title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

New champions were crowned at the TCS World 10K Bengaluru as Burundi's Rodrigue Kwizera shattered the event record to win the international elite men's race, while Rwanda's Florence Niyonkuru clinched the top honours in the women's event here on Sunday.

Thousands of runners turned up on the streets for the World Athletics Gold Label race.

The 26-year-old Kwizera clocked 27 minutes 31 seconds to better the previous course record of 27:38, set by Kenyan Nicholas Kipkorir in 2022.

This was Kwizera's first title at the World 10K Bengaluru after he missed

the top spot in a photo finish to Kenya's Sebastian Sawe three years ago.

He had then promised to come back to take the title, and he did just that on Sunday with grit and determination.

In the international elite women's section, 25-year-old Florence crossed the finish line in 30:45 to win her maiden title here.

Among the Indians, Sanjivani Jadhav won the women's title, making it three in a row here, while Harmanjot Singh took the men's crown, narrowly missing the Indian event record.

Kwizera, a 10,000m World Championships finalist in Budapest 2023, snatched the lead at the 8th kilometer mark while title contender



Harbert Kibet of Uganda was still on his heels.

But from there, Kwizera never looked back and went on to win the race. It was the

fifth fastest 10K time for Kwizera in his career.

The 20-year-old Kibet, who earlier this year clocked 26:39 in Spain, finished runner-up

in 27:39. Kenya's Gilbert Kipkosgei Kiprotich, running only his second international 10K, finished third in 27:43. Kwizera earned \$34,000,

which includes the event record bonus of \$8,000.

"I am very happy to have won the race. The challenge was the heat. I have been training in Spain and it's much cooler this time of the year there. Today I told myself after 5K, I will push. And then again in the final 1K. Yes, I wanted to go for the event record, so I am glad that I did it," Kwizera said after winning the race.

In the women's elite race, defending champion Sarah Chelangat of Uganda faced a stiff challenge right from the start.

Kenya's 20-year-old Brenda Jepchirchir, who set an early world lead of 29:25 while winning at Valencia this January, was leading in the first quarter of the race.

Nelly Korda slows her torrid pace and settles for 5-shot lead in Chevron Championship

DOUG FERGUSON ■ Houston

Nelly Korda stretched her lead to eight shots Saturday until missing a series of short putts that caused her to settle for a 2-under 70 and a five-shot lead in The Chevron Championship, the largest 54-hole lead of her career.

But the work is not over. Korda looked close to unbeatable for so long with another clinic controlling her irons on the heavily sloped greens of Memorial Park.

And then the gap began to shrink as her contenders did just enough to stay in range.

"I played really solid on the front and then just kind of ... not may have lost concentration, but the wind started picking up and then I just put myself



into great positions (and) didn't kind of execute really well," Korda said. The heat and humidity also took a

toll, and Korda often walked the fairways with an umbrella to shield her from the sun.

Patty Tavatanakit, who went 48 holes without a bogey before making one on the 13th, bounced back with a pair of birdies over the last five holes for a 69 to get within five shots.

It was a remarkable scrambling performance for Tavatanakit, who won this major as a rookie in 2021. She got up-and-down seven times, missing out only on the 13th.

Ruoning Yin of China, a Women's PGA champion and former No. 1 in the world, shot 66 and was six shots behind along with Pauline Roussin-Bouchard of France, who had a 67.

"I just don't really make mistakes and I've been hitting well and putting well," Yin said. (AP)



Disappointed with BWF decision to alter scoring system: Vimal Kumar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Former chief coach Vimal Kumar is "extremely disappointed" with Badminton World Federation's decision to change the scoring system, calling it a dilution of the sport without addressing the game's real challenges.

The Badminton World Federation (BWF) on Saturday approved the adoption of the 3x15 scoring system at its Annual General Meeting in Horsens, Denmark, with the proposal securing the required two-thirds majority.

The new format will come into effect from January 4, 2027, replacing the existing 21-point system.

"Extremely disappointed with the BWF decision to alter the scoring system...and even more concerning is the overwhelming support it has received from the Council members. It's disheartening

to see a sport followed so passionately, especially across Asia, being reshaped for reasons that do not address its real challenges," said Vimal.

"The existing (21-point) format ensured a true level-playing field across playing styles, especially in the premier events — Men's and Women's Singles — which have always embodied the very essence of our sport: skill, resilience, fitness, and mental strength," he added.

He indicated the sport could lose some of its compelling appeal, arguing that the claim it would generate more excitement does not hold in badminton, a sport he said has never lacked excitement.

"By effectively reducing the duration (and in essence removing one game's worth of play — 18 points), BWF risks diluting what made these events so compelling.

Fitzpatrick brothers card record 57, take 4-shot lead at Zurich Classic

BRETT MARTEL ■ Avondale (USA)

Matt Fitzpatrick and his younger brother Alex shot a tournament-record 15-under 57 in better-ball play on Saturday, giving them a four-shot lead heading into the final round of the Zurich Classic.

"Amazing day. Probably not kind of sunk in how well we played today, if I'm honest," Matt Fitzpatrick said. "It was just hole after hole."

The Englishmen were at 30-under 186 through 54 holes - also a record at the PGA Tour's only team event.

Matt Fitzpatrick continued to deliver after arriving as arguably the hottest player in golf with two wins



this spring, including last weekend at Harbour Town. The elder brother, ranked third in the world, highlighted his round with a chip-in birdie on the first hole and a 33 1/2-foot putt for eagle on the par-5 seventh.

His 210-yard approach with a 5-iron on Number 12

settled 4 feet from the hole, setting up a birdie that gave the Fitzpatricks a lead they maintained for the rest of the day. Alex Fitzpatrick, who plays on the European tour, held up his end as he seeks his first PGA Tour title, which would give him an exemption through 2028 on the same tour as his more

accomplished brother.

"He played brilliant golf both last two days. His game has really turned a corner these last few months, and I believe in him to continue that trend," the elder Fitzpatrick said of his younger brother, who won the Indian Open last month. "He's doing all the right things, and obviously it was nice for him to have such a big impact there on the back nine."

Alex Fitzpatrick found the green on the par-4 eighth with a 325-yard tee shot to set up a birdie. He birdied the 16th with a short chip-in and the par-3 17th with an 18-foot putt. Alex reached the par-5 18th green in two to set up his team's eighth birdie of the back nine. (AP)

Messi, Miami settle for another home tie, this time against New England

TIM REYNOLDS ■ Miami

Lionel Messi and Inter Miami are still waiting for their first win in their new home.

German Berterame scored off a rebound in the 76th minute and Inter Miami finished in a 1-1 tie with the New England Revolution on Saturday night, keeping the defending MLS Cup champions winless in three matches at their new Miami stadium.

The Herons are 0-0-3 in the new building — compared with 5-1-1 in MLS road matches this season. Inter Miami is now unbeaten (5-0-4) in its last nine MLS matches following a season-opening loss at LAFC, and unbeaten in its last 11 matches (5-0-6)

across all competitions.

Former MLS MVP Carles Gil scored in the 56th minute for New England, which had lost each of its last four meetings with Inter Miami.

Gil's goal started when Will Sands' long throw-in into the box was settled by Dor Turgeman — who basically just left the ball where the charging Gil could get it. Gil chipped the ball past Inter Miami goalie Dayne St. Clair, opening the scoring.

That goal came just a couple minutes after Inter Miami thought it had struck first, but Tadeo Allende's right-footed blast was waved off by an offside call.

About 20 minutes later, Inter Miami knotted the match. Luis Suarez spun



around and tried a shot from near the goal mouth, the low roller getting saved by New England goalkeeper Matt Turner. The ball deflected off Turner's hand and went right

to Berterame, who scored with ease to make it 1-1.

Until then, it looked like the Revolution would get their first win in the series since June 10, 2023 - a couple

Man City books another FA Cup final and Arsenal goes top of the Premier League

JAMES ROBSON ■ London

Manchester City is back in another FA Cup final. Arsenal is back on top of the Premier League.

City will play in a record fourth straight Cup final after surviving a scare to beat second division Southampton 2-1 at Wembley on Saturday. Nico Gonzalez's 87th-minute winner completed a comeback after going a goal down in the second half.

Victory kept up City's bid for a domestic treble of trophies, having won the English League Cup and being locked in a race with Arsenal for the Premier League title.

No team has made four finals in a row. It's extraordinary and hopefully we can

arrive with a good momentum," City manager Pep Guardiola told the BBC.

Arsenal took advantage of City's semifinal commitments to move three points clear at the top of the standings with a 1-0 win against Newcastle. Eberechi Eze's brilliant first half strike helped Mikel Arteta's team bounce back after defeat to City last week.

"We knew after last week what we have to do, we have to win every game. We can't focus on other people, we can only focus on ourselves," Arsenal midfielder Declan Rice said.

At the bottom of the table, a first league win in 2026 wasn't enough to lift Tottenham out of the relegation zone.

Spurs beat relegated Wolves 1-0 to hand Roberto De Zerbi his first victory as coach. But it remained in the drop zone, two points behind West Ham, which clinched a 2-1 win against Everton through Callum Wilson's stoppage time goal at London Stadium.

Liverpool moved up to fourth on goal difference by beating Crystal Palace 3-1. The defending champion leapfrogged Aston Villa which lost to Fulham 1-0.

Treble chaser

Guardiola is chasing a second treble of English domestic trophies after achieving the feat in 2019. A semifinal against Championship side Southampton was not



expected to trip up his City team.

But when Finn Azaz curled a shot from outside the area into the top corner in the 79th, a famous Cup upset

was on the cards.

Instead, City turned on the style. Jeremy Doku leveled with a deflected shot three minutes later and Gonzalez powered a long-

range effort past Daniel Peretz shortly after.

"It was amazing to score at the end. In this amazing stadium, with this atmosphere, an amazing feeling," Gonzalez told the BBC. "It has been a really important week for us. We are alive in the league and in another final."

Despite being a serial Cup finalist, City's only win during that run was in 2023, having lost in each of the last two seasons.

Back on top

An early goal was just what Arsenal needed to ease the nerves in a crucial title clash against Newcastle. Eze delivered just that when whipping home from outside the box in the ninth.

But it was another tense day for Arsenal fans at Emirates Stadium as the Gunners ground out the win.

Arsenal was three points clear of second-placed City having played a game more. The gap could be six points if Arsenal beats Fulham next Saturday before City plays Everton a week on Monday.

"We've got to this point for a reason," Rice said. "There's always going to be noise, from home fans, away fans, people outside. It's about blocking it out and believing in what we can do and that is just winning football matches."

Defeat for Newcastle was its fifth in a row in all competitions. It has won only three of its last 13 in the league.

Relegation rollercoaster

For a short while everything seemed to be going Tottenham's way.

First, midfielder Joao Paulinha managed to stay outside to slide Spurs into an 82nd-minute lead at Molineux and survive a VAR check.

Moments later, Everton's Kiernan Dewsbury-Hall leveled the score at West Ham — cancelling out Tomas Soucek's opener and temporarily helping Spurs climb out of the relegation zone.

But Wilson's winner for West Ham in the 92nd — after going on as a late substitute — saw the fight for survival take another twist. (AP)

Kolkata Knight Riders beat Lucknow Super Giants in super over

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Kolkata Knight Riders edged Lucknow Super Giants via Super Overs in a battle between two bottom-placed teams in the IPL, here on Sunday.

Chasing a modest 156, LSG suffered a batting collapse and managed to tie the contest and take it to Super Over with No. 9 Mohammed Shami striking a last-ball six against a wayward Kartik Tyagi, who leaked 16 runs in the final over.

But Sunil Narine bowled a stunning Super Over conceding just one run and taking two wickets to give KKR an easy target.

Rinku Singh then finished

the chase with a boundary off first ball from Prince Yadav.

Earlier the KKR were in deep trouble with 93/7 in 15 overs but Rinku smashed a sensational 83 not out from 51 balls including four sixes in a row in the final over to lift them to 155/7.

Cameron Green (34) was the only other batter to reach double-digit scores as KKR suffered a familiar batting meltdown with Mohsin taking his maiden fifer. In reply, LSG continued their dismal show with the bat to succumb to their fifth loss in a row.

Earlier in the game, Lucknow Super Giants pacer Mohsin Khan added another sordid chapter to Kolkata Knight Riders' batting woes, taking five wickets to restrict



the three-time champions to a modest 155 for seven in their IPL match here on Sunday.

Mohsin's 5 for 23, a personal best for the left-arm pacer in this format, tore apart an already struggling KKR batting unit, as he snaffled the cream wickets of Ajinkya Rahane, Tim Seifert, Cameron Green, Rovman Powell and Anukul Roy.

Rinku Singh (83 not out, 51 balls) made a well-paced fifty and punished Mohammed Shami in the 19th over for 6, 4, 4 and the smoked four sixes in a row against spinner Digvesh Rathi as KKR made 43 runs in the last two overs to go past the 150-run mark.

But his fifty remained a lone act, as Mohsin firmly stood in the limelight. His bowling

ethos were rooted in simple tactics - bang the ball into the black soil pitch to gain bounce or use cutters at various pace to keep the batters guessing.

Mohsin, who started the night with a wicket maiden, showed his variety across two dismissals.

He followed Rahane with a fuller ball as the batter tried to go over the covers, but the ball's trajectory forced the KKR skipper to just slice the ball up for a simple catch for Aiden Markram.

The 27-year-old stayed calm when Green, who looked comfortable out there while smashing George Linde for two successive sixes, slammed him for a huge maximum.

Two balls later, Mohsin dug one short, challenging Green

(34) to go for the pull and the Australian all-rounder took the bait. The into-the-body angle worked again as Green could only sky the ball to wicketkeeper Rishabh Pant.

Green's ouster also ended a fifth wicket alliance worth 42 with Rinku Singh.

If the existing turmoil was not enough, KKR had to bear the dejection of seeing Angkrish Raghuvanshi getting dismissed obstructing the field. On the final ball of the fifth over from Prince Yadav, Raghuvanshi nudged one towards mid-on and set off for a single, only to be rejected by Green.

Raghuvanshi put in a dive to save himself but he came in the line of the throw from Shami.

Deepti grabs maiden T20I fifer to carry India to 14-run over SA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Johannesburg

Seasoned Deepti Sharma produced a stirring all-round effort, including her maiden fifer in the shortest format, to inspire India's 14-run win over South Africa in the fourth women's T20I on Saturday.

South Africa had already taken an unassailable 3-0 lead coming into this match, and they appeared all set to extend the run after restricting India to 185 for five.

But Deepti (5/19), who played a big role in taking India past the 180-run mark with a composed unbeaten 36, grabbed key wickets in the middle phase to impede SA's run, and limit them to



171 for nine. South Africa raised the challenge through Sune Luus (40) and Tazmine Brits (30), who added 54 runs for the second wicket.

But once Deepti castled Luus, India were all over the home side like a bad rash. Luus was seriously threatening to go big after skipper

Laura Wolvaardt was earlier bowled by pacer Kranti Goud.

Apart from Luus, off-spinner Deepti also jettisoned Annerie Dercksen, big-hitting Kayla Reyneke, Tumi Sekhu and Ayabonga Khaka to break SA's batting unit.

Earlier, India batters failed to build on their starts against a disciplined set of SA bowlers, posting a slightly below par 185 for five.

After being sent in to bat, India started off on a shaky note, losing Shafali Verma to Eliz Marx while Anushka Sharma, who came in for rested Smriti Mandhana, fell for 23.

India were 47 for two at the end of the Power Play segment, and needed to

move on without losing further damage.

Skipper Harmanpreet Kaur (22) and Jemimah Rodrigues (43) did just that, adding 55 runs for the third wicket in little over six overs.

Rodrigues was impressive, in particular, while smashing spinner Nonku Mlaba for 24 runs in the 11th over through a sequence of runs which read 4, 2, 6, 6, 2, 4.

The two successive sixes straight over the bowler's head were a treat to watch.

But just as India were gaining some momentum, Rodrigues, who was dropped on 18, failed to connect a sweep off off-spinner Reyneke, losing her stumps.

‘Self-belief and bowling changes helped overcome lean patch’

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Johannesburg

India all-rounder Deepti Sharma struck form with an impactful display against South Africa in the fourth T20I, crediting renewed self-belief and subtle adjustments to her bowling for ending a prolonged lean run.

Deepti had endured poor form since the T20I series in Australia in February, managing just one double-digit score in nine matches across formats before her unbeaten 36 and match-winning five-for in India's 14-run win over South Africa on Saturday — a timely return to form that eased selection concerns ahead of the T20 World Cup in England and Wales in June.

Even though the hosts had already sealed the series 3-1 with one game to spare, Deepti, a vital cog in India's maiden ODI World Cup-winning campaign, said unwa-



vering self-belief through a prolonged slump helped her fight her way out of the hole.

"First is, I always keep believing in myself and second is line and length, which line I have to bowl.

And basically today, I was more focused on my offspin ball other than the little faster one," said the spin-bowling all-rounder after her sterling show on Saturday.

She said that approach gave her

confidence, while adding the dew made it tricky for bowlers to judge their pace, but discussions within the bowling group helped them make the right adjustments.

"Yeah, because it was a little dewish over here. So, we just had a conversation with the bowlers as well. Just bowl in the right areas and that will give you results," added Deepti, who had gone wicketless in the previous three T20Is here and managed just two runs, a lean run that had also contributed to India's heavy defeats.

On the batting front, Deepti said she and Richa Ghosh (34 not out) had decided to preserve their wickets and bat deep, a plan that helped India post a competitive 185 for five through an unbroken 65-run stand.

Deepti then capped the effort with a stellar bowling spell as India restricted the Proteas to 171 for nine in the chase.

Mansukh Mandaviya unveils Srinagar Khel Sankalp document

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jammu

Reaffirming India's commitment to host the world's biggest sporting events, such as the Olympics and World Cups, the Sports Minister, Mansukh Mandaviya, on Sunday unveiled the Srinagar Khel Sankalp document at the end of the three-day Chintan Shivir, outlining a collective national vision to strengthen sports culture through "cooperative federalism", with a focus on athlete-centric development and expansion of infrastructure.

"We dream together of hosting the world's biggest tournaments — Olympics and World Cups — to uplift communities and showcase India's unity on the global stage. We, the States and the Union, pledge from this valley and beyond: sports will not be a foot-



note but a rising chapter in India's renaissance.

The document recognised sport as a driver of economic growth and nation-building - boosting tourism, attracting international events, spurring local industry and reinforcing India's ambition to host major global sporting events. It said sports federations,

States and the Centre must work in harmony to make India a sporting nation and ensure sport does not remain a footnote in the country's growth story.

Mandaviya chaired the Chintan Shivir of the Ministers of Youth Affairs and Sports of States and Union Territories of the country. Over 15 state sports ministers,

along with eminent sports personalities such as Adile Sumariwalla, Abhinav Bindra, Pullela Gopichand and Gagan Narang, attended the Chintan Shivir and shared their ideas with the stakeholders.

The document outlined a collective national vision to strengthen the sports culture through cooperative federalism, with a focus on athlete-centric development, expansion of sports infrastructure, talent identification, development of regional sports clusters, and leveraging sports for unity, youth empowerment, health, tourism, and economic growth. It also reaffirms India's aspiration to host major global sporting events.

"To realise this (sporting) ambition, we affirm that Sporting Federations and Associations, States, and the Union shall move

as one, converging on shared targets, speaking in one voice, and advancing together with an athlete-centric approach," the document read.

"With one voice — *Sankalp se Siddhi* (resolution brings success) — we commit ourselves to this journey, confident that together we will build an India where every athlete can soar, and every child is fit and healthy," the document said.

We recognise that India's diversity is not a challenge to be managed but a reservoir to be drawn from, and we shall map and develop infrastructure, identify talent, and build sports clusters rooted in the unique geography, culture, and heritage of every State. *Yogah karmasu kausalam* (excellence in action) guides our steps.

Nothing wrong with Riyan's batting, says Vikram Rathour



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

Skipper Riyan Parag's meagre returns in the first eight IPL games are the least of concerns for Vikram Rathour, with the Rajasthan Royals batting coach confident the Assam batter will come good at some stage in the tournament.

Riyan, a debatable choice for the Rajasthan Royals captaincy despite the presence of India regulars Yashasvi Jaiswal and Dhruv Jurel, has managed just 88 runs in eight games at a dismal strike-rate of 112.82, with a top score of 20.

"There is nothing going wrong with him. He is batting well in the nets. He is

working hard," Rathour, a former India batting coach, told reporters.

Riyan's returns pale beside the heavy lifting done by Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (357 at a strike-rate of 234-plus), Yashasvi Jaiswal (255 at 153) and Dhruv Jurel (232 at 130-plus), the trio carrying much of RR's batting load so far.

So wretched has been Riyan's form that he is even behind Ravindra Jadeja (132) and Donovan Ferreira (130).

On Saturday, Riyan was undone by a yorker from Sunrisers Hyderabad's comeback man Pat Cummins, who bowled one fast onto the base of the stumps, and the Assam man didn't have enough technical finesse to bring the bat down in time.

When not in team, I did not sulk but chose to score runs in domestic cricket: Ishan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Wicketkeeper-batter Ishan Kishan revealed that rather than sulking over his near two-year absence from the Indian team he focused on improving his game in order to be more consistent.

Kishan returned to Team India earlier this year for the T20I series against New Zealand and the T20 World Cup, earning his recall on the back of a superb domestic season in which he cap-

tained Jharkhand to the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy title, scoring 500-plus runs.

"When I wasn't playing and was out of the team, I told myself I can't cry or sulk about it. It's the easiest thing to do for any sportsman. It might earn you the sympathy of a few people, you might even feel good about it, but it won't get you anywhere," Ishan, the Sunrisers Hyderabad player, told JioHotstar.

"The only thing that could have gotten me back into the reckoning was runs. So, I



just wanted to improve my game and score as many runs as I could, even if that meant hitting more sixes

than any other batter."

He added that his time away from the national side made him even more

committed to the game, with that hunger translating into a heavy weight of domestic runs.

"Only consistent run-scoring can bring you back into the team. If 300 runs in a season are not enough, score 400; if not that, score 500. At the end of the day, cricket is our daily bread.

"When you're out of the team, you understand its importance and start respecting every game. You become hungrier, and that was my focus: to become the

best," added Ishan.

Speaking about his mindset at the crucial Number 3 spot, Ishan said years of batting in that position had given him the confidence to pace an innings and bat deep.

Coming in at his usual slot, he underlined that assurance with a blistering 31-ball 74 as Sunrisers Hyderabad chased down an imposing 228 for 6 set by Rajasthan Royals with ease in an IPL match in Jaipur on Saturday.